

A decorative border with intricate floral and scrollwork patterns in a dark green color, framing the central text.

BibInVs MN 09

Samuel1

*Bible Translation:
Interverse MSG/NIV - 9*

God

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Interversed Message/NIV Bible

1 Samuel

1 Samuel 1

MSG

NIV

- 1 There once was a man who lived in Ramathaim. He was descended from the old Zuph family in the Ephraim hills. His name was Elkanah. (He was connected with the Zuphs from Ephraim through his father Jeroham, his grandfather Elihu, and his great-grandfather Tohu.)
- 1 There was a certain man from Ramathaim, a Zuphite from the hill country of Ephraim, whose name was Elkanah son of Jeroham, the son of Elihu, the son of Tohu, the son of Zuph, an Ephraimite.
- 2 He had two wives. The first was Hannah; the second was Peninnah. Peninnah had children; Hannah did not.
- 2 He had two wives; one was called Hannah and the other Peninnah. Peninnah had children, but Hannah had none.
- 3 Every year this man went from his hometown up to Shiloh to worship and offer a sacrifice to GOD-of-the-Angel-Armies. Eli and his two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, served as the priests of GOD there.
- 3 Year after year this man went up from his town to worship and sacrifice to the LORD Almighty at Shiloh, where Hophni and Phinehas, the two sons of Eli, were priests of the LORD.
- 4 When Elkanah sacrificed, he passed helpings from the sacrificial meal around to his wife Peninnah and all her children,
- 4 Whenever the day came for Elkanah to sacrifice, he would give portions of the meat to his wife Peninnah and to all her sons and daughters.
- 5 but he always gave an especially generous helping to Hannah because he loved her so much, and because GOD had not given her children.
- 5 But to Hannah he gave a double portion because he loved her, and the LORD had closed her womb.
- 6 But her rival wife taunted her cruelly, rubbing it in and never letting her forget that GOD had not given her children.

- 6 And because the LORD had closed her womb, her rival kept provoking her in order to irritate her.
- 7 This went on year after year. Every time she went to the sanctuary of GOD she could expect to be taunted. Hannah was reduced to tears and had no appetite.
- 7 This went on year after year. Whenever Hannah went up to the house of the LORD, her rival provoked her till she wept and would not eat.
- 8 Her husband Elkanah said, "Oh, Hannah, why are you crying? Why aren't you eating? And why are you so upset? Am I not of more worth to you than ten sons?"
- 8 Elkanah her husband would say to her, "Hannah, why are you weeping? Why don't you eat? Why are you downhearted? Don't I mean more to you than ten sons?"
- 9 So Hannah ate. Then she pulled herself together, slipped away quietly, and entered the sanctuary. The priest Eli was on duty at the entrance to GOD's Temple in the customary seat.
- 9 Once when they had finished eating and drinking in Shiloh, Hannah stood up. Now Eli the priest was sitting on a chair by the doorpost of the LORD's temple.
- 10 Crushed in soul, Hannah prayed to GOD and cried and cried--inconsolably.
- 10 In bitterness of soul Hannah wept much and prayed to the LORD.
- 11 Then she made a vow: Oh, GOD-of-the-Angel-Armies, If you'll take a good, hard look at my pain, If you'll quit neglecting me and go into action for me By giving me a son, I'll give him completely, unreservedly to you. I'll set him apart for a life of holy discipline.
- 11 And she made a vow, saying, "O LORD Almighty, if you will only look upon your servant's misery and remember me, and not forget your servant but give her a son, then I will give him to the LORD for all the days of his life, and no razor will ever be used on his head."
- 12 It so happened that as she continued in prayer before GOD, Eli was watching her closely.
- 12 As she kept on praying to the LORD, Eli observed her mouth.
- 13 Hannah was praying in her heart, silently. Her lips moved, but no sound was heard. Eli jumped to the conclusion that she was drunk.

13 Hannah was praying in her heart, and her lips were moving but her voice was not heard. Eli thought she was drunk

14 He approached her and said, "You're drunk! How long do you plan to keep this up? Sober up, woman!"

14 and said to her, "How long will you keep on getting drunk? Get rid of your wine."

15 Hannah said, "Oh no, sir--please! I'm a woman hard used. I haven't been drinking. Not a drop of wine or beer. The only thing I've been pouring out is my heart, pouring it out to GOD.

15 Not so, my lord, Hannah replied, "I am a woman who is deeply troubled. I have not been drinking wine or beer; I was pouring out my soul to the LORD.

16 Don't for a minute think I'm a bad woman. It's because I'm so desperately unhappy and in such pain that I've stayed here so long."

16 Do not take your servant for a wicked woman; I have been praying here out of my great anguish and grief."

17 Eli answered her, "Go in peace. And may the God of Israel give you what you have asked of him."

17 Eli answered, "Go in peace, and may the God of Israel grant you what you have asked of him."

18 "Think well of me--and pray for me!" she said, and went her way. Then she ate heartily, her face radiant.

18 She said, "May your servant find favor in your eyes." Then she went her way and ate something, and her face was no longer downcast.

19 Up before dawn, they worshiped GOD and returned home to Ramah. Elkanah slept with Hannah his wife, and GOD began making the necessary arrangements in response to what she had asked.

19 Early the next morning they arose and worshiped before the LORD and then went back to their home at Ramah. Elkanah lay with Hannah his wife, and the LORD remembered her.

20 Before the year was out, Hannah had conceived and given birth to a son. She named him Samuel, explaining, "I asked GOD for him."

20 So in the course of time Hannah conceived and gave birth to a son. She named him Samuel, saying, "Because I asked the LORD for him."

21 When Elkanah next took his family on their annual trip to Shiloh to worship GOD, offering sacrifices and keeping his vow,

21 When the man Elkanah went up with all his family to offer the annual sacrifice to the LORD and to fulfill his vow,

22 Hannah didn't go. She told her husband, "After the child is weaned, I'll bring him myself and present him before GOD--and that's where he'll stay, for good."

22 Hannah did not go. She said to her husband, "After the boy is weaned, I will take him and present him before the LORD, and he will live there always."

23 Elkanah said to his wife, "Do what you think is best. Stay home until you have weaned him. Yes! Let GOD complete what he has begun!" So she did. She stayed home and nursed her son until she had weaned him.

23 Do what seems best to you, Elkanah her husband told her. "Stay here until you have weaned him; only may the LORD make good his word." So the woman stayed at home and nursed her son until she had weaned him.

24 Then she took him up to Shiloh, bringing also the makings of a generous sacrificial meal--a prize bull, flour, and wine. The child was so young to be sent off!

24 After he was weaned, she took the boy with her, young as he was, along with a three-year-old bull, an ephah of flour and a skin of wine, and brought him to the house of the LORD at Shiloh.

25 They first butchered the bull, then brought the child to Eli.

25 When they had slaughtered the bull, they brought the boy to Eli,

26 Hannah said, "Excuse me, sir. Would you believe that I'm the very woman who was standing before you at this very spot, praying to GOD?"

26 and she said to him, "As surely as you live, my lord, I am the woman who stood here beside you praying to the LORD.

27 I prayed for this child, and GOD gave me what I asked for.

27 I prayed for this child, and the LORD has granted me what I asked of him.

28 And now I have dedicated him to GOD. He's dedicated to GOD for life." Then and there, they worshiped GOD.

28 So now I give him to the LORD. For his whole life he will be given over to the LORD." And he worshiped the LORD there.

1 Samuel 2

MSG

NIV

- 1 Hannah prayed: I'm bursting with God-news! I'm walking on air. I'm laughing at my rivals. I'm dancing my salvation.
- 1 Then Hannah prayed and said: "My heart rejoices in the LORD; in the LORD my horn is lifted high. My mouth boasts over my enemies, for I delight in your deliverance.
- 2 Nothing and no one is holy like GOD, no rock mountain like our God.
- 2 There is no one holy like the LORD; there is no one besides you; there is no Rock like our God.
- 3 Don't dare talk pretentiously-- not a word of boasting, ever! For GOD knows what's going on. He takes the measure of everything that happens.
- 3 Do not keep talking so proudly or let your mouth speak such arrogance, for the LORD is a God who knows, and by him deeds are weighed.
- 4 The weapons of the strong are smashed to pieces, while the weak are infused with fresh strength.
- 4 The bows of the warriors are broken, but those who stumbled are armed with strength.
- 5 The well-fed are out begging in the streets for crusts, while the hungry are getting second helpings. The barren woman has a houseful of children, while the mother of many is bereft.
- 5 Those who were full hire themselves out for food, but those who were hungry hunger no more. She who was barren has borne seven children, but she who has had many sons pines away.
- 6 GOD brings death and GOD brings life, brings down to the grave and raises up.
- 6 The LORD brings death and makes alive; he brings down to the grave and raises up.
- 7 GOD brings poverty and GOD brings wealth; he lowers, he also lifts up.
- 7 The LORD sends poverty and wealth; he humbles and he exalts.
- 8 He puts poor people on their feet again; he rekindles burned-out lives with fresh hope, Restoring dignity and respect to their lives-- a place in the sun! For the very structures of earth are GOD's; he has laid out his operations on a firm foundation.

- 8 He raises the poor from the dust and lifts the needy from the ash heap; he seats them with princes and has them inherit a throne of honor. "For the foundations of the earth are the LORD's; upon them he has set the world.
- 9 He protectively cares for his faithful friends, step by step, but leaves the wicked to stumble in the dark. No one makes it in this life by sheer muscle!
- 9 He will guard the feet of his saints, but the wicked will be silenced in darkness. "It is not by strength that one prevails;
- 10 GOD's enemies will be blasted out of the sky, crashed in a heap and burned. GOD will set things right all over the earth, he'll give strength to his king, he'll set his anointed on top of the world!
- 10 those who oppose the LORD will be shattered. He will thunder against them from heaven; the LORD will judge the ends of the earth. "He will give strength to his king and exalt the horn of his anointed."
- 11 Elkanah went home to Ramah. The boy stayed and served GOD in the company of Eli the priest.
- 11 Then Elkanah went home to Ramah, but the boy ministered before the LORD under Eli the priest.
- 12 Eli's own sons were a bad lot. They didn't know GOD and could not have cared less
- 12 Eli's sons were wicked men; they had no regard for the LORD.
- 13 about the customs of priests among the people. Ordinarily, when someone offered a sacrifice, the priest's servant was supposed to come up and, while the meat was boiling,
- 13 Now it was the practice of the priests with the people that whenever anyone offered a sacrifice and while the meat was being boiled, the servant of the priest would come with a three-pronged fork in his hand.
- 14 stab a three-pronged fork into the cooking pot. The priest then got whatever came up on the fork. But this is how Eli's sons treated all the Israelites who came to Shiloh to offer sacrifices to GOD.
- 14 He would plunge it into the pan or kettle or caldron or pot, and the priest would take for himself whatever the fork brought up. This is how they treated all the Israelites who came to Shiloh.
- 15 Before they had even burned the fat to GOD, the priest's servant would interrupt whoever was sacrificing and say, "Hand over some of that meat for the priest to roast. He doesn't like boiled meat; he likes his rare."

- 15 But even before the fat was burned, the servant of the priest would come and say to the man who was sacrificing, "Give the priest some meat to roast; he won't accept boiled meat from you, but only raw."
- 16 If the man objected, "First let the fat be burned--God's portion!--then take all you want," the servant would demand, "No, I want it now. If you won't give it, I'll take it."
- 16 If the man said to him, "Let the fat be burned up first, and then take whatever you want," the servant would then answer, "No, hand it over now; if you don't, I'll take it by force."
- 17 It was a horrible sin these young servants were committing--and right in the presence of GOD!--desecrating the holy offerings to GOD.
- 17 This sin of the young men was very great in the LORD's sight, for they were treating the LORD's offering with contempt.
- 18 In the midst of all this, Samuel, a boy dressed in a priestly linen tunic, served GOD.
- 18 But Samuel was ministering before the LORD--a boy wearing a linen ephod.
- 19 Additionally, every year his mother would make him a little robe cut to his size and bring it to him when she and her husband came for the annual sacrifice.
- 19 Each year his mother made him a little robe and took it to him when she went up with her husband to offer the annual sacrifice.
- 20 Eli would bless Elkanah and his wife, saying, "GOD give you children to replace this child you have dedicated to GOD." Then they would go home.
- 20 Eli would bless Elkanah and his wife, saying, "May the LORD give you children by this woman to take the place of the one she prayed for and gave to the LORD." Then they would go home.
- 21 GOD was most especially kind to Hannah. She had three more sons and two daughters! The boy Samuel stayed at the sanctuary and grew up with GOD.
- 21 And the LORD was gracious to Hannah; she conceived and gave birth to three sons and two daughters. Meanwhile, the boy Samuel grew up in the presence of the LORD.
- 22 By this time Eli was very old. He kept getting reports on how his sons were ripping off the people and sleeping with the women who helped out

at the sanctuary.

22 Now Eli, who was very old, heard about everything his sons were doing to all Israel and how they slept with the women who served at the entrance to the Tent of Meeting.

23 Eli took them to task: "What's going on here? Why are you doing these things? I hear story after story of your corrupt and evil carrying on.

23 So he said to them, "Why do you do such things? I hear from all the people about these wicked deeds of yours.

24 Oh, my sons, this is not right! These are terrible reports I'm getting, stories spreading right and left among GOD's people!

24 No, my sons; it is not a good report that I hear spreading among the LORD's people.

25 If you sin against another person, there's help--God's help. But if you sin against GOD, who is around to help?" But they were far gone in disobedience and refused to listen to a thing their father said. So GOD, who was fed up with them, decreed their death.

25 If a man sins against another man, God may mediate for him; but if a man sins against the LORD, who will intercede for him?" His sons, however, did not listen to their father's rebuke, for it was the LORD's will to put them to death.

26 But the boy Samuel was very much alive, growing up, blessed by GOD and popular with the people.

26 And the boy Samuel continued to grow in stature and in favor with the LORD and with men.

27 A holy man came to Eli and said: "This is GOD's message: I revealed myself openly to your ancestors when they were Pharaoh's slaves in Egypt.

27 Now a man of God came to Eli and said to him, "This is what the LORD says: 'Did I not clearly reveal myself to your father's house when they were in Egypt under Pharaoh?

28 Out of all the tribes of Israel, I chose your family to be my priests: to preside at the altar, to burn incense, to wear the priestly robes in my presence. I put your ancestral family in charge of all the sacrificial offerings of Israel.

28 I chose your father out of all the tribes of Israel to be my priest, to go up to my altar, to burn incense, and to wear an ephod in my presence. I also

- gave your father's house all the offerings made with fire by the Israelites.
- 29 So why do you now treat as mere loot these very sacrificial offerings that I commanded for my worship? Why do you treat your sons better than me, turning them loose to get fat on these offerings, and ignoring me?
- 29 Why do you scorn my sacrifice and offering that I prescribed for my dwelling? Why do you honor your sons more than me by fattening yourselves on the choice parts of every offering made by my people Israel?'
- 30 Therefore--this is GOD's word, the God of Israel speaking--I once said that you and your ancestral family would be my priests indefinitely, but now--GOD's word, remember!--there is no way this can continue. I honor those who honor me; those who scorn me I demean.
- 30 Therefore the LORD, the God of Israel, declares: 'I promised that your house and your father's house would minister before me forever.' But now the LORD declares: 'Far be it from me! Those who honor me I will honor, but those who despise me will be disdained.
- 31 "Be well warned: It won't be long before I wipe out both your family and your future family. No one in your family will make it to old age!
- 31 The time is coming when I will cut short your strength and the strength of your father's house, so that there will not be an old man in your family line
- 32 You'll see good things that I'm doing in Israel, but you'll see it and weep, for no one in your family will live to enjoy it.
- 32 and you will see distress in my dwelling. Although good will be done to Israel, in your family line there will never be an old man.
- 33 I will leave one person to serve at my altar, but it will be a hard life, with many tears. Everyone else in your family will die before their time.
- 33 Every one of you that I do not cut off from my altar will be spared only to blind your eyes with tears and to grieve your heart, and all your descendants will die in the prime of life.
- 34 What happens to your two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, will be the proof: Both will die the same day.
- 34 'And what happens to your two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, will be a sign to you--they will both die on the same day.

- 35 Then I'll establish for myself a true priest. He'll do what I want him to do, be what I want him to be. I'll make his position secure and he'll do his work freely in the service of my anointed one.
- 35 I will raise up for myself a faithful priest, who will do according to what is in my heart and mind. I will firmly establish his house, and he will minister before my anointed one always.
- 36 Survivors from your family will come to him begging for handouts, saying, 'Please, give me some priest work, just enough to put some food on the table.'
- 36 Then everyone left in your family line will come and bow down before him for a piece of silver and a crust of bread and plead, "Appoint me to some priestly office so I can have food to eat." ' ' "

1 Samuel 3

MSG

NIV

- 1 The boy Samuel was serving GOD under Eli's direction. This was at a time when the revelation of GOD was rarely heard or seen.
- 1 The boy Samuel ministered before the LORD under Eli. In those days the word of the LORD was rare; there were not many visions.
- 2 One night Eli was sound asleep (his eyesight was very bad--he could hardly see).
- 2 One night Eli, whose eyes were becoming so weak that he could barely see, was lying down in his usual place.
- 3 It was well before dawn; the sanctuary lamp was still burning. Samuel was still in bed in the Temple of GOD, where the Chest of God rested.
- 3 The lamp of God had not yet gone out, and Samuel was lying down in the temple of the LORD, where the ark of God was.
- 4 Then GOD called out, "Samuel, Samuel!" Samuel answered, "Yes? I'm here."
- 4 Then the LORD called Samuel. Samuel answered, "Here I am."
- 5 Then he ran to Eli saying, "I heard you call. Here I am." Eli said, "I didn't call you. Go back to bed." And so he did.
- 5 And he ran to Eli and said, "Here I am; you called me." But Eli said, "I did not call; go back and lie down." So he went and lay down.

- 6 GOD called again, "Samuel, Samuel!" Samuel got up and went to Eli, "I heard you call. Here I am." Again Eli said, "Son, I didn't call you. Go back to bed."
- 6 Again the LORD called, "Samuel!" And Samuel got up and went to Eli and said, "Here I am; you called me." "My son," Eli said, "I did not call; go back and lie down."
- 7 (This all happened before Samuel knew GOD for himself. It was before the revelation of GOD had been given to him personally.)
- 7 Now Samuel did not yet know the LORD: The word of the LORD had not yet been revealed to him.
- 8 GOD called again, "Samuel!"--the third time! Yet again Samuel got up and went to Eli, "Yes? I heard you call me. Here I am." That's when it dawned on Eli that GOD was calling the boy.
- 8 The LORD called Samuel a third time, and Samuel got up and went to Eli and said, "Here I am; you called me." Then Eli realized that the LORD was calling the boy.
- 9 So Eli directed Samuel, "Go back and lie down. If the voice calls again, say, 'Speak, GOD. I'm your servant, ready to listen.'" Samuel returned to his bed.
- 9 So Eli told Samuel, "Go and lie down, and if he calls you, say, 'Speak, LORD, for your servant is listening.' " So Samuel went and lay down in his place.
- 10 Then GOD came and stood before him exactly as before, calling out, "Samuel! Samuel!" Samuel answered, "Speak. I'm your servant, ready to listen."
- 10 The LORD came and stood there, calling as at the other times, "Samuel! Samuel!" Then Samuel said, "Speak, for your servant is listening."
- 11 GOD said to Samuel, "Listen carefully. I'm getting ready to do something in Israel that is going to shake everyone up and get their attention.
- 11 And the LORD said to Samuel: "See, I am about to do something in Israel that will make the ears of everyone who hears of it tingle.
- 12 The time has come for me to bring down on Eli's family everything I warned him of, every last word of it.
- 12 At that time I will carry out against Eli everything I spoke against his family--from beginning to end.

- 13 I'm letting him know that the time's up. I'm bringing judgment on his family for good. He knew what was going on, that his sons were desecrating God's name and God's place, and he did nothing to stop them.
- 13 For I told him that I would judge his family forever because of the sin he knew about; his sons made themselves contemptible, and he failed to restrain them.
- 14 This is my sentence on the family of Eli: The evil of Eli's family can never be wiped out by sacrifice or offering."
- 14 Therefore, I swore to the house of Eli, 'The guilt of Eli's house will never be atoned for by sacrifice or offering.' "
- 15 Samuel stayed in bed until morning, then rose early and went about his duties, opening the doors of the sanctuary, but he dreaded having to tell the vision to Eli.
- 15 Samuel lay down until morning and then opened the doors of the house of the LORD. He was afraid to tell Eli the vision,
- 16 But then Eli summoned Samuel: "Samuel, my son!" Samuel came running: "Yes? What can I do for you?"
- 16 but Eli called him and said, "Samuel, my son." Samuel answered, "Here I am."
- 17 "What did he say? Tell it to me, all of it. Don't suppress or soften one word, as God is your judge! I want it all, word for word as he said it to you."
- 17 What was it he said to you? Eli asked. "Do not hide it from me. May God deal with you, be it ever so severely, if you hide from me anything he told you."
- 18 So Samuel told him, word for word. He held back nothing. Eli said, "He is GOD. Let him do whatever he thinks best."
- 18 So Samuel told him everything, hiding nothing from him. Then Eli said, "He is the LORD; let him do what is good in his eyes."
- 19 Samuel grew up. GOD was with him, and Samuel's prophetic record was flawless.
- 19 The LORD was with Samuel as he grew up, and he let none of his words fall to the ground.
- 20 Everyone in Israel, from Dan in the north to Beersheba in the south, recognized that Samuel was the real thing--a true prophet of GOD.

- 20 And all Israel from Dan to Beersheba recognized that Samuel was attested as a prophet of the LORD.
- 21 GOD continued to show up at Shiloh, revealed through his word to Samuel at Shiloh.
- 21 The LORD continued to appear at Shiloh, and there he revealed himself to Samuel through his word.

1 Samuel 4

MSG

NIV

- 1 Whatever Samuel said was broadcast all through Israel. Israel went to war against the Philistines. Israel set up camp at Ebenezer, the Philistines at Aphek.
- 1 And Samuel's word came to all Israel. Now the Israelites went out to fight against the Philistines. The Israelites camped at Ebenezer, and the Philistines at Aphek.
- 2 The Philistines marched out to meet Israel, the fighting spread, and Israel was badly beaten--about 4,000 soldiers left dead on the field.
- 2 The Philistines deployed their forces to meet Israel, and as the battle spread, Israel was defeated by the Philistines, who killed about four thousand of them on the battlefield.
- 3 When the troops returned to camp, Israel's elders said, "Why has GOD given us such a beating today by the Philistines? Let's go to Shiloh and get the Chest of GOD's Covenant. It will accompany us and save us from the grip of our enemies."
- 3 When the soldiers returned to camp, the elders of Israel asked, "Why did the LORD bring defeat upon us today before the Philistines? Let us bring the ark of the LORD's covenant from Shiloh, so that it may go with us and save us from the hand of our enemies."
- 4 So the army sent orders to Shiloh. They brought the Chest of the Covenant of GOD, the GOD-of-the-Angel-Armies, the Cherubim-Enthroned-GOD. Eli's two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, accompanied the Chest of the Covenant of God.
- 4 So the people sent men to Shiloh, and they brought back the ark of the covenant of the LORD Almighty, who is enthroned between the

cherubim. And Eli's two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, were there with the ark of the covenant of God.

- 5 When the Chest of the Covenant of GOD was brought into camp, everyone gave a huge cheer. The shouts were like thunderclaps shaking the very ground.
- 5 When the ark of the LORD's covenant came into the camp, all Israel raised such a great shout that the ground shook.
- 6 The Philistines heard the shouting and wondered what on earth was going on: "What's all this shouting among the Hebrews?" Then they learned that the Chest of GOD had entered the Hebrew camp.
- 6 Hearing the uproar, the Philistines asked, "What's all this shouting in the Hebrew camp?" When they learned that the ark of the LORD had come into the camp,
- 7 The Philistines panicked: "Their gods have come to their camp! Nothing like this has ever happened before.
- 7 the Philistines were afraid. "A god has come into the camp," they said. "We're in trouble! Nothing like this has happened before.
- 8 We're done for! Who can save us from the clutches of these supergods? These are the same gods who hit the Egyptians with all kinds of plagues out in the wilderness.
- 8 Woe to us! Who will deliver us from the hand of these mighty gods? They are the gods who struck the Egyptians with all kinds of plagues in the desert.
- 9 On your feet, Philistines! Courage! We're about to become slaves to the Hebrews, just as they have been slaves to us. Show what you're made of! Fight for your lives!"
- 9 Be strong, Philistines! Be men, or you will be subject to the Hebrews, as they have been to you. Be men, and fight!"
- 10 And did they ever fight! It turned into a rout. They thrashed Israel so mercilessly that the Israelite soldiers ran for their lives, leaving behind an incredible 30,000 dead.
- 10 So the Philistines fought, and the Israelites were defeated and every man fled to his tent. The slaughter was very great; Israel lost thirty thousand foot soldiers.
- 11 As if that wasn't bad enough, the Chest of God was taken and the two sons of Eli--Hophni and Phinehas--were killed.

- 11 The ark of God was captured, and Eli's two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, died.
- 12 Immediately, a Benjaminite raced from the front lines back to Shiloh. Shirt torn and face smeared with dirt,
- 12 That same day a Benjamite ran from the battle line and went to Shiloh, his clothes torn and dust on his head.
- 13 he entered the town. Eli was sitting on his stool beside the road keeping vigil, for he was extremely worried about the Chest of God. When the man ran straight into town to tell the bad news, everyone wept.
- 13 When he arrived, there was Eli sitting on his chair by the side of the road, watching, because his heart feared for the ark of God. When the man entered the town and told what had happened, the whole town sent up a cry.
- 14 They were appalled. Eli heard the loud wailing and asked, "Why this uproar?" The messenger hurried over and reported.
- 14 Eli heard the outcry and asked, "What is the meaning of this uproar?" The man hurried over to Eli,
- 15 Eli was ninety-eight years old then, and blind.
- 15 who was ninety-eight years old and whose eyes were set so that he could not see.
- 16 The man said to Eli, "I've just come from the front, barely escaping with my life." "And so, my son," said Eli, "what happened?"
- 16 He told Eli, "I have just come from the battle line; I fled from it this very day." Eli asked, "What happened, my son?"
- 17 The messenger answered, "Israel scattered before the Philistines. The defeat was catastrophic, with enormous losses. Your sons Hophni and Phinehas died, and the Chest of God was taken."
- 17 The man who brought the news replied, "Israel fled before the Philistines, and the army has suffered heavy losses. Also your two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, are dead, and the ark of God has been captured."
- 18 At the words, "Chest of God," Eli fell backwards off his stool where he sat next to the gate. Eli was an old man, and very fat. When he fell, he broke his neck and died. He had led Israel forty years.
- 18 When he mentioned the ark of God, Eli fell backward off his chair by the side of the gate. His neck was broken and he died, for he was an old man and heavy. He had led Israel forty years.

- 19 His daughter-in-law, the wife of Phinehas, was pregnant and ready to deliver. When she heard that the Chest of God had been taken and that both her father-in-law and her husband were dead, she went to her knees to give birth, going into hard labor.
- 19 His daughter-in-law, the wife of Phinehas, was pregnant and near the time of delivery. When she heard the news that the ark of God had been captured and that her father-in-law and her husband were dead, she went into labor and gave birth, but was overcome by her labor pains.
- 20 As she was about to die, her midwife said, "Don't be afraid. You've given birth to a son!" But she gave no sign that she had heard.
- 20 As she was dying, the women attending her said, "Don't despair; you have given birth to a son." But she did not respond or pay any attention.
- 21 The Chest of God gone, father-in-law dead, husband dead, she named the boy Ichabod (Glory's-Gone),
- 21 She named the boy Ichabod, saying, "The glory has departed from Israel"--because of the capture of the ark of God and the deaths of her father-in-law and her husband.
- 22 saying, "Glory is exiled from Israel since the Chest of God was taken."
- 22 She said, "The glory has departed from Israel, for the ark of God has been captured."

1 Samuel 5

MSG

NIV

- 1 Once the Philistines had seized the Chest of God, they took it from Ebenezer to Ashdod,
- 1 After the Philistines had captured the ark of God, they took it from Ebenezer to Ashdod.
- 2 brought it into the shrine of Dagon, and placed it alongside the idol of Dagon.
- 2 Then they carried the ark into Dagon's temple and set it beside Dagon.
- 3 Next morning when the citizens of Ashdod got up, they were shocked to find Dagon toppled from his place, flat on his face before the Chest of GOD. They picked him up and put him back where he belonged.

- 3 When the people of Ashdod rose early the next day, there was Dagon, fallen on his face on the ground before the ark of the LORD! They took Dagon and put him back in his place.
- 4 First thing the next morning they found him again, toppled and flat on his face before the Chest of GOD. Dagon's head and arms were broken off, strewn across the entrance. Only his torso was in one piece.
- 4 But the following morning when they rose, there was Dagon, fallen on his face on the ground before the ark of the LORD! His head and hands had been broken off and were lying on the threshold; only his body remained.
- 5 (That's why even today, the priests of Dagon and visitors to the Dagon shrine in Ashdod avoid stepping on the threshold.)
- 5 That is why to this day neither the priests of Dagon nor any others who enter Dagon's temple at Ashdod step on the threshold.
- 6 GOD was hard on the citizens of Ashdod. He devastated them by hitting them with tumors. This happened in both the town and the surrounding neighborhoods. He let loose rats among them. Jumping from ships there, rats swarmed all over the city! And everyone was deathly afraid.
- 6 The LORD's hand was heavy upon the people of Ashdod and its vicinity; he brought devastation upon them and afflicted them with tumors.
- 7 When the leaders of Ashdod saw what was going on, they decided, "The chest of the god of Israel has got to go. We can't handle this, and neither can our god Dagon."
- 7 When the men of Ashdod saw what was happening, they said, "The ark of the god of Israel must not stay here with us, because his hand is heavy upon us and upon Dagon our god."
- 8 They called together all the Philistine leaders and put it to them: "How can we get rid of the chest of the god of Israel?" The leaders agreed: "Move it to Gath." So they moved the Chest of the God of Israel to Gath.
- 8 So they called together all the rulers of the Philistines and asked them, "What shall we do with the ark of the god of Israel?" They answered, "Have the ark of the god of Israel moved to Gath." So they moved the ark of the God of Israel.
- 9 But as soon as they moved it there, GOD came down hard on that city, too. It was mass hysteria! He hit them with tumors. Tumors broke out on everyone in town, young and old.

- 9 But after they had moved it, the LORD's hand was against that city, throwing it into a great panic. He afflicted the people of the city, both young and old, with an outbreak of tumors.
- 10 So they sent the Chest of God on to Ekron, but as the Chest was being brought into town, the people shouted in protest, "You'll kill us all by bringing in this Chest of the God of Israel!"
- 10 So they sent the ark of God to Ekron. As the ark of God was entering Ekron, the people of Ekron cried out, "They have brought the ark of the god of Israel around to us to kill us and our people."
- 11 They called the Philistine leaders together and demanded, "Get it out of here, this Chest of the God of Israel. Send it back where it came from. We're threatened with mass death!" For everyone was scared to death when the Chest of God showed up. God was already coming down very hard on the place.
- 11 So they called together all the rulers of the Philistines and said, "Send the ark of the god of Israel away; let it go back to its own place, or it will kill us and our people." For death had filled the city with panic; God's hand was very heavy upon it.
- 12 Those who didn't die were hit with tumors. All over the city cries of pain and lament filled the air.
- 12 Those who did not die were afflicted with tumors, and the outcry of the city went up to heaven.

1 Samuel 6

MSG

NIV

- 1 After the Chest of GOD had been among the Philistine people for seven months,
- 1 When the ark of the LORD had been in Philistine territory seven months,
- 2 the Philistine leaders called together their religious professionals, the priests, and experts on the supernatural for consultation: "How can we get rid of this Chest of GOD, get it off our hands without making things worse? Tell us!"
- 2 the Philistines called for the priests and the diviners and said, "What shall we do with the ark of the LORD? Tell us how we should send it back to

its place."

- 3 They said, "If you're going to send the Chest of the God of Israel back, don't just dump it on them. Pay compensation. Then you will be healed. After you're in the clear again, God will let up on you. Why wouldn't he?"
- 3 They answered, "If you return the ark of the god of Israel, do not send it away empty, but by all means send a guilt offering to him. Then you will be healed, and you will know why his hand has not been lifted from you."
- 4 "And what exactly would make for adequate compensation?" "Five gold tumors and five gold rats," they said, "to match the number of Philistine leaders. Since all of you--leaders and people--suffered the same plague,
- 4 The Philistines asked, "What guilt offering should we send to him?" They replied, "Five gold tumors and five gold rats, according to the number of the Philistine rulers, because the same plague has struck both you and your rulers.
- 5 make replicas of the tumors and rats that are devastating the country and present them as an offering to the glory of the God of Israel. Then maybe he'll ease up and not be so hard on you and your gods, and on your country.
- 5 Make models of the tumors and of the rats that are destroying the country, and pay honor to Israel's god. Perhaps he will lift his hand from you and your gods and your land.
- 6 Why be stubborn like the Egyptians and Pharaoh? God didn't quit pounding on them until they let the people go. Only then did he let up.
- 6 Why do you harden your hearts as the Egyptians and Pharaoh did? When he treated them harshly, did they not send the Israelites out so they could go on their way?
- 7 "So here's what you do: Take a brand-new oxcart and two cows that have never been in harness. Hitch the cows to the oxcart and send their calves back to the barn.
- 7 Now then, get a new cart ready, with two cows that have calved and have never been yoked. Hitch the cows to the cart, but take their calves away and pen them up.
- 8 Put the Chest of GOD on the cart. Secure the gold replicas of the tumors and rats that you are offering as compensation in a sack and set them

next to the Chest. Then send it off.

- 8 Take the ark of the LORD and put it on the cart, and in a chest beside it put the gold objects you are sending back to him as a guilt offering. Send it on its way,
- 9 But keep your eyes on it. If it heads straight back home to where it came from, toward Beth Shemesh, it is clear that this catastrophe is a divine judgment, but if not, we'll know that God had nothing to do with it--it was just an accident."
- 9 but keep watching it. If it goes up to its own territory, toward Beth Shemesh, then the LORD has brought this great disaster on us. But if it does not, then we will know that it was not his hand that struck us and that it happened to us by chance."
- 10 So that's what they did: They hitched two cows to the cart, put their calves in the barn,
- 10 So they did this. They took two such cows and hitched them to the cart and penned up their calves.
- 11 and placed the Chest of GOD and the sack of gold rats and tumors on the cart.
- 11 They placed the ark of the LORD on the cart and along with it the chest containing the gold rats and the models of the tumors.
- 12 The cows headed straight for home, down the road to Beth Shemesh, straying neither right nor left, mooing all the way. The Philistine leaders followed them to the outskirts of Beth Shemesh.
- 12 Then the cows went straight up toward Beth Shemesh, keeping on the road and lowing all the way; they did not turn to the right or to the left. The rulers of the Philistines followed them as far as the border of Beth Shemesh.
- 13 The people of Beth Shemesh were harvesting wheat in the valley. They looked up and saw the Chest. Jubilant, they ran to meet it.
- 13 Now the people of Beth Shemesh were harvesting their wheat in the valley, and when they looked up and saw the ark, they rejoiced at the sight.
- 14 The cart came into the field of Joshua, a Beth Shemeshite, and stopped there beside a huge boulder. The harvesters tore the cart to pieces, then chopped up the wood and sacrificed the cows as a burnt offering to GOD.

- 14 The cart came to the field of Joshua of Beth Shemesh, and there it stopped beside a large rock. The people chopped up the wood of the cart and sacrificed the cows as a burnt offering to the LORD.
- 15 The Levites took charge of the Chest of GOD and the sack containing the gold offerings, placing them on the boulder. Offering the sacrifices, everyone in Beth Shemesh worshiped GOD most heartily that day.
- 15 The Levites took down the ark of the LORD, together with the chest containing the gold objects, and placed them on the large rock. On that day the people of Beth Shemesh offered burnt offerings and made sacrifices to the LORD.
- 16 When the five Philistine leaders saw what they came to see, they returned the same day to Ekron.
- 16 The five rulers of the Philistines saw all this and then returned that same day to Ekron.
- 17 The five gold replicas of the tumors were offered by the Philistines in compensation for the cities of Ashdod, Gaza, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron.
- 17 These are the gold tumors the Philistines sent as a guilt offering to the LORD--one each for Ashdod, Gaza, Ashkelon, Gath and Ekron.
- 18 The five gold rats matched the number of Philistine towns, both large and small, ruled by the five leaders. The big boulder on which they placed the Chest of GOD is still there in the field of Joshua of Beth Shemesh, a landmark.
- 18 And the number of the gold rats was according to the number of Philistine towns belonging to the five rulers--the fortified towns with their country villages. The large rock, on which they set the ark of the LORD, is a witness to this day in the field of Joshua of Beth Shemesh.
- 19 God struck some of the men of Beth Shemesh who, out of curiosity, irreverently peeked into the Chest of GOD. Seventy died. The whole town was in mourning, reeling under the hard blow from GOD,
- 19 But God struck down some of the men of Beth Shemesh, putting seventy of them to death because they had looked into the ark of the LORD. The people mourned because of the heavy blow the LORD had dealt them,
- 20 and questioning, "Who can stand before GOD, this holy God? And who can we get to take this Chest off our hands?"

- 20 and the men of Beth Shemesh asked, "Who can stand in the presence of the LORD, this holy God? To whom will the ark go up from here?"
- 21 They sent emissaries to Kiriath Jearim, saying, "The Philistines have returned the Chest of GOD. Come down and get it."
- 21 Then they sent messengers to the people of Kiriath Jearim, saying, "The Philistines have returned the ark of the LORD. Come down and take it up to your place."

1 Samuel 7

MSG

NIV

- 1 And they did. The men of Kiriath Jearim came and got the Chest of GOD and delivered it to the house of Abinadab on the hill. They ordained his son, Eleazar, to take responsibility for the Chest of GOD.
- 1 So the men of Kiriath Jearim came and took up the ark of the LORD. They took it to Abinadab's house on the hill and consecrated Eleazar his son to guard the ark of the LORD.
- 2 From the time that the Chest came to rest in Kiriath Jearim, a long time passed--twenty years it was--and throughout Israel there was a widespread, fearful movement toward GOD.
- 2 It was a long time, twenty years in all, that the ark remained at Kiriath Jearim, and all the people of Israel mourned and sought after the LORD.
- 3 Then Samuel addressed the house of Israel: "If you are truly serious about coming back to GOD, clean house. Get rid of the foreign gods and fertility goddesses, ground yourselves firmly in GOD, worship him and him alone, and he'll save you from Philistine oppression."
- 3 And Samuel said to the whole house of Israel, "If you are returning to the LORD with all your hearts, then rid yourselves of the foreign gods and the Ashtoreths and commit yourselves to the LORD and serve him only, and he will deliver you out of the hand of the Philistines."
- 4 They did it. They got rid of the gods and goddesses, the images of Baal and Ashtoreth, and gave their exclusive attention and service to GOD.
- 4 So the Israelites put away their Baals and Ashtoreths, and served the LORD only.

- 5 Next Samuel said, "Get everybody together at Mizpah and I'll pray for you."
- 5 Then Samuel said, "Assemble all Israel at Mizpah and I will intercede with the LORD for you."
- 6 So everyone assembled at Mizpah. They drew water from the wells and poured it out before GOD in a ritual of cleansing. They fasted all day and prayed, "We have sinned against GOD." So Samuel prepared the Israelites for holy war there at Mizpah.
- 6 When they had assembled at Mizpah, they drew water and poured it out before the LORD. On that day they fasted and there they confessed, "We have sinned against the LORD." And Samuel was leader of Israel at Mizpah.
- 7 When the Philistines heard that Israel was meeting at Mizpah, the Philistine leaders went on the offensive. Israel got the report and became frightened--Philistines on the move again!
- 7 When the Philistines heard that Israel had assembled at Mizpah, the rulers of the Philistines came up to attack them. And when the Israelites heard of it, they were afraid because of the Philistines.
- 8 They pleaded with Samuel, "Pray with all your might! And don't let up! Pray to GOD, our God, that he'll save us from the boot of the Philistines."
- 8 They said to Samuel, "Do not stop crying out to the LORD our God for us, that he may rescue us from the hand of the Philistines."
- 9 Samuel took a young lamb not yet weaned and offered it whole as a Whole-Burnt-Offering to GOD. He prayed fervently to GOD, interceding for Israel. And GOD answered.
- 9 Then Samuel took a suckling lamb and offered it up as a whole burnt offering to the LORD. He cried out to the LORD on Israel's behalf, and the LORD answered him.
- 10 While Samuel was offering the sacrifice, the Philistines came within range to fight Israel. Just then GOD thundered, a huge thunderclap exploding among the Philistines. They panicked--mass confusion!--and ran helter-skelter from Israel.
- 10 While Samuel was sacrificing the burnt offering, the Philistines drew near to engage Israel in battle. But that day the LORD thundered with

loud thunder against the Philistines and threw them into such a panic that they were routed before the Israelites.

11 Israel poured out of Mizpah and gave chase, killing Philistines right and left, to a point just beyond Beth Car.

11 The men of Israel rushed out of Mizpah and pursued the Philistines, slaughtering them along the way to a point below Beth Car.

12 Samuel took a single rock and set it upright between Mizpah and Shen. He named it "Ebenezer" (Rock of Help), saying, "This marks the place where GOD helped us."

12 Then Samuel took a stone and set it up between Mizpah and Shen. He named it Ebenezer, saying, "Thus far has the LORD helped us."

13 The Philistines learned their lesson and stayed home--no more border crossings. GOD was hard on the Philistines all through Samuel's lifetime.

13 So the Philistines were subdued and did not invade Israelite territory again. Throughout Samuel's lifetime, the hand of the LORD was against the Philistines.

14 All the cities from Ekron to Gath that the Philistines had taken from Israel were restored. Israel also freed the surrounding countryside from Philistine control. And there was peace between Israel and the Amorites.

14 The towns from Ekron to Gath that the Philistines had captured from Israel were restored to her, and Israel delivered the neighboring territory from the power of the Philistines. And there was peace between Israel and the Amorites.

15 Samuel gave solid leadership to Israel his entire life.

15 Samuel continued as judge over Israel all the days of his life.

16 Every year he went on a circuit from Bethel to Gilgal to Mizpah. He gave leadership to Israel in each of these places.

16 From year to year he went on a circuit from Bethel to Gilgal to Mizpah, judging Israel in all those places.

17 But always he would return to Ramah, where he lived, and preside from there. That is where he built an altar to GOD.

17 But he always went back to Ramah, where his home was, and there he also judged Israel. And he built an altar there to the LORD.

1 Samuel 8

MSG

NIV

- 1 When Samuel got to be an old man, he set his sons up as judges in Israel.
- 1 When Samuel grew old, he appointed his sons as judges for Israel.
- 2 His firstborn son was named Joel, the name of his second, Abijah. They were assigned duty in Beersheba.
- 2 The name of his firstborn was Joel and the name of his second was Abijah, and they served at Beersheba.
- 3 But his sons didn't take after him; they were out for what they could get for themselves, taking bribes, corrupting justice.
- 3 But his sons did not walk in his ways. They turned aside after dishonest gain and accepted bribes and perverted justice.
- 4 Fed up, all the elders of Israel got together and confronted Samuel at Ramah.
- 4 So all the elders of Israel gathered together and came to Samuel at Ramah.
- 5 They presented their case: "Look, you're an old man, and your sons aren't following in your footsteps. Here's what we want you to do: Appoint a king to rule us, just like everybody else."
- 5 They said to him, "You are old, and your sons do not walk in your ways; now appoint a king to lead us, such as all the other nations have."
- 6 When Samuel heard their demand--"Give us a king to rule us!"--he was crushed. How awful! Samuel prayed to GOD.
- 6 But when they said, "Give us a king to lead us," this displeased Samuel; so he prayed to the LORD.
- 7 GOD answered Samuel, "Go ahead and do what they're asking. They are not rejecting you. They've rejected me as their King.
- 7 And the LORD told him: "Listen to all that the people are saying to you; it is not you they have rejected, but they have rejected me as their king.
- 8 From the day I brought them out of Egypt until this very day they've been behaving like this, leaving me for other gods. And now they're doing it to you.
- 8 As they have done from the day I brought them up out of Egypt until this day, forsaking me and serving other gods, so they are doing to you.

- 9 So let them have their own way. But warn them of what they're in for. Tell them the way kings operate, just what they're likely to get from a king."
- 9 Now listen to them; but warn them solemnly and let them know what the king who will reign over them will do."
- 10 So Samuel told them, delivered GOD's warning to the people who were asking him to give them a king.
- 10 Samuel told all the words of the LORD to the people who were asking him for a king.
- 11 He said, "This is the way the kind of king you're talking about operates. He'll take your sons and make soldiers of them--chariotry, cavalry, infantry,
- 11 He said, "This is what the king who will reign over you will do: He will take your sons and make them serve with his chariots and horses, and they will run in front of his chariots.
- 12 regimented in battalions and squadrons. He'll put some to forced labor on his farms, plowing and harvesting, and others to making either weapons of war or chariots in which he can ride in luxury.
- 12 Some he will assign to be commanders of thousands and commanders of fifties, and others to plow his ground and reap his harvest, and still others to make weapons of war and equipment for his chariots.
- 13 He'll put your daughters to work as beauticians and waitresses and cooks.
- 13 He will take your daughters to be perfumers and cooks and bakers.
- 14 He'll conscript your best fields, vineyards, and orchards and hand them over to his special friends.
- 14 He will take the best of your fields and vineyards and olive groves and give them to his attendants.
- 15 He'll tax your harvests and vintage to support his extensive bureaucracy.
- 15 He will take a tenth of your grain and of your vintage and give it to his officials and attendants.
- 16 Your prize workers and best animals he'll take for his own use.
- 16 Your menservants and maidservants and the best of your cattle and donkeys he will take for his own use.
- 17 He'll lay a tax on your flocks and you'll end up no better than slaves.

- 17 He will take a tenth of your flocks, and you yourselves will become his slaves.
- 18 The day will come when you will cry in desperation because of this king you so much want for yourselves. But don't expect GOD to answer."
- 18 When that day comes, you will cry out for relief from the king you have chosen, and the LORD will not answer you in that day."
- 19 But the people wouldn't listen to Samuel. "No!" they said. "We will have a king to rule us!
- 19 But the people refused to listen to Samuel. "No!" they said. "We want a king over us.
- 20 Then we'll be just like all the other nations. Our king will rule us and lead us and fight our battles."
- 20 Then we will be like all the other nations, with a king to lead us and to go out before us and fight our battles."
- 21 Samuel took in what they said and rehearsed it with GOD.
- 21 When Samuel heard all that the people said, he repeated it before the LORD.
- 22 GOD told Samuel, "Do what they say. Make them a king." Then Samuel dismissed the men of Israel: "Go home, each of you to your own city."
- 22 The LORD answered, "Listen to them and give them a king." Then Samuel said to the men of Israel, "Everyone go back to his town."

1 Samuel 9

MSG

NIV

- 1 There was a man from the tribe of Benjamin named Kish. He was the son of Abiel, grandson of Zeror, great-grandson of Becorath, great-great-grandson of Aphiah--a Benjaminite of stalwart character.
- 1 There was a Benjamite, a man of standing, whose name was Kish son of Abiel, the son of Zeror, the son of Becorath, the son of Aphiah of Benjamin.
- 2 He had a son, Saul, a most handsome young man. There was none finer--he literally stood head and shoulders above the crowd!

- 2 He had a son named Saul, an impressive young man without equal among the Israelites--a head taller than any of the others.
- 3 Some of Kish's donkeys got lost. Kish said to his son, "Saul, take one of the servants with you and go look for the donkeys."
- 3 Now the donkeys belonging to Saul's father Kish were lost, and Kish said to his son Saul, "Take one of the servants with you and go and look for the donkeys."
- 4 Saul took one of the servants and went to find the donkeys. They went into the hill country of Ephraim around Shalisha, but didn't find them. Then they went over to Shaalim--no luck. Then to Jabin, and still nothing.
- 4 So he passed through the hill country of Ephraim and through the area around Shalisha, but they did not find them. They went on into the district of Shaalim, but the donkeys were not there. Then he passed through the territory of Benjamin, but they did not find them.
- 5 When they got to Zuph, Saul said to the young man with him, "Enough of this. Let's go back. Soon my father is going to forget about the donkeys and start worrying about us."
- 5 When they reached the district of Zuph, Saul said to the servant who was with him, "Come, let's go back, or my father will stop thinking about the donkeys and start worrying about us."
- 6 He replied, "Not so fast. There's a holy man in this town. He carries a lot of weight around here. What he says is always right on the mark. Maybe he can tell us where to go."
- 6 But the servant replied, "Look, in this town there is a man of God; he is highly respected, and everything he says comes true. Let's go there now. Perhaps he will tell us what way to take."
- 7 Saul said, "If we go, what do we have to give him? There's no more bread in our sacks. We've nothing to bring as a gift to the holy man. Do we have anything else?"
- 7 Saul said to his servant, "If we go, what can we give the man? The food in our sacks is gone. We have no gift to take to the man of God. What do we have?"
- 8 The servant spoke up, "Look, I just happen to have this silver coin! I'll give it to the holy man and he'll tell us how to proceed!"

- 8 The servant answered him again. "Look," he said, "I have a quarter of a shekel of silver. I will give it to the man of God so that he will tell us what way to take."
- 9 (In former times in Israel, a person who wanted to seek God's word on a matter would say, "Let's visit the Seer," because the one we now call "the Prophet" used to be called "the Seer.")
- 9 (Formerly in Israel, if a man went to inquire of God, he would say, "Come, let us go to the seer," because the prophet of today used to be called a seer.)
- 10 "Good," said Saul, "let's go." And they set off for the town where the holy man lived.
- 10 Good, Saul said to his servant. "Come, let's go." So they set out for the town where the man of God was.
- 11 As they were climbing up the hill into the town, they met some girls who were coming out to draw water. They said to them, "Is this where the Seer lives?"
- 11 As they were going up the hill to the town, they met some girls coming out to draw water, and they asked them, "Is the seer here?"
- 12 They answered, "It sure is--just ahead. Hurry up. He's come today because the people have prepared a sacrifice at the shrine.
- 12 He is, they answered. "He's ahead of you. Hurry now; he has just come to our town today, for the people have a sacrifice at the high place.
- 13 As soon as you enter the town, you can catch him before he goes up to the shrine to eat. The people won't eat until he arrives, for he has to bless the sacrifice. Only then can everyone eat. So get going. You're sure to find him!"
- 13 As soon as you enter the town, you will find him before he goes up to the high place to eat. The people will not begin eating until he comes, because he must bless the sacrifice; afterward, those who are invited will eat. Go up now; you should find him about this time."
- 14 They continued their climb and entered the city. And then there he was--Samuel!--coming straight toward them on his way to the shrine!
- 14 They went up to the town, and as they were entering it, there was Samuel, coming toward them on his way up to the high place.
- 15 The very day before, GOD had confided in Samuel,
- 15 Now the day before Saul came, the LORD had revealed this to Samuel:

- 16 "This time tomorrow, I'm sending a man from the land of Benjamin to meet you. You're to anoint him as prince over my people Israel. He will free my people from Philistine oppression. Yes, I know all about their hard circumstances. I've heard their cries for help."
- 16 About this time tomorrow I will send you a man from the land of Benjamin. Anoint him leader over my people Israel; he will deliver my people from the hand of the Philistines. I have looked upon my people, for their cry has reached me.
- 17 The moment Samuel laid eyes on Saul, GOD said, "He's the one, the man I told you about. This is the one who will keep my people in check."
- 17 When Samuel caught sight of Saul, the LORD said to him, "This is the man I spoke to you about; he will govern my people."
- 18 Saul came up to Samuel in the street and said, "Pardon me, but can you tell me where the Seer lives?"
- 18 Saul approached Samuel in the gateway and asked, "Would you please tell me where the seer's house is?"
- 19 "I'm the Seer," said Samuel. "Accompany me to the shrine and eat with me. In the morning I'll tell you all about what's on your mind, and send you on your way."
- 19 I am the seer, Samuel replied. "Go up ahead of me to the high place, for today you are to eat with me, and in the morning I will let you go and will tell you all that is in your heart."
- 20 And by the way, your lost donkeys--the ones you've been hunting for the last three days--have been found, so don't worry about them. At this moment, Israel's future is in your hands."
- 20 As for the donkeys you lost three days ago, do not worry about them; they have been found. And to whom is all the desire of Israel turned, if not to you and all your father's family?"
- 21 Saul answered, "But I'm only a Benjaminite, from the smallest of Israel's tribes, and from the most insignificant clan in the tribe at that. Why are you talking to me like this?"
- 21 Saul answered, "But am I not a Benjamite, from the smallest tribe of Israel, and is not my clan the least of all the clans of the tribe of Benjamin? Why do you say such a thing to me?"
- 22 Samuel took Saul and his servant and led them into the dining hall at the shrine and seated them at the head of the table. There were about thirty

guests.

- 22 Then Samuel brought Saul and his servant into the hall and seated them at the head of those who were invited--about thirty in number.
- 23 Then Samuel directed the chef, "Bring the choice cut I pointed out to you, the one I told you to reserve."
- 23 Samuel said to the cook, "Bring the piece of meat I gave you, the one I told you to lay aside."
- 24 The chef brought it and placed it before Saul with a flourish, saying, "This meal was kept aside just for you. Eat! It was especially prepared for this time and occasion with these guests." Saul ate with Samuel--a memorable day!
- 24 So the cook took up the leg with what was on it and set it in front of Saul. Samuel said, "Here is what has been kept for you. Eat, because it was set aside for you for this occasion, from the time I said, 'I have invited guests.' " And Saul dined with Samuel that day.
- 25 Afterward they went down from the shrine into the city. A bed was prepared for Saul on the breeze-cooled roof of Samuel's house.
- 25 After they came down from the high place to the town, Samuel talked with Saul on the roof of his house.
- 26 They woke at the break of day. Samuel called to Saul on the roof, "Get up and I'll send you off." Saul got up and the two of them went out in the street.
- 26 They rose about daybreak and Samuel called to Saul on the roof, "Get ready, and I will send you on your way." When Saul got ready, he and Samuel went outside together.
- 27 As they approached the outskirts of town, Samuel said to Saul, "Tell your servant to go on ahead of us. You stay with me for a bit. I have a word of God to give you."
- 27 As they were going down to the edge of the town, Samuel said to Saul, "Tell the servant to go on ahead of us"--and the servant did so--"but you stay here awhile, so that I may give you a message from God."

1 Samuel 10

MSG

NIV

- 1 Then Samuel took a flask of oil, poured it on Saul's head, and kissed him. He said, "Do you see what this means? GOD has anointed you prince over his people. "This sign will confirm GOD's anointing of you as prince over his inheritance:
- 1 Then Samuel took a flask of oil and poured it on Saul's head and kissed him, saying, "Has not the LORD anointed you leader over his inheritance?
- 2 After you leave me today, as you get closer to your home country of Benjamin, you'll meet two men near Rachel's Tomb. They'll say, 'The donkeys you went to look for are found. Your father has forgotten about the donkeys and is worried about you, wringing his hands--quite beside himself!'
- 2 When you leave me today, you will meet two men near Rachel's tomb, at Zelzah on the border of Benjamin. They will say to you, 'The donkeys you set out to look for have been found. And now your father has stopped thinking about them and is worried about you. He is asking, "What shall I do about my son?" '
- 3 "Leaving there, you'll arrive at the Oak of Tabor. There you'll meet three men going up to worship God at Bethel. One will be carrying three young goats, another carrying three sacks of bread, and the third a jug of wine.
- 3 Then you will go on from there until you reach the great tree of Tabor. Three men going up to God at Bethel will meet you there. One will be carrying three young goats, another three loaves of bread, and another a skin of wine.
- 4 They'll say, 'Hello, how are you?' and offer you two loaves of bread, which you will accept.
- 4 They will greet you and offer you two loaves of bread, which you will accept from them.
- 5 "Next, you'll come to Gibeah of God, where there's a Philistine garrison. As you approach the town, you'll run into a bunch of prophets coming down from the shrine, playing harps and tambourines, flutes and drums. And they'll be prophesying.
- 5 After that you will go to Gibeah of God, where there is a Philistine outpost. As you approach the town, you will meet a procession of

- prophets coming down from the high place with lyres, tambourines, flutes and harps being played before them, and they will be prophesying.
- 6 Before you know it, the Spirit of GOD will come on you and you'll be prophesying right along with them. And you'll be transformed. You'll be a new person!
- 6 The Spirit of the LORD will come upon you in power, and you will prophesy with them; and you will be changed into a different person.
- 7 "When these confirming signs are accomplished, you'll know that you're ready: Whatever job you're given to do, do it. God is with you!
- 7 Once these signs are fulfilled, do whatever your hand finds to do, for God is with you.
- 8 "Now, go down to Gilgal and I will follow. I'll come down and join you in worship by sacrificing burnt offerings and peace offerings. Wait seven days. Then I'll come and tell you what to do next."
- 8 Go down ahead of me to Gilgal. I will surely come down to you to sacrifice burnt offerings and fellowship offerings, but you must wait seven days until I come to you and tell you what you are to do.
- 9 Saul turned and left Samuel. At that very moment God transformed him--made him a new person! And all the confirming signs took place the same day.
- 9 As Saul turned to leave Samuel, God changed Saul's heart, and all these signs were fulfilled that day.
- 10 When Saul and his party got to Gibeah, there were the prophets, right in front of them! Before he knew it, the Spirit of God came on Saul and he was prophesying right along with them.
- 10 When they arrived at Gibeah, a procession of prophets met him; the Spirit of God came upon him in power, and he joined in their prophesying.
- 11 When those who had previously known Saul saw him prophesying with the prophets, they were totally surprised. "What's going on here? What's come over the son of Kish? How on earth did Saul get to be a prophet?"
- 11 When all those who had formerly known him saw him prophesying with the prophets, they asked each other, "What is this that has happened to the son of Kish? Is Saul also among the prophets?"
- 12 One man spoke up and said, "Who started this? Where did these people ever come from?" That's how the saying got started, "Saul among the

- prophets! Who would have guessed?!"
- 12 A man who lived there answered, "And who is their father?" So it became a saying: "Is Saul also among the prophets?"
- 13 When Saul was done prophesying, he returned home.
- 13 After Saul stopped prophesying, he went to the high place.
- 14 His uncle asked him and his servant, "So where have you two been all this time?" "Out looking for the donkeys. We looked and looked and couldn't find them. And then we found Samuel!"
- 14 Now Saul's uncle asked him and his servant, "Where have you been?" "Looking for the donkeys," he said. "But when we saw they were not to be found, we went to Samuel."
- 15 "So," said Saul's uncle, "what did Samuel tell you?"
- 15 Saul's uncle said, "Tell me what Samuel said to you."
- 16 Saul said, "He told us not to worry--the donkeys had been found." But Saul didn't breathe a word to his uncle of what Samuel said about the king business.
- 16 Saul replied, "He assured us that the donkeys had been found." But he did not tell his uncle what Samuel had said about the kingship.
- 17 Samuel called the people to assemble before GOD at Mizpah.
- 17 Samuel summoned the people of Israel to the LORD at Mizpah
- 18 He addressed the children of Israel, "This is GOD's personal message to you: "I brought Israel up out of Egypt. I delivered you from Egyptian oppression--yes, from all the bullying governments that made your life miserable.
- 18 and said to them, "This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says: 'I brought Israel up out of Egypt, and I delivered you from the power of Egypt and all the kingdoms that oppressed you.'
- 19 And now you want nothing to do with your God, the very God who has a history of getting you out of troubles of all sorts. "And now you say, 'No! We want a king; give us a king!' "Well, if that's what you want, that's what you'll get! Present yourselves formally before GOD, ranked in tribes and families."
- 19 But you have now rejected your God, who saves you out of all your calamities and distresses. And you have said, 'No, set a king over us.' So now present yourselves before the LORD by your tribes and clans."

- 20 After Samuel got all the tribes of Israel lined up, the Benjamin tribe was picked.
- 20 When Samuel brought all the tribes of Israel near, the tribe of Benjamin was chosen.
- 21 Then he lined up the Benjamin tribe in family groups, and the family of Matri was picked. The family of Matri took its place in the lineup, and the name Saul, son of Kish, was picked. But when they went looking for him, he was nowhere to be found.
- 21 Then he brought forward the tribe of Benjamin, clan by clan, and Matri's clan was chosen. Finally Saul son of Kish was chosen. But when they looked for him, he was not to be found.
- 22 Samuel went back to GOD: "Is he anywhere around?" GOD said, "Yes, he's right over there--hidden in that pile of baggage."
- 22 So they inquired further of the LORD, "Has the man come here yet?" And the LORD said, "Yes, he has hidden himself among the baggage."
- 23 They ran and got him. He took his place before everyone, standing tall--head and shoulders above them.
- 23 They ran and brought him out, and as he stood among the people he was a head taller than any of the others.
- 24 Samuel then addressed the people, "Take a good look at whom GOD has chosen: the best! No one like him in the whole country!" Then a great shout went up from the people: "Long live the king!"
- 24 Samuel said to all the people, "Do you see the man the LORD has chosen? There is no one like him among all the people." Then the people shouted, "Long live the king!"
- 25 Samuel went on to instruct the people in the rules and regulations involved in a kingdom, wrote it all down in a book, and placed it before GOD. Then Samuel sent everyone home.
- 25 Samuel explained to the people the regulations of the kingship. He wrote them down on a scroll and deposited it before the LORD. Then Samuel dismissed the people, each to his own home.
- 26 Saul also went home to Gibeah, and with him some true and brave men whom GOD moved to join him.
- 26 Saul also went to his home in Gibeah, accompanied by valiant men whose hearts God had touched.

- 27 But the riff-raff went off muttering, "'Deliverer'? Don't make me laugh!" They held him in contempt and refused to congratulate him. But Saul paid them no mind. Nahash, king of the Ammonites, was brutalizing the tribes of Gad and Reuben, gouging out their right eyes and intimidating anyone who would come to Israel's help. There were very few Israelites living on the east side of the Jordan River who had not had their right eyes gouged out by Nahash. But seven thousand men had escaped from the Ammonites and were now living safely in Jabesh.
- 27 But some troublemakers said, "How can this fellow save us?" They despised him and brought him no gifts. But Saul kept silent.

1 Samuel 11

MSG

NIV

- 1 So Nahash went after them and prepared to go to war against Jabesh Gilead. The men of Jabesh petitioned Nahash: "Make a treaty with us and we'll serve you."
- 1 Nahash the Ammonite went up and besieged Jabesh Gilead. And all the men of Jabesh said to him, "Make a treaty with us, and we will be subject to you."
- 2 Nahash said, "I'll make a treaty with you on one condition: that every right eye among you be gouged out! I'll humiliate every last man and woman in Israel before I'm done!"
- 2 But Nahash the Ammonite replied, "I will make a treaty with you only on the condition that I gouge out the right eye of every one of you and so bring disgrace on all Israel."
- 3 The town leaders of Jabesh said, "Give us time to send messengers around Israel--seven days should do it. If no one shows up to help us, we'll accept your terms."
- 3 The elders of Jabesh said to him, "Give us seven days so we can send messengers throughout Israel; if no one comes to rescue us, we will surrender to you."
- 4 The messengers came to Saul's place at Gibeah and told the people what was going on. As the people broke out in loud wails,

- 4 When the messengers came to Gibeah of Saul and reported these terms to the people, they all wept aloud.
- 5 Saul showed up. He was coming back from the field with his oxen. Saul asked, "What happened? Why is everyone crying?" And they repeated the message that had come from Jabesh.
- 5 Just then Saul was returning from the fields, behind his oxen, and he asked, "What is wrong with the people? Why are they weeping?" Then they repeated to him what the men of Jabesh had said.
- 6 The Spirit of God came on Saul when he heard the report and he flew into a rage.
- 6 When Saul heard their words, the Spirit of God came upon him in power, and he burned with anger.
- 7 He grabbed the yoke of oxen and butchered them on the spot. He sent the messengers throughout Israel distributing the bloody pieces with this message: "Anyone who refuses to join up with Saul and Samuel, let this be the fate of his oxen!" The terror of GOD seized the people, and they came out, one and all, not a laggard among them.
- 7 He took a pair of oxen, cut them into pieces, and sent the pieces by messengers throughout Israel, proclaiming, "This is what will be done to the oxen of anyone who does not follow Saul and Samuel." Then the terror of the LORD fell on the people, and they turned out as one man.
- 8 Saul took command of the people at Bezek. There were 300,000 men from Israel, another 30,000 from Judah.
- 8 When Saul mustered them at Bezek, the men of Israel numbered three hundred thousand and the men of Judah thirty thousand.
- 9 Saul instructed the messengers, "Tell this to the folk in Jabesh Gilead: 'Help is on the way. Expect it by noon tomorrow.'" The messengers set straight off and delivered their message. Elated, the people of Jabesh Gilead
- 9 They told the messengers who had come, "Say to the men of Jabesh Gilead, 'By the time the sun is hot tomorrow, you will be delivered.' " When the messengers went and reported this to the men of Jabesh, they were elated.
- 10 sent word to Nahash: "Tomorrow we'll give ourselves up. You can deal with us on your terms."

- 10 They said to the Ammonites, "Tomorrow we will surrender to you, and you can do to us whatever seems good to you."
- 11 Long before dawn the next day, Saul had strategically placed his army in three groups. At first light they broke into the enemy camp and slaughtered Ammonites until noon. Those who were left ran for their lives, scattering every which way.
- 11 The next day Saul separated his men into three divisions; during the last watch of the night they broke into the camp of the Ammonites and slaughtered them until the heat of the day. Those who survived were scattered, so that no two of them were left together.
- 12 The people came to Samuel then and said, "Where are those men who said, 'Saul is not fit to rule over us'? Hand them over. We'll kill them!"
- 12 The people then said to Samuel, "Who was it that asked, 'Shall Saul reign over us?' Bring these men to us and we will put them to death."
- 13 But Saul said, "Nobody is going to be executed this day. This is the day GOD saved Israel!
- 13 But Saul said, "No one shall be put to death today, for this day the LORD has rescued Israel."
- 14 Come, let's go to Gilgal and there reconsecrate the kingship."
- 14 Then Samuel said to the people, "Come, let us go to Gilgal and there reaffirm the kingship."
- 15 They all trooped out to Gilgal. Before GOD, they crowned Saul king at Gilgal. And there they worshiped, sacrificing peace offerings. Saul and all Israel celebrated magnificently.
- 15 So all the people went to Gilgal and confirmed Saul as king in the presence of the LORD. There they sacrificed fellowship offerings before the LORD, and Saul and all the Israelites held a great celebration.

1 Samuel 12

MSG

NIV

- 1 Samuel addressed all Israel: "I've listened to everything you've said to me, listened carefully to every word, and I've given you a king.
- 1 Samuel said to all Israel, "I have listened to everything you said to me and have set a king over you.

- 2 See for yourself: Your king among you, leading you! But now look at me: I'm old and gray, and my sons are still here. I've led you faithfully from my youth until this very day.
- 2 Now you have a king as your leader. As for me, I am old and gray, and my sons are here with you. I have been your leader from my youth until this day.
- 3 Look at me! Do you have any complaints to bring before GOD and his anointed? Have I ever stolen so much as an ox or a donkey? Have I ever taken advantage of you or exploited you? Have I ever taken a bribe or played fast and loose with the law? Bring your complaint and I'll make it right."
- 3 Here I stand. Testify against me in the presence of the LORD and his anointed. Whose ox have I taken? Whose donkey have I taken? Whom have I cheated? Whom have I oppressed? From whose hand have I accepted a bribe to make me shut my eyes? If I have done any of these, I will make it right."
- 4 "Oh no," they said, "never. You've never done any of that--never abused us, never lined your own pockets."
- 4 You have not cheated or oppressed us, they replied. "You have not taken anything from anyone's hand."
- 5 "That settles it then," said Samuel. "GOD is witness, and his anointed is witness that you find nothing against me--no faults, no complaints."
- 5 Samuel said to them, "The LORD is witness against you, and also his anointed is witness this day, that you have not found anything in my hand." "He is witness," they said.
- 6 And the people said, "He is witness." Samuel continued, "This is the GOD who made Moses and Aaron your leaders and brought your ancestors out of Egypt.
- 6 Then Samuel said to the people, "It is the LORD who appointed Moses and Aaron and brought your forefathers up out of Egypt.
- 7 Take your stand before him now as I review your case before GOD in the light of all the righteous ways in which GOD has worked with you and your ancestors.
- 7 Now then, stand here, because I am going to confront you with evidence before the LORD as to all the righteous acts performed by the LORD for you and your fathers.

- 8 When Jacob's sons entered Egypt, the Egyptians made life hard for them and they cried for help to GOD. GOD sent Moses and Aaron, who led your ancestors out of Egypt and settled them here in this place.
- 8 After Jacob entered Egypt, they cried to the LORD for help, and the LORD sent Moses and Aaron, who brought your forefathers out of Egypt and settled them in this place.
- 9 "They soon forgot their GOD, so he sold them off to Sisera, commander of Hazor's army, later to a hard life under the Philistines, and still later to the king of Moab. They had to fight for their lives.
- 9 But they forgot the LORD their God; so he sold them into the hand of Sisera, the commander of the army of Hazor, and into the hands of the Philistines and the king of Moab, who fought against them.
- 10 "Then they cried for help to GOD. They confessed, 'We've sinned! We've gone off and left GOD and worshiped the fertility gods and goddesses of Canaan. Oh, deliver us from the brutalities of our enemies and we'll worship you alone.'
- 10 They cried out to the LORD and said, 'We have sinned; we have forsaken the LORD and served the Baals and the Ashtoreths. But now deliver us from the hands of our enemies, and we will serve you.'
- 11 "So GOD sent Jerub-Baal (Gideon), Bedan (Barak), Jephthah, and Samuel. He saved you from that hard life surrounded by enemies, and you lived in peace.
- 11 Then the LORD sent Jerub-Baal, Barak, Jephthah and Samuel, and he delivered you from the hands of your enemies on every side, so that you lived securely.
- 12 "But when you saw Nahash, king of the Ammonites, preparing to attack you, you said to me, 'No more of this. We want a king to lead us.' And GOD was already your king!
- 12 But when you saw that Nahash king of the Ammonites was moving against you, you said to me, 'No, we want a king to rule over us'--even though the LORD your God was your king.
- 13 "So here's the king you wanted, the king you asked for. GOD has let you have your own way, given you a king.
- 13 Now here is the king you have chosen, the one you asked for; see, the LORD has set a king over you.

- 14 If you fear GOD, worship and obey him, and don't rebel against what he tells you. If both you and your king follow GOD, no problem. GOD will be sure to save you.
- 14 If you fear the LORD and serve and obey him and do not rebel against his commands, and if both you and the king who reigns over you follow the LORD your God--good!
- 15 But if you don't obey him and rebel against what he tells you, king or no king, you will fare no better than your fathers.
- 15 But if you do not obey the LORD, and if you rebel against his commands, his hand will be against you, as it was against your fathers.
- 16 "Pay attention! Watch this wonder that GOD is going to perform before you now!
- 16 Now then, stand still and see this great thing the LORD is about to do before your eyes!
- 17 It's summer, as you well know, and the rainy season is over. But I'm going to pray to GOD. He'll send thunder and rain, a sign to convince you of the great wrong you have done to GOD by asking for a king."
- 17 Is it not wheat harvest now? I will call upon the LORD to send thunder and rain. And you will realize what an evil thing you did in the eyes of the LORD when you asked for a king."
- 18 Samuel prayed to GOD, and GOD sent thunder and rain that same day. The people were greatly afraid and in awe of GOD and of Samuel.
- 18 Then Samuel called upon the LORD, and that same day the LORD sent thunder and rain. So all the people stood in awe of the LORD and of Samuel.
- 19 Then all the people begged Samuel, "Pray to your GOD for us, your servants. Pray that we won't die! On top of all our other sins, we've piled on one more--asking for a king!"
- 19 The people all said to Samuel, "Pray to the LORD your God for your servants so that we will not die, for we have added to all our other sins the evil of asking for a king."
- 20 Samuel said to them, "Don't be fearful. It's true that you have done something very wrong. All the same, don't turn your back on GOD. Worship and serve him heart and soul!
- 20 Do not be afraid, Samuel replied. "You have done all this evil; yet do not turn away from the LORD, but serve the LORD with all your heart.

- 21 Don't chase after ghost-gods.
- 21 Do not turn away after useless idols. They can do you no good, nor can they rescue you, because they are useless.
- 22 There's nothing to them. They can't help you. They're nothing but ghost-gods! GOD, simply because of who he is, is not going to walk off and leave his people. GOD took delight in making you into his very own people.
- 22 For the sake of his great name the LORD will not reject his people, because the LORD was pleased to make you his own.
- 23 "And neither will I walk off and leave you. That would be a sin against GOD! I'm staying right here at my post praying for you and teaching you the good and right way to live.
- 23 As for me, far be it from me that I should sin against the LORD by failing to pray for you. And I will teach you the way that is good and right.
- 24 But I beg of you, fear GOD and worship him honestly and heartily. You've seen how greatly he has worked among you!
- 24 But be sure to fear the LORD and serve him faithfully with all your heart; consider what great things he has done for you.
- 25 Be warned: If you live badly, both you and your king will be thrown out."
- 25 Yet if you persist in doing evil, both you and your king will be swept away."

1 Samuel 13

MSG

NIV

- 1 Saul was a young man when he began as king. He was king over Israel for many years.
- 1 Saul was thirty years old when he became king, and he reigned over Israel forty-two years.
- 2 Saul conscripted enough men for three companies of soldiers. He kept two companies under his command at Micmash and in the Bethel hills. The other company was under Jonathan at Gibeah in Benjamin. He sent the rest of the men home.

- 2 Saul chose three thousand men from Israel; two thousand were with him at Micmash and in the hill country of Bethel, and a thousand were with Jonathan at Gibeah in Benjamin. The rest of the men he sent back to their homes.
- 3 Jonathan attacked and killed the Philistine governor stationed at Geba (Gibeah). When the Philistines heard the news, they raised the alarm: "The Hebrews are in revolt!" Saul ordered the reveille trumpets blown throughout the land.
- 3 Jonathan attacked the Philistine outpost at Geba, and the Philistines heard about it. Then Saul had the trumpet blown throughout the land and said, "Let the Hebrews hear!"
- 4 The word went out all over Israel, "Saul has killed the Philistine governor--drawn first blood! The Philistines are stirred up and mad as hornets!" Summoned, the army came to Saul at Gilgal.
- 4 So all Israel heard the news: "Saul has attacked the Philistine outpost, and now Israel has become a stench to the Philistines." And the people were summoned to join Saul at Gilgal.
- 5 The Philistines rallied their forces to fight Israel: three companies of chariots, six companies of cavalry, and so many infantry they looked like sand on the seashore. They went up into the hills and set up camp at Micmash, east of Beth Aven.
- 5 The Philistines assembled to fight Israel, with three thousand chariots, six thousand charioteers, and soldiers as numerous as the sand on the seashore. They went up and camped at Micmash, east of Beth Aven.
- 6 When the Israelites saw that they were way outnumbered and in deep trouble, they ran for cover, hiding in caves and pits, ravines and brambles and cisterns--wherever.
- 6 When the men of Israel saw that their situation was critical and that their army was hard pressed, they hid in caves and thickets, among the rocks, and in pits and cisterns.
- 7 They retreated across the Jordan River, refugees fleeing to the country of Gad and Gilead. But Saul held his ground in Gilgal, his soldiers still with him but scared to death.
- 7 Some Hebrews even crossed the Jordan to the land of Gad and Gilead. Saul remained at Gilgal, and all the troops with him were quaking with fear.

- 8 He waited seven days, the time set by Samuel. Samuel failed to show up at Gilgal, and the soldiers were slipping away, right and left.
- 8 He waited seven days, the time set by Samuel; but Samuel did not come to Gilgal, and Saul's men began to scatter.
- 9 So Saul took charge: "Bring me the burnt offering and the peace offerings!" He went ahead and sacrificed the burnt offering.
- 9 So he said, "Bring me the burnt offering and the fellowship offerings. " And Saul offered up the burnt offering.
- 10 No sooner had he done it than Samuel showed up! Saul greeted him.
- 10 Just as he finished making the offering, Samuel arrived, and Saul went out to greet him.
- 11 Samuel said, "What on earth are you doing?" Saul answered, "When I saw I was losing my army from under me, and that you hadn't come when you said you would, and that the Philistines were poised at Micmash,
- 11 What have you done? asked Samuel. Saul replied, "When I saw that the men were scattering, and that you did not come at the set time, and that the Philistines were assembling at Micmash,
- 12 I said, 'The Philistines are about to come down on me in Gilgal, and I haven't yet come before GOD asking for his help.' So I took things into my own hands, and sacrificed the burnt offering."
- 12 I thought, 'Now the Philistines will come down against me at Gilgal, and I have not sought the LORD's favor.' So I felt compelled to offer the burnt offering."
- 13 "That was a fool thing to do," Samuel said to Saul. "If you had kept the appointment that your GOD commanded, by now GOD would have set a firm and lasting foundation under your kingly rule over Israel.
- 13 You acted foolishly, Samuel said. "You have not kept the command the LORD your God gave you; if you had, he would have established your kingdom over Israel for all time.
- 14 As it is, your kingly rule is already falling to pieces. GOD is out looking for your replacement right now. This time he'll do the choosing. When he finds him, he'll appoint him leader of his people. And all because you didn't keep your appointment with GOD!"
- 14 But now your kingdom will not endure; the LORD has sought out a man after his own heart and appointed him leader of his people, because you

have not kept the LORD's command."

15 At that, Samuel got up and left Gilgal. What army there was left followed Saul into battle. They went into the hills from Gilgal toward Gibeah in Benjamin. Saul looked over and assessed the soldiers still with him--a mere six hundred!

15 Then Samuel left Gilgal and went up to Gibeah in Benjamin, and Saul counted the men who were with him. They numbered about six hundred.

16 Saul, his son Jonathan, and the soldiers who had remained made camp at Geba (Gibeah) of Benjamin. The Philistines were camped at Micmash.

16 Saul and his son Jonathan and the men with them were staying in Gibeah in Benjamin, while the Philistines camped at Micmash.

17 Three squads of raiding parties were regularly sent out from the Philistine camp. One squadron was assigned to the Ophrah road going toward Shual country;

17 Raiding parties went out from the Philistine camp in three detachments. One turned toward Ophrah in the vicinity of Shual,

18 another was assigned to the Beth Horon road; the third took the border road that rimmed the Valley of Hyenas.

18 another toward Beth Horon, and the third toward the borderland overlooking the Valley of Zeboim facing the desert.

19 There wasn't a blacksmith to be found anywhere in Israel. The Philistines made sure of that--"Lest those Hebrews start making swords and spears."

19 Not a blacksmith could be found in the whole land of Israel, because the Philistines had said, "Otherwise the Hebrews will make swords or spears!"

20 That meant that the Israelites had to go down among the Philistines to keep their farm tools--plowshares and mattocks, axes and sickles--sharp and in good repair.

20 So all Israel went down to the Philistines to have their plowshares, mattocks, axes and sickles sharpened.

21 They charged a silver coin for the plowshares and mattocks, and half that for the rest.

21 The price was two thirds of a shekel for sharpening plowshares and mattocks, and a third of a shekel for sharpening forks and axes and for repointing goads.

- 22 So when the battle of Micmash was joined, there wasn't a sword or spear to be found anywhere in Israel--except for Saul and his son Jonathan; they were both well-armed.
- 22 So on the day of the battle not a soldier with Saul and Jonathan had a sword or spear in his hand; only Saul and his son Jonathan had them.
- 23 A patrol of Philistines took up a position at Micmash Pass.
- 23 Now a detachment of Philistines had gone out to the pass at Micmash.

1 Samuel 14

MSG

NIV

- 1 Later that day, Jonathan, Saul's son, said to his armor bearer, "Come on, let's go over to the Philistine garrison patrol on the other side of the pass." But he didn't tell his father.
- 1 One day Jonathan son of Saul said to the young man bearing his armor, "Come, let's go over to the Philistine outpost on the other side." But he did not tell his father.
- 2 Meanwhile, Saul was taking it easy under the pomegranate tree at the threshing floor on the edge of town at Geba (Gibeah). There were about six hundred men with him.
- 2 Saul was staying on the outskirts of Gibeah under a pomegranate tree in Migron. With him were about six hundred men,
- 3 Ahijah, wearing the priestly Ephod, was also there. (Ahijah was the son of Ahitub, brother of Ichabod, son of Phinehas, who was the son of Eli the priest of GOD at Shiloh.) No one there knew that Jonathan had gone off.
- 3 among whom was Ahijah, who was wearing an ephod. He was a son of Ichabod's brother Ahitub son of Phinehas, the son of Eli, the LORD's priest in Shiloh. No one was aware that Jonathan had left.
- 4 The pass that Jonathan was planning to cross over to the Philistine garrison was flanked on either side by sharp rock outcroppings, cliffs named Bozez and Seneh.
- 4 On each side of the pass that Jonathan intended to cross to reach the Philistine outpost was a cliff; one was called Bozez, and the other Seneh.

- 5 The cliff to the north faced Micmash; the cliff to the south faced Geba (Gibeah).
- 5 One cliff stood to the north toward Micmash, the other to the south toward Geba.
- 6 Jonathan said to his armor bearer, "Come on now, let's go across to these uncircumcised pagans. Maybe GOD will work for us. There's no rule that says God can only deliver by using a big army. No one can stop GOD from saving when he sets his mind to it."
- 6 Jonathan said to his young armor-bearer, "Come, let's go over to the outpost of those uncircumcised fellows. Perhaps the LORD will act in our behalf. Nothing can hinder the LORD from saving, whether by many or by few."
- 7 His armor bearer said, "Go ahead. Do what you think best. I'm with you all the way."
- 7 Do all that you have in mind, his armor-bearer said. "Go ahead; I am with you heart and soul."
- 8 Jonathan said, "Here's what we'll do. We'll cross over the pass and let the men see we're there."
- 8 Jonathan said, "Come, then; we will cross over toward the men and let them see us."
- 9 If they say, 'Halt! Don't move until we check you out,' we'll stay put and not go up.
- 9 If they say to us, 'Wait there until we come to you,' we will stay where we are and not go up to them.
- 10 But if they say, 'Come on up,' we'll go right up--and we'll know GOD has given them to us. That will be our sign."
- 10 But if they say, 'Come up to us,' we will climb up, because that will be our sign that the LORD has given them into our hands."
- 11 So they did it, the two of them. They stepped into the open where they could be seen by the Philistine garrison. The Philistines shouted out, "Look at that! The Hebrews are crawling out of their holes!"
- 11 So both of them showed themselves to the Philistine outpost. "Look!" said the Philistines. "The Hebrews are crawling out of the holes they were hiding in."
- 12 Then they yelled down to Jonathan and his armor bearer, "Come on up here! We've got a thing or two to show you!"

- 12 The men of the outpost shouted to Jonathan and his armor-bearer, "Come up to us and we'll teach you a lesson." So Jonathan said to his armor-bearer, "Climb up after me; the LORD has given them into the hand of Israel."
- 13 Jonathan shouted to his armor bearer, "Up! Follow me! GOD has turned them over to Israel!" Jonathan scrambled up on all fours, his armor bearer right on his heels. When the Philistines came running up to them, he knocked them flat, his armor bearer right behind finishing them off, bashing their heads in with stones.
- 13 Jonathan climbed up, using his hands and feet, with his armor-bearer right behind him. The Philistines fell before Jonathan, and his armor-bearer followed and killed behind him.
- 14 In this first bloody encounter, Jonathan and his armor bearer killed about twenty men.
- 14 In that first attack Jonathan and his armor-bearer killed some twenty men in an area of about half an acre.
- 15 That set off a terrific upheaval in both camp and field, the soldiers in the garrison and the raiding squad badly shaken up, the ground itself shuddering--panic like you've never seen before!
- 15 Then panic struck the whole army--those in the camp and field, and those in the outposts and raiding parties--and the ground shook. It was a panic sent by God.
- 16 Saul's sentries posted back at Geba (Gibeah) in Benjamin saw the confusion and turmoil raging in the camp.
- 16 Saul's lookouts at Gibeah in Benjamin saw the army melting away in all directions.
- 17 Saul commanded, "Line up and take the roll. See who's here and who's missing."
- 17 Then Saul said to the men who were with him, "Muster the forces and see who has left us." When they did, it was Jonathan and his armor-bearer who were not there.
- 18 When they called the roll, Jonathan and his armor bearer turned up missing. Saul ordered Ahijah, "Bring the priestly Ephod. Let's see what GOD has to say here." (Ahijah was responsible for the Ephod in those days.)

- 18 Saul said to Ahijah, "Bring the ark of God." (At that time it was with the Israelites.)
- 19 While Saul was in conversation with the priest, the upheaval in the Philistine camp became greater and louder. Then Saul interrupted Ahijah: "Put the Ephod away."
- 19 While Saul was talking to the priest, the tumult in the Philistine camp increased more and more. So Saul said to the priest, "Withdraw your hand."
- 20 Saul immediately called his army together and they went straight to the battle. When they got there they found total confusion--Philistines swinging their swords wildly, killing each other.
- 20 Then Saul and all his men assembled and went to the battle. They found the Philistines in total confusion, striking each other with their swords.
- 21 Hebrews who had earlier defected to the Philistine camp came back. They now wanted to be with Israel under Saul and Jonathan.
- 21 Those Hebrews who had previously been with the Philistines and had gone up with them to their camp went over to the Israelites who were with Saul and Jonathan.
- 22 Not only that, but when all the Israelites who had been hiding out in the backwoods of Ephraim heard that the Philistines were running for their lives, they came out and joined the chase.
- 22 When all the Israelites who had hidden in the hill country of Ephraim heard that the Philistines were on the run, they joined the battle in hot pursuit.
- 23 GOD saved Israel! What a day! The fighting moved on to Beth Aven. The whole army was behind Saul now--ten thousand strong!--with the fighting scattering into all the towns throughout the hills of Ephraim.
- 23 So the LORD rescued Israel that day, and the battle moved on beyond Beth Aven.
- 24 Saul did something really foolish that day. He addressed the army: "A curse on the man who eats anything before evening, before I've wreaked vengeance on my enemies!" None of them ate a thing all day.
- 24 Now the men of Israel were in distress that day, because Saul had bound the people under an oath, saying, "Cursed be any man who eats food before evening comes, before I have avenged myself on my enemies!" So none of the troops tasted food.

25 There were honeycombs here and there in the fields.

25 The entire army entered the woods, and there was honey on the ground.

26 But no one so much as put his finger in the honey to taste it, for the soldiers to a man feared the curse.

26 When they went into the woods, they saw the honey oozing out, yet no one put his hand to his mouth, because they feared the oath.

27 But Jonathan hadn't heard his father put the army under oath. He stuck the tip of his staff into some honey and ate it. Refreshed, his eyes lit up with renewed vigor.

27 But Jonathan had not heard that his father had bound the people with the oath, so he reached out the end of the staff that was in his hand and dipped it into the honeycomb. He raised his hand to his mouth, and his eyes brightened.

28 A soldier spoke up, "Your father has put the army under solemn oath, saying, 'A curse on the man who eats anything before evening!' No wonder the soldiers are drooping!"

28 Then one of the soldiers told him, "Your father bound the army under a strict oath, saying, 'Cursed be any man who eats food today!' That is why the men are faint."

29 Jonathan said, "My father has imperiled the country. Just look how quickly my energy has returned since I ate a little of this honey!"

29 Jonathan said, "My father has made trouble for the country. See how my eyes brightened when I tasted a little of this honey."

30 It would have been a lot better, believe me, if the soldiers had eaten their fill of whatever they took from the enemy. Who knows how much worse we could have whipped them!"

30 How much better it would have been if the men had eaten today some of the plunder they took from their enemies. Would not the slaughter of the Philistines have been even greater?"

31 They killed Philistines that day all the way from Micmash to Aijalon, but the soldiers ended up totally exhausted.

31 That day, after the Israelites had struck down the Philistines from Micmash to Aijalon, they were exhausted.

32 Then they started plundering. They grabbed anything in sight--sheep, cattle, calves--and butchered it where they found it. Then they glutted themselves--meat, blood, the works.

- 32 They pounced on the plunder and, taking sheep, cattle and calves, they butchered them on the ground and ate them, together with the blood.
- 33 Saul was told, "Do something! The soldiers are sinning against GOD. They're eating meat with the blood still in it!" Saul said, "You're biting the hand that feeds you! Roll a big rock over here--now!"
- 33 Then someone said to Saul, "Look, the men are sinning against the LORD by eating meat that has blood in it." "You have broken faith," he said. "Roll a large stone over here at once."
- 34 He continued, "Disperse among the troops and tell them, 'Bring your oxen and sheep to me and butcher them properly here. Then you can feast to your heart's content. Please don't sin against GOD by eating meat with the blood still in it.'" And so they did. That night each soldier, one after another, led his animal there to be butchered.
- 34 Then he said, "Go out among the men and tell them, 'Each of you bring me your cattle and sheep, and slaughter them here and eat them. Do not sin against the LORD by eating meat with blood still in it.' " So everyone brought his ox that night and slaughtered it there.
- 35 That's the story behind Saul's building an altar to GOD. It's the first altar to GOD that he built.
- 35 Then Saul built an altar to the LORD; it was the first time he had done this.
- 36 Saul said, "Let's go after the Philistines tonight! We can spend the night looting and plundering. We won't leave a single live Philistine!" "Sounds good to us," said the troops. "Let's do it!" But the priest slowed them down: "Let's find out what God thinks about this."
- 36 Saul said, "Let us go down after the Philistines by night and plunder them till dawn, and let us not leave one of them alive." "Do whatever seems best to you," they replied. But the priest said, "Let us inquire of God here."
- 37 So Saul prayed to God, "Shall I go after the Philistines? Will you put them in Israel's hand?" God didn't answer him on that occasion.
- 37 So Saul asked God, "Shall I go down after the Philistines? Will you give them into Israel's hand?" But God did not answer him that day.
- 38 Saul then said, "All army officers, step forward. Some sin has been committed this day. We're going to find out what it is and who did it!

- 38 Saul therefore said, "Come here, all you who are leaders of the army, and let us find out what sin has been committed today.
- 39 As GOD lives, Israel's Savior God, whoever sinned will die, even if it should turn out to be Jonathan, my son!" Nobody said a word.
- 39 As surely as the LORD who rescues Israel lives, even if it lies with my son Jonathan, he must die." But not one of the men said a word.
- 40 Saul said to the Israelites, "You line up over on that side, and I and Jonathan my son will stand on this side." The army agreed, "Fine. Whatever you say."
- 40 Saul then said to all the Israelites, "You stand over there; I and Jonathan my son will stand over here." "Do what seems best to you," the men replied.
- 41 Then Saul prayed to GOD, "O God of Israel, why haven't you answered me today? Show me the truth. If the sin is in me or Jonathan, then, O GOD, give the sign Urim. But if the sin is in the army of Israel, give the sign Thummim." The Urim sign turned up and pointed to Saul and Jonathan. That cleared the army.
- 41 Then Saul prayed to the LORD, the God of Israel, "Give me the right answer." And Jonathan and Saul were taken by lot, and the men were cleared.
- 42 Next Saul said, "Cast the lots between me and Jonathan--and death to the one GOD points to!" The soldiers protested, "No--this is not right. Stop this!" But Saul pushed on anyway. They cast the lots, Urim and Thummim, and the lot fell to Jonathan.
- 42 Saul said, "Cast the lot between me and Jonathan my son." And Jonathan was taken.
- 43 Saul confronted Jonathan. "What did you do? Tell me!" Jonathan said, "I licked a bit of honey off the tip of the staff I was carrying. That's it--and for that I'm to die?"
- 43 Then Saul said to Jonathan, "Tell me what you have done." So Jonathan told him, "I merely tasted a little honey with the end of my staff. And now must I die?"
- 44 Saul said, "Yes. Jonathan most certainly will die. It's out of my hands--I can't go against God, can I?"
- 44 Saul said, "May God deal with me, be it ever so severely, if you do not die, Jonathan."

- 45 The soldiers rose up: "Jonathan--die? Never! He's just carried out this stunning salvation victory for Israel. As surely as GOD lives, not a hair on his head is going to be harmed. Why, he's been working hand-in-hand with God all day!" The soldiers rescued Jonathan and he didn't die.
- 45 But the men said to Saul, "Should Jonathan die--he who has brought about this great deliverance in Israel? Never! As surely as the LORD lives, not a hair of his head will fall to the ground, for he did this today with God's help." So the men rescued Jonathan, and he was not put to death.
- 46 Saul pulled back from chasing the Philistines, and the Philistines went home.
- 46 Then Saul stopped pursuing the Philistines, and they withdrew to their own land.
- 47 Saul extended his rule, capturing neighboring kingdoms. He fought enemies on every front--Moab, Ammon, Edom, the king of Zobah, the Philistines. Wherever he turned, he came up with a victory.
- 47 After Saul had assumed rule over Israel, he fought against their enemies on every side: Moab, the Ammonites, Edom, the kings of Zobah, and the Philistines. Wherever he turned, he inflicted punishment on them.
- 48 He became invincible! He smashed Amalek, freeing Israel from the savagery and looting.
- 48 He fought valiantly and defeated the Amalekites, delivering Israel from the hands of those who had plundered them.
- 49 Saul's sons were Jonathan, Ishvi, and Malki-Shua. His daughters were Merab, the firstborn, and Michal, the younger.
- 49 Saul's sons were Jonathan, Ishvi and Malki-Shua. The name of his older daughter was Merab, and that of the younger was Michal.
- 50 Saul's wife was Ahinoam, daughter of Ahimaaz. Abner son of Ner was commander of Saul's army (Ner was Saul's uncle).
- 50 His wife's name was Ahinoam daughter of Ahimaaz. The name of the commander of Saul's army was Abner son of Ner, and Ner was Saul's uncle.
- 51 Kish, Saul's father, and Ner, Abner's father, were the sons of Abiel.
- 51 Saul's father Kish and Abner's father Ner were sons of Abiel.
- 52 All through Saul's life there was war, bitter and relentless, with the Philistines. Saul conscripted every strong and brave man he laid eyes on.

52 All the days of Saul there was bitter war with the Philistines, and whenever Saul saw a mighty or brave man, he took him into his service.

1 Samuel 15

MSG

NIV

- 1 Samuel said to Saul, "GOD sent me to anoint you king over his people, Israel. Now, listen again to what GOD says.
- 1 Samuel said to Saul, "I am the one the LORD sent to anoint you king over his people Israel; so listen now to the message from the LORD.
- 2 This is the GOD-of-the-Angel-Armies speaking: "'I'm about to get even with Amalek for ambushing Israel when Israel came up out of Egypt.
- 2 This is what the LORD Almighty says: 'I will punish the Amalekites for what they did to Israel when they waylaid them as they came up from Egypt.
- 3 Here's what you are to do: Go to war against Amalek. Put everything connected with Amalek under a holy ban. And no exceptions! This is to be total destruction--men and women, children and infants, cattle and sheep, camels and donkeys--the works.'"
- 3 Now go, attack the Amalekites and totally destroy everything that belongs to them. Do not spare them; put to death men and women, children and infants, cattle and sheep, camels and donkeys.' "
- 4 Saul called the army together at Telaim and prepared them to go to war--two hundred companies of infantry from Israel and another ten companies from Judah.
- 4 So Saul summoned the men and mustered them at Telaim--two hundred thousand foot soldiers and ten thousand men from Judah.
- 5 Saul marched to Amalek City and hid in the canyon.
- 5 Saul went to the city of Amalek and set an ambush in the ravine.
- 6 Then Saul got word to the Kenites: "Get out of here while you can. Evacuate the city right now or you'll get lumped in with the Amalekites. I'm warning you because you showed real kindness to the Israelites when they came up out of Egypt." And they did. The Kenites evacuated the place.

- 6 Then he said to the Kenites, "Go away, leave the Amalekites so that I do not destroy you along with them; for you showed kindness to all the Israelites when they came up out of Egypt." So the Kenites moved away from the Amalekites.
- 7 Then Saul went after Amalek, from the canyon all the way to Shur near the Egyptian border.
- 7 Then Saul attacked the Amalekites all the way from Havilah to Shur, to the east of Egypt.
- 8 He captured Agag, king of Amalek, alive. Everyone else was killed under the terms of the holy ban.
- 8 He took Agag king of the Amalekites alive, and all his people he totally destroyed with the sword.
- 9 Saul and the army made an exception for Agag, and for the choice sheep and cattle. They didn't include them under the terms of the holy ban. But all the rest, which nobody wanted anyway, they destroyed as decreed by the holy ban.
- 9 But Saul and the army spared Agag and the best of the sheep and cattle, the fat calves and lambs--everything that was good. These they were unwilling to destroy completely, but everything that was despised and weak they totally destroyed.
- 10 Then GOD spoke to Samuel:
- 10 Then the word of the LORD came to Samuel:
- 11 "I'm sorry I ever made Saul king. He's turned his back on me. He refuses to do what I tell him." Samuel was angry when he heard this. He prayed his anger and disappointment all through the night.
- 11 I am grieved that I have made Saul king, because he has turned away from me and has not carried out my instructions. Samuel was troubled, and he cried out to the LORD all that night.
- 12 He got up early in the morning to confront Saul but was told, "Saul's gone. He went to Carmel to set up a victory monument in his own honor, and then was headed for Gilgal." By the time Samuel caught up with him, Saul had just finished an act of worship, having used Amalekite plunder for the burnt offerings sacrificed to GOD.
- 12 Early in the morning Samuel got up and went to meet Saul, but he was told, "Saul has gone to Carmel. There he has set up a monument in his own honor and has turned and gone on down to Gilgal."

- 13 As Samuel came close, Saul called out, "GOD's blessings on you! I accomplished GOD's plan to the letter!"
- 13 When Samuel reached him, Saul said, "The LORD bless you! I have carried out the LORD's instructions."
- 14 Samuel said, "So what's this I'm hearing--this bleating of sheep, this mooing of cattle?"
- 14 But Samuel said, "What then is this bleating of sheep in my ears? What is this lowing of cattle that I hear?"
- 15 "Only some Amalekite loot," said Saul. "The soldiers saved back a few of the choice cattle and sheep to offer up in sacrifice to GOD. But everything else we destroyed under the holy ban."
- 15 Saul answered, "The soldiers brought them from the Amalekites; they spared the best of the sheep and cattle to sacrifice to the LORD your God, but we totally destroyed the rest."
- 16 "Enough!" interrupted Samuel. "Let me tell you what GOD told me last night." Saul said, "Go ahead. Tell me."
- 16 Stop! Samuel said to Saul. "Let me tell you what the LORD said to me last night." "Tell me," Saul replied.
- 17 And Samuel told him. "When you started out in this, you were nothing--and you knew it. Then GOD put you at the head of Israel--made you king over Israel.
- 17 Samuel said, "Although you were once small in your own eyes, did you not become the head of the tribes of Israel? The LORD anointed you king over Israel.
- 18 Then GOD sent you off to do a job for him, ordering you, 'Go and put those sinners, the Amalekites, under a holy ban. Go to war against them until you have totally wiped them out.'
- 18 And he sent you on a mission, saying, 'Go and completely destroy those wicked people, the Amalekites; make war on them until you have wiped them out.'
- 19 So why did you not obey GOD? Why did you grab all this loot? Why, with GOD's eyes on you all the time, did you brazenly carry out this evil?"
- 19 Why did you not obey the LORD? Why did you pounce on the plunder and do evil in the eyes of the LORD?"

- 20 Saul defended himself. "What are you talking about? I did obey GOD. I did the job GOD set for me. I brought in King Agag and destroyed the Amalekites under the terms of the holy ban.
- 20 But I did obey the LORD, Saul said. "I went on the mission the LORD assigned me. I completely destroyed the Amalekites and brought back Agag their king.
- 21 So the soldiers saved back a few choice sheep and cattle from the holy ban for sacrifice to GOD at Gilgal--what's wrong with that?"
- 21 The soldiers took sheep and cattle from the plunder, the best of what was devoted to God, in order to sacrifice them to the LORD your God at Gilgal."
- 22 Then Samuel said, Do you think all GOD wants are sacrifices-- empty rituals just for show? He wants you to listen to him! Plain listening is the thing, not staging a lavish religious production.
- 22 But Samuel replied: "Does the LORD delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices as much as in obeying the voice of the LORD? To obey is better than sacrifice, and to heed is better than the fat of rams.
- 23 Not doing what GOD tells you is far worse than fooling around in the occult. Getting self-important around GOD is far worse than making deals with your dead ancestors. Because you said No to GOD's command, he says No to your kingship.
- 23 For rebellion is like the sin of divination, and arrogance like the evil of idolatry. Because you have rejected the word of the LORD, he has rejected you as king."
- 24 Saul gave in and confessed, "I've sinned. I've trampled roughshod over GOD's Word and your instructions. I cared more about pleasing the people. I let them tell me what to do.
- 24 Then Saul said to Samuel, "I have sinned. I violated the LORD's command and your instructions. I was afraid of the people and so I gave in to them.
- 25 Oh, absolve me of my sin! Take my hand and lead me to the altar so I can worship GOD!"
- 25 Now I beg you, forgive my sin and come back with me, so that I may worship the LORD."
- 26 But Samuel refused: "No, I can't come alongside you in this. You rejected GOD's command. Now GOD has rejected you as king over

Israel."

26 But Samuel said to him, "I will not go back with you. You have rejected the word of the LORD, and the LORD has rejected you as king over Israel!"

27 As Samuel turned to leave, Saul grabbed at his priestly robe and a piece tore off.

27 As Samuel turned to leave, Saul caught hold of the hem of his robe, and it tore.

28 Samuel said, "GOD has just now torn the kingdom from you, and handed it over to your neighbor, a better man than you are.

28 Samuel said to him, "The LORD has torn the kingdom of Israel from you today and has given it to one of your neighbors--to one better than you.

29 Israel's God-of-Glory doesn't deceive and he doesn't dither. He says what he means and means what he says."

29 He who is the Glory of Israel does not lie or change his mind; for he is not a man, that he should change his mind."

30 Saul tried again, "I have sinned. But don't abandon me! Support me with your presence before the leaders and the people. Come alongside me as I go back to worship GOD."

30 Saul replied, "I have sinned. But please honor me before the elders of my people and before Israel; come back with me, so that I may worship the LORD your God."

31 Samuel did. He went back with him. And Saul went to his knees before GOD and worshiped.

31 So Samuel went back with Saul, and Saul worshiped the LORD.

32 Then Samuel said, "Present King Agag of Amalek to me." Agag came, dragging his feet, muttering that he'd be better off dead.

32 Then Samuel said, "Bring me Agag king of the Amalekites." Agag came to him confidently, thinking, "Surely the bitterness of death is past."

33 Samuel said, "Just as your sword made many a woman childless, so your mother will be childless among those women!" And Samuel cut Agag down in the presence of GOD right there in Gilgal.

33 But Samuel said, "As your sword has made women childless, so will your mother be childless among women." And Samuel put Agag to death

before the LORD at Gilgal.

34 Samuel left immediately for Ramah and Saul went home to Gibeah.

34 Then Samuel left for Ramah, but Saul went up to his home in Gibeah of Saul.

35 Samuel never laid eyes on Saul again in this life, although he grieved long and deeply over him. But GOD was sorry he had ever made Saul king in the first place.

35 Until the day Samuel died, he did not go to see Saul again, though Samuel mourned for him. And the LORD was grieved that he had made Saul king over Israel.

1 Samuel 16

MSG

NIV

- 1 GOD addressed Samuel: "So, how long are you going to mope over Saul? You know I've rejected him as king over Israel. Fill your flask with anointing oil and get going. I'm sending you to Jesse of Bethlehem. I've spotted the very king I want among his sons."
- 1 The LORD said to Samuel, "How long will you mourn for Saul, since I have rejected him as king over Israel? Fill your horn with oil and be on your way; I am sending you to Jesse of Bethlehem. I have chosen one of his sons to be king."
- 2 "I can't do that," said Samuel. "Saul will hear about it and kill me." GOD said, "Take a heifer with you and announce, 'I've come to lead you in worship of GOD, with this heifer as a sacrifice.'"
- 2 But Samuel said, "How can I go? Saul will hear about it and kill me." The LORD said, "Take a heifer with you and say, 'I have come to sacrifice to the LORD.'"
- 3 Make sure Jesse gets invited. I'll let you know what to do next. I'll point out the one you are to anoint."
- 3 Invite Jesse to the sacrifice, and I will show you what to do. You are to anoint for me the one I indicate."
- 4 Samuel did what GOD told him. When he arrived at Bethlehem, the town fathers greeted him, but apprehensively. "Is there something wrong?"
- 4 Samuel did what the LORD said. When he arrived at Bethlehem, the elders of the town trembled when they met him. They asked, "Do you come in peace?"
- 5 "Nothing's wrong. I've come to sacrifice this heifer and lead you in the worship of GOD. Prepare yourselves, be consecrated, and join me in worship." He made sure Jesse and his sons were also consecrated and called to worship.
- 5 Samuel replied, "Yes, in peace; I have come to sacrifice to the LORD. Consecrate yourselves and come to the sacrifice with me." Then he consecrated Jesse and his sons and invited them to the sacrifice.

- 6 When they arrived, Samuel took one look at Eliab and thought, "Here he is! GOD's anointed!"
- 6 When they arrived, Samuel saw Eliab and thought, "Surely the LORD's anointed stands here before the LORD."
- 7 But GOD told Samuel, "Looks aren't everything. Don't be impressed with his looks and stature. I've already eliminated him. GOD judges persons differently than humans do. Men and women look at the face; GOD looks into the heart."
- 7 But the LORD said to Samuel, "Do not consider his appearance or his height, for I have rejected him. The LORD does not look at the things man looks at. Man looks at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart."
- 8 Jesse then called up Abinadab and presented him to Samuel. Samuel said, "This man isn't GOD's choice either."
- 8 Then Jesse called Abinadab and had him pass in front of Samuel. But Samuel said, "The LORD has not chosen this one either."
- 9 Next Jesse presented Shammah. Samuel said, "No, this man isn't either."
- 9 Jesse then had Shammah pass by, but Samuel said, "Nor has the LORD chosen this one."
- 10 Jesse presented his seven sons to Samuel. Samuel was blunt with Jesse, "GOD hasn't chosen any of these."
- 10 Jesse had seven of his sons pass before Samuel, but Samuel said to him, "The LORD has not chosen these."
- 11 Then he asked Jesse, "Is this it? Are there no more sons?" "Well, yes, there's the runt. But he's out tending the sheep." Samuel ordered Jesse, "Go get him. We're not moving from this spot until he's here."
- 11 So he asked Jesse, "Are these all the sons you have?" "There is still the youngest," Jesse answered, "but he is tending the sheep." Samuel said, "Send for him; we will not sit down until he arrives."
- 12 Jesse sent for him. He was brought in, the very picture of health--bright-eyed, good-looking. GOD said, "Up on your feet! Anoint him! This is the one."
- 12 So he sent and had him brought in. He was ruddy, with a fine appearance and handsome features. Then the LORD said, "Rise and anoint him; he is the one."

- 13 Samuel took his flask of oil and anointed him, with his brothers standing around watching. The Spirit of GOD entered David like a rush of wind, God vitally empowering him for the rest of his life. Samuel left and went home to Ramah.
- 13 So Samuel took the horn of oil and anointed him in the presence of his brothers, and from that day on the Spirit of the LORD came upon David in power. Samuel then went to Ramah.
- 14 At that very moment the Spirit of GOD left Saul and in its place a black mood sent by GOD settled on him. He was terrified.
- 14 Now the Spirit of the LORD had departed from Saul, and an evil spirit from the LORD tormented him.
- 15 Saul's advisors said, "This awful tormenting depression from God is making your life miserable.
- 15 Saul's attendants said to him, "See, an evil spirit from God is tormenting you.
- 16 O master, let us help. Let us look for someone who can play the harp. When the black mood from God moves in, he'll play his music and you'll feel better."
- 16 Let our lord command his servants here to search for someone who can play the harp. He will play when the evil spirit from God comes upon you, and you will feel better."
- 17 Saul told his servants, "Go ahead. Find me someone who can play well and bring him to me."
- 17 So Saul said to his attendants, "Find someone who plays well and bring him to me."
- 18 One of the young men spoke up, "I know someone. I've seen him myself: the son of Jesse of Bethlehem, an excellent musician. He's also courageous, of age, well-spoken, and good-looking. And GOD is with him."
- 18 One of the servants answered, "I have seen a son of Jesse of Bethlehem who knows how to play the harp. He is a brave man and a warrior. He speaks well and is a fine-looking man. And the LORD is with him."
- 19 So Saul sent messengers to Jesse requesting, "Send your son David to me, the one who tends the sheep."
- 19 Then Saul sent messengers to Jesse and said, "Send me your son David, who is with the sheep."

- 20 Jesse took a donkey, loaded it with a couple of loaves of bread, a flask of wine, and a young goat, and sent his son David with it to Saul.
- 20 So Jesse took a donkey loaded with bread, a skin of wine and a young goat and sent them with his son David to Saul.
- 21 David came to Saul and stood before him. Saul liked him immediately and made him his right-hand man.
- 21 David came to Saul and entered his service. Saul liked him very much, and David became one of his armor-bearers.
- 22 Saul sent word back to Jesse: "Thank you. David will stay here. He's just the one I was looking for. I'm very impressed by him."
- 22 Then Saul sent word to Jesse, saying, "Allow David to remain in my service, for I am pleased with him."
- 23 After that, whenever the bad depression from God tormented Saul, David got out his harp and played. That would calm Saul down, and he would feel better as the moodiness lifted.
- 23 Whenever the spirit from God came upon Saul, David would take his harp and play. Then relief would come to Saul; he would feel better, and the evil spirit would leave him.

1 Samuel 17

MSG

NIV

- 1 The Philistines drew up their troops for battle. They deployed them at Socoh in Judah, and set up camp between Socoh and Azekah at Ephes Dammim.
- 1 Now the Philistines gathered their forces for war and assembled at Socoh in Judah. They pitched camp at Ephes Dammim, between Socoh and Azekah.
- 2 Saul and the Israelites came together, camped at Oak Valley, and spread out their troops in battle readiness for the Philistines.
- 2 Saul and the Israelites assembled and camped in the Valley of Elah and drew up their battle line to meet the Philistines.
- 3 The Philistines were on one hill, the Israelites on the opposing hill, with the valley between them.

- 3 The Philistines occupied one hill and the Israelites another, with the valley between them.
- 4 A giant nearly ten feet tall stepped out from the Philistine line into the open, Goliath from Gath.
- 4 A champion named Goliath, who was from Gath, came out of the Philistine camp. He was over nine feet tall.
- 5 He had a bronze helmet on his head and was dressed in armor--126 pounds of it!
- 5 He had a bronze helmet on his head and wore a coat of scale armor of bronze weighing five thousand shekels;
- 6 He wore bronze shin guards and carried a bronze sword.
- 6 on his legs he wore bronze greaves, and a bronze javelin was slung on his back.
- 7 His spear was like a fence rail--the spear tip alone weighed over fifteen pounds. His shield bearer walked ahead of him.
- 7 His spear shaft was like a weaver's rod, and its iron point weighed six hundred shekels. His shield bearer went ahead of him.
- 8 Goliath stood there and called out to the Israelite troops, "Why bother using your whole army? Am I not Philistine enough for you? And you're all committed to Saul, aren't you? So pick your best fighter and pit him against me.
- 8 Goliath stood and shouted to the ranks of Israel, "Why do you come out and line up for battle? Am I not a Philistine, and are you not the servants of Saul? Choose a man and have him come down to me.
- 9 If he gets the upper hand and kills me, the Philistines will all become your slaves. But if I get the upper hand and kill him, you'll all become our slaves and serve us.
- 9 If he is able to fight and kill me, we will become your subjects; but if I overcome him and kill him, you will become our subjects and serve us."
- 10 I challenge the troops of Israel this day. Give me a man. Let us fight it out together!"
- 10 Then the Philistine said, "This day I defy the ranks of Israel! Give me a man and let us fight each other."
- 11 When Saul and his troops heard the Philistine's challenge, they were terrified and lost all hope.

- 11 On hearing the Philistine's words, Saul and all the Israelites were dismayed and terrified.
- 12 Enter David. He was the son of Jesse the Ephrathite from Bethlehem in Judah. Jesse, the father of eight sons, was himself too old to join Saul's army.
- 12 Now David was the son of an Ephrathite named Jesse, who was from Bethlehem in Judah. Jesse had eight sons, and in Saul's time he was old and well advanced in years.
- 13 Jesse's three older sons had followed Saul to war. The names of the three sons who had joined up with Saul were Eliab, the firstborn; next, Abinadab; and third, Shammah.
- 13 Jesse's three oldest sons had followed Saul to the war: The firstborn was Eliab; the second, Abinadab; and the third, Shammah.
- 14 David was the youngest son. While his three oldest brothers went to war with Saul, David went back and forth from attending to Saul to tending his father's sheep in Bethlehem.
- 14 David was the youngest. The three oldest followed Saul,
- 15 (SEE 17:14)
- 15 but David went back and forth from Saul to tend his father's sheep at Bethlehem.
- 16 Each morning and evening for forty days, Goliath took his stand and made his speech.
- 16 For forty days the Philistine came forward every morning and evening and took his stand.
- 17 One day, Jesse told David his son, "Take this sack of cracked wheat and these ten loaves of bread and run them down to your brothers in the camp.
- 17 Now Jesse said to his son David, "Take this ephah of roasted grain and these ten loaves of bread for your brothers and hurry to their camp.
- 18 And take these ten wedges of cheese to the captain of their division. Check in on your brothers to see whether they are getting along all right, and let me know how they're doing--
- 18 Take along these ten cheeses to the commander of their unit. See how your brothers are and bring back some assurance from them.
- 19 Saul and your brothers, and all the Israelites in their war with the Philistines in the Oak Valley."

- 19 They are with Saul and all the men of Israel in the Valley of Elah, fighting against the Philistines."
- 20 David was up at the crack of dawn and, having arranged for someone to tend his flock, took the food and was on his way just as Jesse had directed him. He arrived at the camp just as the army was moving into battle formation, shouting the war cry.
- 20 Early in the morning David left the flock with a shepherd, loaded up and set out, as Jesse had directed. He reached the camp as the army was going out to its battle positions, shouting the war cry.
- 21 Israel and the Philistines moved into position, facing each other, battle-ready.
- 21 Israel and the Philistines were drawing up their lines facing each other.
- 22 David left his bundles of food in the care of a sentry, ran to the troops who were deployed, and greeted his brothers.
- 22 David left his things with the keeper of supplies, ran to the battle lines and greeted his brothers.
- 23 While they were talking together, the Philistine champion, Goliath of Gath, stepped out from the front lines of the Philistines, and gave his usual challenge. David heard him.
- 23 As he was talking with them, Goliath, the Philistine champion from Gath, stepped out from his lines and shouted his usual defiance, and David heard it.
- 24 The Israelites, to a man, fell back the moment they saw the giant--totally frightened.
- 24 When the Israelites saw the man, they all ran from him in great fear.
- 25 The talk among the troops was, "Have you ever seen anything like this, this man openly and defiantly challenging Israel? The man who kills the giant will have it made. The king will give him a huge reward, offer his daughter as a bride, and give his entire family a free ride."
- 25 Now the Israelites had been saying, "Do you see how this man keeps coming out? He comes out to defy Israel. The king will give great wealth to the man who kills him. He will also give him his daughter in marriage and will exempt his father's family from taxes in Israel."
- 26 David, who was talking to the men standing around him, asked, "What's in it for the man who kills that Philistine and gets rid of this ugly blot on

- Israel's honor? Who does he think he is, anyway, this uncircumcised Philistine, taunting the armies of God-Alive?"
- 26 David asked the men standing near him, "What will be done for the man who kills this Philistine and removes this disgrace from Israel? Who is this uncircumcised Philistine that he should defy the armies of the living God?"
- 27 They told him what everyone was saying about what the king would do for the man who killed the Philistine.
- 27 They repeated to him what they had been saying and told him, "This is what will be done for the man who kills him."
- 28 Eliab, his older brother, heard David fraternizing with the men and lost his temper: "What are you doing here! Why aren't you minding your own business, tending that scrawny flock of sheep? I know what you're up to. You've come down here to see the sights, hoping for a ringside seat at a bloody battle!"
- 28 When Eliab, David's oldest brother, heard him speaking with the men, he burned with anger at him and asked, "Why have you come down here? And with whom did you leave those few sheep in the desert? I know how conceited you are and how wicked your heart is; you came down only to watch the battle."
- 29 "What is it with you?" replied David. "All I did was ask a question."
- 29 Now what have I done? said David. "Can't I even speak?"
- 30 Ignoring his brother, he turned to someone else, asked the same question, and got the same answer as before.
- 30 He then turned away to someone else and brought up the same matter, and the men answered him as before.
- 31 The things David was saying were picked up and reported to Saul. Saul sent for him.
- 31 What David said was overheard and reported to Saul, and Saul sent for him.
- 32 "Master," said David, "don't give up hope. I'm ready to go and fight this Philistine."
- 32 David said to Saul, "Let no one lose heart on account of this Philistine; your servant will go and fight him."
- 33 Saul answered David, "You can't go and fight this Philistine. You're too young and inexperienced--and he's been at this fighting business since

before you were born."

33 Saul replied, "You are not able to go out against this Philistine and fight him; you are only a boy, and he has been a fighting man from his youth."

34 David said, "I've been a shepherd, tending sheep for my father. Whenever a lion or bear came and took a lamb from the flock,

34 But David said to Saul, "Your servant has been keeping his father's sheep. When a lion or a bear came and carried off a sheep from the flock,

35 I'd go after it, knock it down, and rescue the lamb. If it turned on me, I'd grab it by the throat, wring its neck, and kill it.

35 I went after it, struck it and rescued the sheep from its mouth. When it turned on me, I seized it by its hair, struck it and killed it.

36 Lion or bear, it made no difference--I killed it. And I'll do the same to this Philistine pig who is taunting the troops of God-Alive.

36 Your servant has killed both the lion and the bear; this uncircumcised Philistine will be like one of them, because he has defied the armies of the living God.

37 GOD, who delivered me from the teeth of the lion and the claws of the bear, will deliver me from this Philistine." Saul said, "Go. And GOD help you!"

37 The LORD who delivered me from the paw of the lion and the paw of the bear will deliver me from the hand of this Philistine." Saul said to David, "Go, and the LORD be with you."

38 Then Saul outfitted David as a soldier in armor. He put his bronze helmet on his head and belted his sword on him over the armor.

38 Then Saul dressed David in his own tunic. He put a coat of armor on him and a bronze helmet on his head.

39 David tried to walk but he could hardly budge. David told Saul, "I can't even move with all this stuff on me. I'm not used to this." And he took it all off.

39 David fastened on his sword over the tunic and tried walking around, because he was not used to them. "I cannot go in these," he said to Saul, "because I am not used to them." So he took them off.

40 Then David took his shepherd's staff, selected five smooth stones from the brook, and put them in the pocket of his shepherd's pack, and with his sling in his hand approached Goliath.

- 40 Then he took his staff in his hand, chose five smooth stones from the stream, put them in the pouch of his shepherd's bag and, with his sling in his hand, approached the Philistine.
- 41 As the Philistine paced back and forth, his shield bearer in front of him, he noticed David.
- 41 Meanwhile, the Philistine, with his shield bearer in front of him, kept coming closer to David.
- 42 He took one look down on him and sneered--a mere youngster, apple-cheeked and peach-fuzzed.
- 42 He looked David over and saw that he was only a boy, ruddy and handsome, and he despised him.
- 43 The Philistine ridiculed David. "Am I a dog that you come after me with a stick?" And he cursed him by his gods.
- 43 He said to David, "Am I a dog, that you come at me with sticks?" And the Philistine cursed David by his gods.
- 44 "Come on," said the Philistine. "I'll make roadkill of you for the buzzards. I'll turn you into a tasty morsel for the field mice."
- 44 Come here, he said, "and I'll give your flesh to the birds of the air and the beasts of the field!"
- 45 David answered, "You come at me with sword and spear and battle-ax. I come at you in the name of GOD-of-the-Angel-Armies, the God of Israel's troops, whom you curse and mock.
- 45 David said to the Philistine, "You come against me with sword and spear and javelin, but I come against you in the name of the LORD Almighty, the God of the armies of Israel, whom you have defied.
- 46 This very day GOD is handing you over to me. I'm about to kill you, cut off your head, and serve up your body and the bodies of your Philistine buddies to the crows and coyotes. The whole earth will know that there's an extraordinary God in Israel.
- 46 This day the LORD will hand you over to me, and I'll strike you down and cut off your head. Today I will give the carcasses of the Philistine army to the birds of the air and the beasts of the earth, and the whole world will know that there is a God in Israel.
- 47 And everyone gathered here will learn that GOD doesn't save by means of sword or spear. The battle belongs to GOD--he's handing you to us on a platter!"

- 47 All those gathered here will know that it is not by sword or spear that the LORD saves; for the battle is the LORD's, and he will give all of you into our hands."
- 48 That roused the Philistine, and he started toward David. David took off from the front line, running toward the Philistine.
- 48 As the Philistine moved closer to attack him, David ran quickly toward the battle line to meet him.
- 49 David reached into his pocket for a stone, slung it, and hit the Philistine hard in the forehead, embedding the stone deeply. The Philistine crashed, facedown in the dirt.
- 49 Reaching into his bag and taking out a stone, he slung it and struck the Philistine on the forehead. The stone sank into his forehead, and he fell facedown on the ground.
- 50 That's how David beat the Philistine--with a sling and a stone. He hit him and killed him. No sword for David!
- 50 So David triumphed over the Philistine with a sling and a stone; without a sword in his hand he struck down the Philistine and killed him.
- 51 Then David ran up to the Philistine and stood over him, pulled the giant's sword from its sheath, and finished the job by cutting off his head. When the Philistines saw that their great champion was dead, they scattered, running for their lives.
- 51 David ran and stood over him. He took hold of the Philistine's sword and drew it from the scabbard. After he killed him, he cut off his head with the sword. When the Philistines saw that their hero was dead, they turned and ran.
- 52 The men of Israel and Judah were up on their feet, shouting! They chased the Philistines all the way to the outskirts of Gath and the gates of Ekron.
- 52 Then the men of Israel and Judah surged forward with a shout and pursued the Philistines to the entrance of Gath and to the gates of Ekron. Their dead were strewn along the Shaaraim road to Gath and Ekron.
- 53 Wounded Philistines were strewn along the Shaaraim road all the way to Gath and Ekron. After chasing the Philistines, the Israelites came back and looted their camp.
- 53 When the Israelites returned from chasing the Philistines, they plundered their camp.

- 54 David took the Philistine's head and brought it to Jerusalem. But the giant's weapons he placed in his own tent.
- 54 David took the Philistine's head and brought it to Jerusalem, and he put the Philistine's weapons in his own tent.
- 55 When Saul saw David go out to meet the Philistine, he said to Abner, commander of the army, "Tell me about this young man's family." Abner said, "For the life of me, O King, I don't know."
- 55 As Saul watched David going out to meet the Philistine, he said to Abner, commander of the army, "Abner, whose son is that young man?" Abner replied, "As surely as you live, O king, I don't know."
- 56 The king said, "Well, find out the lineage of this raw youth."
- 56 The king said, "Find out whose son this young man is."
- 57 As soon as David came back from killing the Philistine, Abner brought him, the Philistine's head still in his hand, straight to Saul.
- 57 As soon as David returned from killing the Philistine, Abner took him and brought him before Saul, with David still holding the Philistine's head.
- 58 Saul asked him, "Young man, whose son are you?" "I'm the son of your servant Jesse," said David, "the one who lives in Bethlehem."
- 58 Whose son are you, young man? Saul asked him. David said, "I am the son of your servant Jesse of Bethlehem."

1 Samuel 18

MSG

NIV

- 1 By the time David had finished reporting to Saul, Jonathan was deeply impressed with David--an immediate bond was forged between them. He became totally committed to David. From that point on he would be David's number-one advocate and friend.
- 1 After David had finished talking with Saul, Jonathan became one in spirit with David, and he loved him as himself.
- 2 Saul received David into his own household that day, no more to return to the home of his father.
- 2 From that day Saul kept David with him and did not let him return to his father's house.

- 3 Jonathan, out of his deep love for David, made a covenant with him.
- 3 And Jonathan made a covenant with David because he loved him as himself.
- 4 He formalized it with solemn gifts: his own royal robe and weapons--armor, sword, bow, and belt.
- 4 Jonathan took off the robe he was wearing and gave it to David, along with his tunic, and even his sword, his bow and his belt.
- 5 Whatever Saul gave David to do, he did it--and did it well. So well that Saul put him in charge of his military operations. Everybody, both the people in general and Saul's servants, approved of and admired David's leadership.
- 5 Whatever Saul sent him to do, David did it so successfully that Saul gave him a high rank in the army. This pleased all the people, and Saul's officers as well.
- 6 As they returned home, after David had killed the Philistine, the women poured out of all the villages of Israel singing and dancing, welcoming King Saul with tambourines, festive songs, and lutes.
- 6 When the men were returning home after David had killed the Philistine, the women came out from all the towns of Israel to meet King Saul with singing and dancing, with joyful songs and with tambourines and lutes.
- 7 In playful frolic the women sang, Saul kills by the thousand, David by the ten thousand!
- 7 As they danced, they sang: "Saul has slain his thousands, and David his tens of thousands."
- 8 This made Saul angry--very angry. He took it as a personal insult. He said, "They credit David with 'ten thousands' and me with only 'thousands.' Before you know it they'll be giving him the kingdom!"
- 8 Saul was very angry; this refrain galled him. "They have credited David with tens of thousands," he thought, "but me with only thousands. What more can he get but the kingdom?"
- 9 From that moment on, Saul kept his eye on David.
- 9 And from that time on Saul kept a jealous eye on David.
- 10 The next day an ugly mood was sent by God to afflict Saul, who became quite beside himself, raving. David played his harp, as he usually did at such times. Saul had a spear in his hand.

- 10 The next day an evil spirit from God came forcefully upon Saul. He was prophesying in his house, while David was playing the harp, as he usually did. Saul had a spear in his hand
- 11 Suddenly Saul threw the spear, thinking, "I'll nail David to the wall." David ducked, and the spear missed. This happened twice.
- 11 and he hurled it, saying to himself, "I'll pin David to the wall." But David eluded him twice.
- 12 Now Saul feared David. It was clear that GOD was with David and had left Saul.
- 12 Saul was afraid of David, because the LORD was with David but had left Saul.
- 13 So, Saul got David out of his sight by making him an officer in the army. David was in combat frequently.
- 13 So he sent David away from him and gave him command over a thousand men, and David led the troops in their campaigns.
- 14 Everything David did turned out well. Yes, GOD was with him.
- 14 In everything he did he had great success, because the LORD was with him.
- 15 As Saul saw David becoming more successful, he himself grew more fearful. He could see the handwriting on the wall.
- 15 When Saul saw how successful he was, he was afraid of him.
- 16 But everyone else in Israel and Judah loved David. They loved watching him in action.
- 16 But all Israel and Judah loved David, because he led them in their campaigns.
- 17 One day Saul said to David, "Here is Merab, my eldest daughter. I want to give her to you as your wife. Be brave and bold for my sake. Fight GOD's battles!" But all the time Saul was thinking, "The Philistines will kill him for me. I won't have to lift a hand against him."
- 17 Saul said to David, "Here is my older daughter Merab. I will give her to you in marriage; only serve me bravely and fight the battles of the LORD." For Saul said to himself, "I will not raise a hand against him. Let the Philistines do that!"
- 18 David, embarrassed, answered, "Do you really mean that? I'm from a family of nobodies! I can't be son-in-law to the king."

- 18 But David said to Saul, "Who am I, and what is my family or my father's clan in Israel, that I should become the king's son-in-law?"
- 19 The wedding day was set, but as the time neared for Merab and David to be married, Saul reneged and married his daughter off to Adriel the Meholathite.
- 19 So when the time came for Merab, Saul's daughter, to be given to David, she was given in marriage to Adriel of Meholah.
- 20 Meanwhile, Saul's daughter Michal was in love with David. When Saul was told of this, he rubbed his hands in anticipation. "Ah, a second chance. I'll use Michal as bait to get David out where the Philistines will make short work of him." So again he said to David, "You're going to be my son-in-law."
- 20 Now Saul's daughter Michal was in love with David, and when they told Saul about it, he was pleased.
- 21 (SEE 18:20)
- 21 I will give her to him, he thought, "so that she may be a snare to him and so that the hand of the Philistines may be against him." So Saul said to David, "Now you have a second opportunity to become my son-in-law."
- 22 Saul ordered his servants, "Get David off by himself and tell him, 'The king is very taken with you, and everyone at court loves you. Go ahead, become the king's son-in-law!'"
- 22 Then Saul ordered his attendants: "Speak to David privately and say, 'Look, the king is pleased with you, and his attendants all like you; now become his son-in-law.' "
- 23 The king's servants told all this to David, but David held back. "What are you thinking of? I can't do that. I'm a nobody; I have nothing to offer."
- 23 They repeated these words to David. But David said, "Do you think it is a small matter to become the king's son-in-law? I'm only a poor man and little known."
- 24 When the servants reported David's response to Saul, he told them to tell David this: "The king isn't expecting any money from you; only this: Go kill a hundred Philistines and bring evidence of your vengeance on the king's behalf. Avenge the king on his enemies." (Saul expected David to be killed in action.)

- 24 When Saul's servants told him what David had said,
25 (SEE 18:24)
25 Saul replied, "Say to David, 'The king wants no other price for the bride than a hundred Philistine foreskins, to take revenge on his enemies.' " Saul's plan was to have David fall by the hands of the Philistines.
- 26 On receiving this message, David was pleased. There was something he could do for the king that would qualify him to be his son-in-law! He lost no time but went right out, he and his men, killed the hundred Philistines, brought their evidence back in a sack, and counted it out before the king--mission completed! Saul gave Michal his daughter to David in marriage.
- 26 When the attendants told David these things, he was pleased to become the king's son-in-law. So before the allotted time elapsed,
27 (SEE 18:26)
27 David and his men went out and killed two hundred Philistines. He brought their foreskins and presented the full number to the king so that he might become the king's son-in-law. Then Saul gave him his daughter Michal in marriage.
- 28 As Saul more and more realized that GOD was with David, and how much his own daughter, Michal, loved him, his fear of David increased and settled into hate. Saul hated David.
- 28 When Saul realized that the LORD was with David and that his daughter Michal loved David,
29 (SEE 18:28)
29 Saul became still more afraid of him, and he remained his enemy the rest of his days.
- 30 Whenever the Philistine warlords came out to battle, David was there to meet them--and beat them, upstaging Saul's men. David's name was on everyone's lips.
- 30 The Philistine commanders continued to go out to battle, and as often as they did, David met with more success than the rest of Saul's officers, and his name became well known.

1 Samuel 19

MSG

NIV

- 1 Saul called his son Jonathan together with his servants and ordered them to kill David. But because Jonathan treasured David,
- 1 Saul told his son Jonathan and all the attendants to kill David. But Jonathan was very fond of David
- 2 he went and warned him: "My father is looking for a way to kill you. Here's what you are to do. Tomorrow morning, hide and stay hidden.
- 2 and warned him, "My father Saul is looking for a chance to kill you. Be on your guard tomorrow morning; go into hiding and stay there.
- 3 I'll go out with my father into the field where you are hiding. I'll talk about you with my father and we'll see what he says. Then I'll report back to you."
- 3 I will go out and stand with my father in the field where you are. I'll speak to him about you and will tell you what I find out."
- 4 Jonathan brought up David with his father, speaking well of him. "Please," he said to his father, "don't attack David. He hasn't wronged you, has he? And just look at all the good he has done!
- 4 Jonathan spoke well of David to Saul his father and said to him, "Let not the king do wrong to his servant David; he has not wronged you, and what he has done has benefited you greatly.
- 5 He put his life on the line when he killed the Philistine. What a great victory GOD gave Israel that day! You were there. You saw it and were on your feet applauding with everyone else. So why would you even think of sinning against an innocent person, killing David for no reason whatever?"
- 5 He took his life in his hands when he killed the Philistine. The LORD won a great victory for all Israel, and you saw it and were glad. Why then would you do wrong to an innocent man like David by killing him for no reason?"
- 6 Saul listened to Jonathan and said, "You're right. As GOD lives, David lives. He will not be killed."
- 6 Saul listened to Jonathan and took this oath: "As surely as the LORD lives, David will not be put to death."
- 7 Jonathan sent for David and reported to him everything that was said. Then he brought David back to Saul and everything was as it was before.

- 7 So Jonathan called David and told him the whole conversation. He brought him to Saul, and David was with Saul as before.
- 8 War broke out again and David went out to fight Philistines. He beat them badly, and they ran for their lives.
- 8 Once more war broke out, and David went out and fought the Philistines. He struck them with such force that they fled before him.
- 9 But then a black mood from God settled over Saul and took control of him. He was sitting at home, his spear in his hand, while David was playing music.
- 9 But an evil spirit from the LORD came upon Saul as he was sitting in his house with his spear in his hand. While David was playing the harp,
- 10 Suddenly, Saul tried to skewer David with his spear, but David ducked. The spear stuck in the wall and David got away. It was night.
- 10 Saul tried to pin him to the wall with his spear, but David eluded him as Saul drove the spear into the wall. That night David made good his escape.
- 11 Saul sent men to David's house to stake it out and then, first thing in the morning, to kill him. But Michal, David's wife, told him what was going on. "Quickly now--make your escape tonight. If not, you'll be dead by morning!"
- 11 Saul sent men to David's house to watch it and to kill him in the morning. But Michal, David's wife, warned him, "If you don't run for your life tonight, tomorrow you'll be killed."
- 12 She let him out of a window, and he made his escape.
- 12 So Michal let David down through a window, and he fled and escaped.
- 13 Then Michal took a dummy god and put it in the bed, placed a wig of goat's hair on its head, and threw a quilt over it.
- 13 Then Michal took an idol and laid it on the bed, covering it with a garment and putting some goats' hair at the head.
- 14 When Saul's men arrived to get David, she said, "He's sick in bed."
- 14 When Saul sent the men to capture David, Michal said, "He is ill."
- 15 Saul sent his men back, ordering them, "Bring him, bed and all, so I can kill him."
- 15 Then Saul sent the men back to see David and told them, "Bring him up to me in his bed so that I may kill him."

- 16 When the men entered the room, all they found in the bed was the dummy god with its goat-hair wig!
- 16 But when the men entered, there was the idol in the bed, and at the head was some goats' hair.
- 17 Saul stormed at Michal: "How could you play tricks on me like this? You sided with my enemy, and now he's gotten away!" Michal said, "He threatened me. He said, 'Help me out of here or I'll kill you.'"
- 17 Saul said to Michal, "Why did you deceive me like this and send my enemy away so that he escaped?" Michal told him, "He said to me, 'Let me get away. Why should I kill you?' "
- 18 David made good his escape and went to Samuel at Ramah and told him everything Saul had done to him. Then he and Samuel withdrew to the privacy of Naioth.
- 18 When David had fled and made his escape, he went to Samuel at Ramah and told him all that Saul had done to him. Then he and Samuel went to Naioth and stayed there.
- 19 Saul was told, "David's at Naioth in Ramah."
- 19 Word came to Saul: "David is in Naioth at Ramah";
- 20 He immediately sent his men to capture him. They saw a band of prophets prophesying with Samuel presiding over them. Before they knew it, the Spirit of God was on them, too, and they were ranting and raving right along with the prophets!
- 20 so he sent men to capture him. But when they saw a group of prophets prophesying, with Samuel standing there as their leader, the Spirit of God came upon Saul's men and they also prophesied.
- 21 That was reported back to Saul, and he dispatched more men. They, too, were soon prophesying. So Saul tried a third time--a third set of men--and they ended up mindlessly raving as well!
- 21 Saul was told about it, and he sent more men, and they prophesied too. Saul sent men a third time, and they also prophesied.
- 22 Fed up, Saul went to Ramah himself. He came to the big cistern at Secu and inquired, "Where are Samuel and David?" A bystander said, "Over at Naioth in Ramah."
- 22 Finally, he himself left for Ramah and went to the great cistern at Secu. And he asked, "Where are Samuel and David?" "Over in Naioth at Ramah," they said.

- 23 As he headed out for Naioth in Ramah, the Spirit of God was on him, too. All the way to Naioth he was caught up in a babbling trance!
- 23 So Saul went to Naioth at Ramah. But the Spirit of God came even upon him, and he walked along prophesying until he came to Naioth.
- 24 He ripped off his clothes and lay there rambling gibberish before Samuel for a day and a night, stretched out naked. People are still talking about it: "Saul among the prophets! Who would have guessed?"
- 24 He stripped off his robes and also prophesied in Samuel's presence. He lay that way all that day and night. This is why people say, "Is Saul also among the prophets?"

1 Samuel 20

MSG

NIV

- 1 David got out of Naioth in Ramah alive and went to Jonathan. "What do I do now? What wrong have I inflicted on your father that makes him so determined to kill me?"
- 1 Then David fled from Naioth at Ramah and went to Jonathan and asked, "What have I done? What is my crime? How have I wronged your father, that he is trying to take my life?"
- 2 "Nothing," said Jonathan. "You've done nothing wrong. And you're not going to die. Really, you're not! My father tells me everything. He does nothing, whether big or little, without confiding in me. So why would he do this behind my back? It can't be."
- 2 Never! Jonathan replied. "You are not going to die! Look, my father doesn't do anything, great or small, without confiding in me. Why would he hide this from me? It's not so!"
- 3 But David said, "Your father knows that we are the best of friends. So he says to himself, 'Jonathan must know nothing of this. If he does, he'll side with David.' But it's true--as sure as GOD lives, and as sure as you're alive before me right now--he's determined to kill me."
- 3 But David took an oath and said, "Your father knows very well that I have found favor in your eyes, and he has said to himself, 'Jonathan must

- not know this or he will be grieved.' Yet as surely as the LORD lives and as you live, there is only a step between me and death."
- 4 Jonathan said, "Tell me what you have in mind. I'll do anything for you."
- 4 Jonathan said to David, "Whatever you want me to do, I'll do for you."
- 5 David said, "Tomorrow marks the New Moon. I'm scheduled to eat dinner with the king. Instead, I'll go hide in the field until the evening of the third."
- 5 So David said, "Look, tomorrow is the New Moon festival, and I am supposed to dine with the king; but let me go and hide in the field until the evening of the day after tomorrow."
- 6 If your father misses me, say, 'David asked if he could run down to Bethlehem, his hometown, for an anniversary reunion, and worship with his family.'
- 6 If your father misses me at all, tell him, 'David earnestly asked my permission to hurry to Bethlehem, his hometown, because an annual sacrifice is being made there for his whole clan.'
- 7 If he says, 'Good!' then I'm safe. But if he gets angry, you'll know for sure that he's made up his mind to kill me."
- 7 If he says, 'Very well,' then your servant is safe. But if he loses his temper, you can be sure that he is determined to harm me."
- 8 Oh, stick with me in this. You've entered into a covenant of GOD with me, remember! If I'm in the wrong, go ahead and kill me yourself. Why bother giving me up to your father?"
- 8 As for you, show kindness to your servant, for you have brought him into a covenant with you before the LORD. If I am guilty, then kill me yourself! Why hand me over to your father?"
- 9 "Never!" exclaimed Jonathan. "I'd never do that! If I get the slightest hint that my father is fixated on killing you, I'll tell you."
- 9 Never! Jonathan said. "If I had the least inkling that my father was determined to harm you, wouldn't I tell you?"
- 10 David asked, "And whom will you get to tell me if your father comes back with a harsh answer?"
- 10 David asked, "Who will tell me if your father answers you harshly?"
- 11 "Come outside," said Jonathan. "Let's go to the field." When the two of them were out in the field,

- 11 Come, Jonathan said, "let's go out into the field." So they went there together.
- 12 Jonathan said, "As GOD, the God of Israel, is my witness, by this time tomorrow I'll get it out of my father how he feels about you. Then I'll let you know what I learn.
- 12 Then Jonathan said to David: "By the LORD, the God of Israel, I will surely sound out my father by this time the day after tomorrow! If he is favorably disposed toward you, will I not send you word and let you know?
- 13 May GOD do his worst to me if I let you down! If my father still intends to kill you, I'll tell you and get you out of here in one piece. And GOD be with you as he's been with my father!
- 13 But if my father is inclined to harm you, may the LORD deal with me, be it ever so severely, if I do not let you know and send you away safely. May the LORD be with you as he has been with my father.
- 14 If I make it through this alive, continue to be my covenant friend. And if I die,
- 14 But show me unfailing kindness like that of the LORD as long as I live, so that I may not be killed,
- 15 keep the covenant friendship with my family--forever. And when GOD finally rids the earth of David's enemies, stay loyal to Jonathan!"
- 15 and do not ever cut off your kindness from my family--not even when the LORD has cut off every one of David's enemies from the face of the earth."
- 16 (SEE 20:15)
- 16 So Jonathan made a covenant with the house of David, saying, "May the LORD call David's enemies to account."
- 17 Jonathan repeated his pledge of love and friendship for David. He loved David more than his own soul!
- 17 And Jonathan had David reaffirm his oath out of love for him, because he loved him as he loved himself.
- 18 Jonathan then laid out his plan: "Tomorrow is the New Moon, and you'll be missed when you don't show up for dinner.
- 18 Then Jonathan said to David: "Tomorrow is the New Moon festival. You will be missed, because your seat will be empty.

- 19 On the third day, when they've quit expecting you, come to the place where you hid before, and wait beside that big boulder.
- 19 The day after tomorrow, toward evening, go to the place where you hid when this trouble began, and wait by the stone Ezel.
- 20 I'll shoot three arrows in the direction of the boulder.
- 20 I will shoot three arrows to the side of it, as though I were shooting at a target.
- 21 Then I'll send off my servant, 'Go find the arrows.' If I yell after the servant, 'The arrows are on this side! Retrieve them!' that's the signal that you can return safely--as GOD lives, not a thing to fear!
- 21 Then I will send a boy and say, 'Go, find the arrows.' If I say to him, 'Look, the arrows are on this side of you; bring them here,' then come, because, as surely as the LORD lives, you are safe; there is no danger.
- 22 But if I yell, 'The arrows are farther out!' then run for it--GOD wants you out of here!
- 22 But if I say to the boy, 'Look, the arrows are beyond you,' then you must go, because the LORD has sent you away.
- 23 Regarding all the things we've discussed, remember that GOD's in on this with us to the very end!"
- 23 And about the matter you and I discussed--remember, the LORD is witness between you and me forever."
- 24 David hid in the field. On the holiday of the New Moon, the king came to the table to eat.
- 24 So David hid in the field, and when the New Moon festival came, the king sat down to eat.
- 25 He sat where he always sat, the place against the wall, with Jonathan across the table and Abner at Saul's side. But David's seat was empty.
- 25 He sat in his customary place by the wall, opposite Jonathan, and Abner sat next to Saul, but David's place was empty.
- 26 Saul didn't mention it at the time, thinking, "Something's happened that's made him unclean. That's it--he's probably unclean for the holy meal."
- 26 Saul said nothing that day, for he thought, "Something must have happened to David to make him ceremonially unclean--surely he is unclean."

- 27 But the day after the New Moon, day two of the holiday, David's seat was still empty. Saul asked Jonathan his son, "So where's that son of Jesse? He hasn't eaten with us either yesterday or today."
- 27 But the next day, the second day of the month, David's place was empty again. Then Saul said to his son Jonathan, "Why hasn't the son of Jesse come to the meal, either yesterday or today?"
- 28 Jonathan said, "David asked my special permission to go to Bethlehem.
- 28 Jonathan answered, "David earnestly asked me for permission to go to Bethlehem.
- 29 He said, 'Give me leave to attend a family reunion back home. My brothers have ordered me to be there. If it seems all right to you, let me go and see my brothers.' That's why he's not here at the king's table."
- 29 He said, 'Let me go, because our family is observing a sacrifice in the town and my brother has ordered me to be there. If I have found favor in your eyes, let me get away to see my brothers.' That is why he has not come to the king's table."
- 30 Saul exploded in anger at Jonathan: "You son of a slut! Don't you think I know that you're in cahoots with the son of Jesse, disgracing both you and your mother?"
- 30 Saul's anger flared up at Jonathan and he said to him, "You son of a perverse and rebellious woman! Don't I know that you have sided with the son of Jesse to your own shame and to the shame of the mother who bore you?"
- 31 For as long as the son of Jesse is walking around free on this earth, your future in this kingdom is at risk. Now go get him. Bring him here. From this moment, he's as good as dead!"
- 31 As long as the son of Jesse lives on this earth, neither you nor your kingdom will be established. Now send and bring him to me, for he must die!"
- 32 Jonathan stood up to his father. "Why dead? What's he done?"
- 32 Why should he be put to death? What has he done? Jonathan asked his father.
- 33 Saul threw his spear at him to kill him. That convinced Jonathan that his father was fixated on killing David.
- 33 But Saul hurled his spear at him to kill him. Then Jonathan knew that his father intended to kill David.

- 34 Jonathan stormed from the table, furiously angry, and ate nothing the rest of the day, upset for David and smarting under the humiliation from his father.
- 34 Jonathan got up from the table in fierce anger; on that second day of the month he did not eat, because he was grieved at his father's shameful treatment of David.
- 35 In the morning, Jonathan went to the field for the appointment with David. He had his young servant with him.
- 35 In the morning Jonathan went out to the field for his meeting with David. He had a small boy with him,
- 36 He told the servant, "Run and get the arrows I'm about to shoot." The boy started running and Jonathan shot an arrow way beyond him.
- 36 and he said to the boy, "Run and find the arrows I shoot." As the boy ran, he shot an arrow beyond him.
- 37 As the boy came to the area where the arrow had been shot, Jonathan yelled out, "Isn't the arrow farther out?"
- 37 When the boy came to the place where Jonathan's arrow had fallen, Jonathan called out after him, "Isn't the arrow beyond you?"
- 38 He yelled again, "Hurry! Quickly! Don't just stand there!" Jonathan's servant then picked up the arrow and brought it to his master.
- 38 Then he shouted, "Hurry! Go quickly! Don't stop!" The boy picked up the arrow and returned to his master.
- 39 The boy, of course, knew nothing of what was going on. Only Jonathan and David knew.
- 39 (The boy knew nothing of all this; only Jonathan and David knew.)
- 40 Jonathan gave his quiver and bow to the boy and sent him back to town.
- 40 Then Jonathan gave his weapons to the boy and said, "Go, carry them back to town."
- 41 After the servant was gone, David got up from his hiding place beside the boulder, then fell on his face to the ground--three times prostrating himself! And then they kissed one another and wept, friend over friend, David weeping especially hard.
- 41 After the boy had gone, David got up from the south side of the stone and bowed down before Jonathan three times, with his face to the ground. Then they kissed each other and wept together--but David wept the most.

- 42 Jonathan said, "Go in peace! The two of us have vowed friendship in GOD's name, saying, 'GOD will be the bond between me and you, and between my children and your children forever!'"
- 42 Jonathan said to David, "Go in peace, for we have sworn friendship with each other in the name of the LORD, saying, 'The LORD is witness between you and me, and between your descendants and my descendants forever.' " Then David left, and Jonathan went back to the town.

1 Samuel 21

MSG

NIV

- 1 David went on his way and Jonathan returned to town. David went to Nob, to Ahimelech the Priest. Ahimelech was alarmed as he went out to greet David: "What are you doing here all by yourself--and not a soul with you?"
- 1 David went to Nob, to Ahimelech the priest. Ahimelech trembled when he met him, and asked, "Why are you alone? Why is no one with you?"
- 2 David answered Ahimelech the Priest, "The king sent me on a mission and gave strict orders: 'This is top secret--not a word of this to a soul.' I've arranged to meet up with my men in a certain place.
- 2 David answered Ahimelech the priest, "The king charged me with a certain matter and said to me, 'No one is to know anything about your mission and your instructions.' As for my men, I have told them to meet me at a certain place.
- 3 Now, what's there here to eat? Do you have five loaves of bread? Give me whatever you can scrounge up!"
- 3 Now then, what do you have on hand? Give me five loaves of bread, or whatever you can find."
- 4 "I don't have any regular bread on hand," said the priest. "I only have holy bread. If your men have not slept with women recently, it's yours."
- 4 But the priest answered David, "I don't have any ordinary bread on hand; however, there is some consecrated bread here--provided the men have kept themselves from women."
- 5 David said, "None of us has touched a woman. I always do it this way when I'm on a mission: My men abstain from sex. Even when it is an

ordinary mission we do that--how much more on this holy mission."

- 5 David replied, "Indeed women have been kept from us, as usual whenever I set out. The men's things are holy even on missions that are not holy. How much more so today!"
- 6 So the priest gave them the holy bread. It was the only bread he had, Bread of the Presence that had been removed from GOD's presence and replaced by fresh bread at the same time.
- 6 So the priest gave him the consecrated bread, since there was no bread there except the bread of the Presence that had been removed from before the LORD and replaced by hot bread on the day it was taken away.
- 7 One of Saul's officials was present that day keeping a religious vow. His name was Doeg the Edomite. He was chief of Saul's shepherds.
- 7 Now one of Saul's servants was there that day, detained before the LORD; he was Doeg the Edomite, Saul's head shepherd.
- 8 David asked Ahimelech, "Do you have a spear or sword of any kind around here? I didn't have a chance to grab my weapons. The king's mission was urgent and I left in a hurry."
- 8 David asked Ahimelech, "Don't you have a spear or a sword here? I haven't brought my sword or any other weapon, because the king's business was urgent."
- 9 The priest said, "The sword of Goliath, the Philistine you killed at Oak Valley--that's here! It's behind the Ephod wrapped in a cloth. If you want it, take it. There's nothing else here."
- 9 The priest replied, "The sword of Goliath the Philistine, whom you killed in the Valley of Elah, is here; it is wrapped in a cloth behind the ephod. If you want it, take it; there is no sword here but that one." David said, "There is none like it; give it to me."
- 10 "Oh," said David, "there's no sword like that! Give it to me!" And at that, David shot out of there, running for his life from Saul. He went to Achish, king of Gath.
- 10 That day David fled from Saul and went to Achish king of Gath.
- 11 When the servants of Achish saw him, they said, "Can this be David, the famous David? Is this the one they sing of at their dances? Saul kills by the thousand, David by the ten thousand!"

- 11 But the servants of Achish said to him, "Isn't this David, the king of the land? Isn't he the one they sing about in their dances: " 'Saul has slain his thousands, and David his tens of thousands'?"
- 12 When David realized that he had been recognized, he panicked, fearing the worst from Achish, king of Gath.
- 12 David took these words to heart and was very much afraid of Achish king of Gath.
- 13 So right there, while they were looking at him, he pretended to go crazy, pounding his head on the city gate and foaming at the mouth, spit dripping from his beard.
- 13 So he pretended to be insane in their presence; and while he was in their hands he acted like a madman, making marks on the doors of the gate and letting saliva run down his beard.
- 14 Achish took one look at him and said to his servants, "Can't you see he's crazy? Why did you let him in here?"
- 14 Achish said to his servants, "Look at the man! He is insane! Why bring him to me?"
- 15 Don't you think I have enough crazy people to put up with as it is without adding another? Get him out of here!"
- 15 Am I so short of madmen that you have to bring this fellow here to carry on like this in front of me? Must this man come into my house?"

1 Samuel 22

MSG

NIV

- 1 So David got away and escaped to the Cave of Adullam. When his brothers and others associated with his family heard where he was, they came down and joined him.
- 1 David left Gath and escaped to the cave of Adullam. When his brothers and his father's household heard about it, they went down to him there.
- 2 Not only that, but all who were down on their luck came around--losers and vagrants and misfits of all sorts. David became their leader. There were about four hundred in all.
- 2 All those who were in distress or in debt or discontented gathered around him, and he became their leader. About four hundred men were with

him.

- 3 Then David went to Mizpah in Moab. He petitioned the king of Moab, "Grant asylum to my father and mother until I find out what God has planned for me."
- 3 From there David went to Mizpah in Moab and said to the king of Moab, "Would you let my father and mother come and stay with you until I learn what God will do for me?"
- 4 David left his parents in the care of the king of Moab. They stayed there all through the time David was hiding out.
- 4 So he left them with the king of Moab, and they stayed with him as long as David was in the stronghold.
- 5 The prophet Gad told David, "Don't go back to the cave. Go to Judah." David did what he told him. He went to the forest of Hereth.
- 5 But the prophet Gad said to David, "Do not stay in the stronghold. Go into the land of Judah." So David left and went to the forest of Hereth.
- 6 Saul got word of the whereabouts of David and his men. He was sitting under the big oak on the hill at Gibeah at the time, spear in hand, holding court surrounded by his officials.
- 6 Now Saul heard that David and his men had been discovered. And Saul, spear in hand, was seated under the tamarisk tree on the hill at Gibeah, with all his officials standing around him.
- 7 He said, "Listen here, you Benjaminites! Don't think for a minute that you have any future with the son of Jesse! Do you think he's going to hand over choice land, give you all influential jobs?"
- 7 Saul said to them, "Listen, men of Benjamin! Will the son of Jesse give all of you fields and vineyards? Will he make all of you commanders of thousands and commanders of hundreds?"
- 8 Think again. Here you are, conspiring against me, whispering behind my back--not one of you is man enough to tell me that my own son is making deals with the son of Jesse, not one of you who cares enough to tell me that my son has taken the side of this, this . . . outlaw!"
- 8 Is that why you have all conspired against me? No one tells me when my son makes a covenant with the son of Jesse. None of you is concerned about me or tells me that my son has incited my servant to lie in wait for me, as he does today."

- 9 Then Doeg the Edomite, who was standing with Saul's officials, spoke up: "I saw the son of Jesse meet with Ahimelech son of Ahitub, in Nob.
- 9 But Doeg the Edomite, who was standing with Saul's officials, said, "I saw the son of Jesse come to Ahimelech son of Ahitub at Nob.
- 10 I saw Ahimelech pray with him for GOD's guidance, give him food, and arm him with the sword of Goliath the Philistine."
- 10 Ahimelech inquired of the LORD for him; he also gave him provisions and the sword of Goliath the Philistine."
- 11 Saul sent for the priest Ahimelech son of Ahitub, along with the whole family of priests at Nob. They all came to the king.
- 11 Then the king sent for the priest Ahimelech son of Ahitub and his father's whole family, who were the priests at Nob, and they all came to the king.
- 12 Saul said, "You listen to me, son of Ahitub!" "Certainly, master," he said.
- 12 Saul said, "Listen now, son of Ahitub." "Yes, my lord," he answered.
- 13 "Why have you ganged up against me with the son of Jesse, giving him bread and a sword, even praying with him for GOD's guidance, setting him up as an outlaw, out to get me?"
- 13 Saul said to him, "Why have you conspired against me, you and the son of Jesse, giving him bread and a sword and inquiring of God for him, so that he has rebelled against me and lies in wait for me, as he does today?"
- 14 Ahimelech answered the king, "There's not an official in your administration as true to you as David, your own son-in-law and captain of your bodyguard. None more honorable either.
- 14 Ahimelech answered the king, "Who of all your servants is as loyal as David, the king's son-in-law, captain of your bodyguard and highly respected in your household?
- 15 Do you think that was the first time I prayed with him for God's guidance? Hardly! But don't accuse me of any wrongdoing, me or my family. I have no idea what you're trying to get at with this 'outlaw' talk."
- 15 Was that day the first time I inquired of God for him? Of course not! Let not the king accuse your servant or any of his father's family, for your servant knows nothing at all about this whole affair."

- 16 The king said, "Death, Ahimelech! You're going to die--you and everyone in your family!"
- 16 But the king said, "You will surely die, Ahimelech, you and your father's whole family."
- 17 The king ordered his henchmen, "Surround and kill the priests of GOD! They're hand in glove with David. They knew he was running away from me and didn't tell me." But the king's men wouldn't do it. They refused to lay a hand on the priests of GOD.
- 17 Then the king ordered the guards at his side: "Turn and kill the priests of the LORD, because they too have sided with David. They knew he was fleeing, yet they did not tell me." But the king's officials were not willing to raise a hand to strike the priests of the LORD.
- 18 Then the king told Doeg, "You do it--massacre the priests!" Doeg the Edomite led the attack and slaughtered the priests, the eighty-five men who wore the sacred robes.
- 18 The king then ordered Doeg, "You turn and strike down the priests." So Doeg the Edomite turned and struck them down. That day he killed eighty-five men who wore the linen ephod.
- 19 He then carried the massacre into Nob, the city of priests, killing man and woman, child and baby, ox, donkey, and sheep--the works.
- 19 He also put to the sword Nob, the town of the priests, with its men and women, its children and infants, and its cattle, donkeys and sheep.
- 20 Only one son of Ahimelech son of Ahitub escaped: Abiathar. He got away and joined up with David.
- 20 But Abiathar, a son of Ahimelech son of Ahitub, escaped and fled to join David.
- 21 Abiathar reported to David that Saul had murdered the priests of GOD.
- 21 He told David that Saul had killed the priests of the LORD.
- 22 David said to Abiathar, "I knew it--that day I saw Doeg the Edomite there, I knew he'd tell Saul. I'm to blame for the death of everyone in your father's family.
- 22 Then David said to Abiathar: "That day, when Doeg the Edomite was there, I knew he would be sure to tell Saul. I am responsible for the death of your father's whole family.
- 23 Stay here with me. Don't be afraid. The one out to kill you is out to kill me, too. Stick with me. I'll protect you."

23 Stay with me; don't be afraid; the man who is seeking your life is seeking mine also. You will be safe with me."

1 Samuel 23

MSG

NIV

- 1 It was reported to David that the Philistines were raiding Keilah and looting the grain.
- 1 When David was told, "Look, the Philistines are fighting against Keilah and are looting the threshing floors,"
- 2 David went in prayer to GOD: "Should I go after these Philistines and teach them a lesson?" GOD said, "Go. Attack the Philistines and save Keilah."
- 2 he inquired of the LORD, saying, "Shall I go and attack these Philistines?" The LORD answered him, "Go, attack the Philistines and save Keilah."
- 3 But David's men said, "We live in fear of our lives right here in Judah. How can you think of going to Keilah in the thick of the Philistines?"
- 3 But David's men said to him, "Here in Judah we are afraid. How much more, then, if we go to Keilah against the Philistine forces!"
- 4 So David went back to GOD in prayer. GOD said, "Get going. Head for Keilah. I'm placing the Philistines in your hands."
- 4 Once again David inquired of the LORD, and the LORD answered him, "Go down to Keilah, for I am going to give the Philistines into your hand."
- 5 David and his men went to Keilah and fought the Philistines. He scattered their cattle, beat them decisively, and saved the people of Keilah.
- 5 So David and his men went to Keilah, fought the Philistines and carried off their livestock. He inflicted heavy losses on the Philistines and saved the people of Keilah.
- 6 After Abiathar took refuge with David, he joined David in the raid on Keilah, bringing the Ephod with him.
- 6 (Now Abiathar son of Ahimelech had brought the ephod down with him when he fled to David at Keilah.)

- 7 Saul learned that David had gone to Keilah and thought immediately, "Good! God has handed him to me on a platter! He's in a walled city with locked gates, trapped!"
- 7 Saul was told that David had gone to Keilah, and he said, "God has handed him over to me, for David has imprisoned himself by entering a town with gates and bars."
- 8 Saul mustered his troops for battle and set out for Keilah to lay siege to David and his men.
- 8 And Saul called up all his forces for battle, to go down to Keilah to besiege David and his men.
- 9 But David got wind of Saul's strategy to destroy him and said to Abiathar the priest, "Get the Ephod."
- 9 When David learned that Saul was plotting against him, he said to Abiathar the priest, "Bring the ephod."
- 10 Then David prayed to GOD: "God of Israel, I've just heard that Saul plans to come to Keilah and destroy the city because of me.
- 10 David said, "O LORD, God of Israel, your servant has heard definitely that Saul plans to come to Keilah and destroy the town on account of me.
- 11 Will the city fathers of Keilah turn me over to him? Will Saul come down and do what I've heard? O GOD, God of Israel, tell me!" GOD replied, "He's coming down."
- 11 Will the citizens of Keilah surrender me to him? Will Saul come down, as your servant has heard? O LORD, God of Israel, tell your servant." And the LORD said, "He will."
- 12 "And will the head men of Keilah turn me and my men over to Saul?" And GOD said, "They'll turn you over."
- 12 Again David asked, "Will the citizens of Keilah surrender me and my men to Saul?" And the LORD said, "They will."
- 13 So David and his men got out of there. There were about six hundred of them. They left Keilah and kept moving, going here, there, wherever--always on the move. When Saul was told that David had escaped from Keilah, he called off the raid.
- 13 So David and his men, about six hundred in number, left Keilah and kept moving from place to place. When Saul was told that David had escaped from Keilah, he did not go there.

- 14 David continued to live in desert hideouts and the backcountry wilderness hills of Ziph. Saul was out looking for him day after day, but God never turned David over to him.
- 14 David stayed in the desert strongholds and in the hills of the Desert of Ziph. Day after day Saul searched for him, but God did not give David into his hands.
- 15 David kept out of the way in the wilderness of Ziph, secluded at Horesh, since it was plain that Saul was determined to hunt him down.
- 15 While David was at Horesh in the Desert of Ziph, he learned that Saul had come out to take his life.
- 16 Jonathan, Saul's son, visited David at Horesh and encouraged him in God.
- 16 And Saul's son Jonathan went to David at Horesh and helped him find strength in God.
- 17 He said, "Don't despair. My father, Saul, can't lay a hand on you. You will be Israel's king and I'll be right at your side to help. And my father knows it."
- 17 Don't be afraid, he said. "My father Saul will not lay a hand on you. You will be king over Israel, and I will be second to you. Even my father Saul knows this."
- 18 Then the two of them made a covenant before GOD. David stayed at Horesh and Jonathan went home.
- 18 The two of them made a covenant before the LORD. Then Jonathan went home, but David remained at Horesh.
- 19 Some Ziphites went to Saul at Gibeah and said, "Did you know that David is hiding out near us in the caves and canyons of Horesh? Right now he's at Hakilah Hill just south of Jeshimon.
- 19 The Ziphites went up to Saul at Gibeah and said, "Is not David hiding among us in the strongholds at Horesh, on the hill of Hakilah, south of Jeshimon?
- 20 So whenever you're ready to come down, we'd count it an honor to hand him over to the king."
- 20 Now, O king, come down whenever it pleases you to do so, and we will be responsible for handing him over to the king."
- 21 Saul said, "GOD bless you for thinking about me!
- 21 Saul replied, "The LORD bless you for your concern for me.

- 22 Now go back and check everything out. Learn his routines. Observe his movements--where he goes, who he's with. He's very shrewd, you know.
- 22 Go and make further preparation. Find out where David usually goes and who has seen him there. They tell me he is very crafty.
- 23 Scout out all his hiding places. Then meet me at Nacon and I'll go with you. If he is anywhere to be found in all the thousands of Judah, I'll track him down!"
- 23 Find out about all the hiding places he uses and come back to me with definite information. Then I will go with you; if he is in the area, I will track him down among all the clans of Judah."
- 24 So the Ziphites set out on their reconnaissance for Saul. Meanwhile, David and his men were in the wilderness of Maon, in the desert south of Jeshimon.
- 24 So they set out and went to Ziph ahead of Saul. Now David and his men were in the Desert of Maon, in the Arabah south of Jeshimon.
- 25 Saul and his men arrived and began their search. When David heard of it, he went south to Rock Mountain, camping out in the wilderness of Maon. Saul heard where he was and set off for the wilderness of Maon in pursuit.
- 25 Saul and his men began the search, and when David was told about it, he went down to the rock and stayed in the Desert of Maon. When Saul heard this, he went into the Desert of Maon in pursuit of David.
- 26 Saul was on one side of the mountain, David and his men on the other. David was in full retreat, running, with Saul and his men closing in, about to get him.
- 26 Saul was going along one side of the mountain, and David and his men were on the other side, hurrying to get away from Saul. As Saul and his forces were closing in on David and his men to capture them,
- 27 Just then a messenger came to Saul and said, "Hurry! Come back! The Philistines have just attacked the country!"
- 27 a messenger came to Saul, saying, "Come quickly! The Philistines are raiding the land."
- 28 So Saul called off his pursuit of David and went back to deal with the Philistines. That's how that place got the name Narrow Escape.
- 28 Then Saul broke off his pursuit of David and went to meet the Philistines. That is why they call this place Sela Hammahlekoth.

- 29 David left there and camped out in the caves and canyons of En Gedi.
29 And David went up from there and lived in the strongholds of En Gedi.

1 Samuel 24

MSG

NIV

- 1 When Saul came back after dealing with the Philistines, he was told, "David is now in the wilderness of En Gedi."
- 1 After Saul returned from pursuing the Philistines, he was told, "David is in the Desert of En Gedi."
- 2 Saul took three companies--the best he could find in all Israel--and set out in search of David and his men in the region of Wild Goat Rocks.
- 2 So Saul took three thousand chosen men from all Israel and set out to look for David and his men near the Crags of the Wild Goats.
- 3 He came to some sheep pens along the road. There was a cave there and Saul went in to relieve himself. David and his men were huddled far back in the same cave.
- 3 He came to the sheep pens along the way; a cave was there, and Saul went in to relieve himself. David and his men were far back in the cave.
- 4 David's men whispered to him, "Can you believe it? This is the day GOD was talking about when he said, 'I'll put your enemy in your hands. You can do whatever you want with him.'" Quiet as a cat, David crept up and cut off a piece of Saul's royal robe.
- 4 The men said, "This is the day the LORD spoke of when he said to you, 'I will give your enemy into your hands for you to deal with as you wish.' " Then David crept up unnoticed and cut off a corner of Saul's robe.
- 5 Immediately, he felt guilty.
- 5 Afterward, David was conscience-stricken for having cut off a corner of his robe.
- 6 He said to his men, "GOD forbid that I should have done this to my master, GOD's anointed, that I should so much as raise a finger against him. He's GOD's anointed!"
- 6 He said to his men, "The LORD forbid that I should do such a thing to my master, the LORD's anointed, or lift my hand against him; for he is

the anointed of the LORD."

- 7 David held his men in check with these words and wouldn't let them pounce on Saul. Saul got up, left the cave, and went on down the road.
- 7 With these words David rebuked his men and did not allow them to attack Saul. And Saul left the cave and went his way.
- 8 Then David stood at the mouth of the cave and called to Saul, "My master! My king!" Saul looked back. David fell to his knees and bowed in reverence.
- 8 Then David went out of the cave and called out to Saul, "My lord the king!" When Saul looked behind him, David bowed down and prostrated himself with his face to the ground.
- 9 He called out, "Why do you listen to those who say 'David is out to get you'?"
- 9 He said to Saul, "Why do you listen when men say, 'David is bent on harming you'?"
- 10 This very day with your very own eyes you have seen that just now in the cave GOD put you in my hands. My men wanted me to kill you, but I wouldn't do it. I told them that I won't lift a finger against my master--he's GOD's anointed.
- 10 This day you have seen with your own eyes how the LORD delivered you into my hands in the cave. Some urged me to kill you, but I spared you; I said, 'I will not lift my hand against my master, because he is the LORD's anointed.'
- 11 Oh, my father, look at this, look at this piece that I cut from your robe. I could have cut you--killed you!--but I didn't. Look at the evidence! I'm not against you. I'm no rebel. I haven't sinned against you, and yet you're hunting me down to kill me.
- 11 See, my father, look at this piece of your robe in my hand! I cut off the corner of your robe but did not kill you. Now understand and recognize that I am not guilty of wrongdoing or rebellion. I have not wronged you, but you are hunting me down to take my life.
- 12 Let's decide which of us is in the right. God may avenge me, but it is in his hands, not mine.
- 12 May the LORD judge between you and me. And may the LORD avenge the wrongs you have done to me, but my hand will not touch you.

- 13 An old proverb says, 'Evil deeds come from evil people.' So be assured that my hand won't touch you.
- 13 As the old saying goes, 'From evildoers come evil deeds,' so my hand will not touch you.
- 14 "What does the king of Israel think he's doing? Who do you think you're chasing? A dead dog? A flea?
- 14 Against whom has the king of Israel come out? Whom are you pursuing? A dead dog? A flea?
- 15 GOD is our judge. He'll decide who is right. Oh, that he would look down right now, decide right now--and set me free of you!"
- 15 May the LORD be our judge and decide between us. May he consider my cause and uphold it; may he vindicate me by delivering me from your hand."
- 16 When David had finished saying all this, Saul said, "Can this be the voice of my son David?" and he wept in loud sobs.
- 16 When David finished saying this, Saul asked, "Is that your voice, David my son?" And he wept aloud.
- 17 "You're the one in the right, not me," he continued. "You've heaped good on me; I've dumped evil on you.
- 17 You are more righteous than I, he said. "You have treated me well, but I have treated you badly.
- 18 And now you've done it again--treated me generously. GOD put me in your hands and you didn't kill me.
- 18 You have just now told me of the good you did to me; the LORD delivered me into your hands, but you did not kill me.
- 19 Why? When a man meets his enemy, does he send him down the road with a blessing? May GOD give you a bonus of blessings for what you've done for me today!
- 19 When a man finds his enemy, does he let him get away unharmed? May the LORD reward you well for the way you treated me today.
- 20 I know now beyond doubt that you will rule as king. The kingdom of Israel is already in your grasp!
- 20 I know that you will surely be king and that the kingdom of Israel will be established in your hands.
- 21 Now promise me under GOD that you will not kill off my family or wipe my name off the books."

- 21 Now swear to me by the LORD that you will not cut off my descendants or wipe out my name from my father's family."
- 22 David promised Saul. Then Saul went home and David and his men went up to their wilderness refuge.
- 22 So David gave his oath to Saul. Then Saul returned home, but David and his men went up to the stronghold.

1 Samuel 25

MSG

NIV

- 1 Samuel died. The whole country came to his funeral. Everyone grieved over his death, and he was buried in his hometown of Ramah. Meanwhile, David moved again, this time to the wilderness of Maon.
- 1 Now Samuel died, and all Israel assembled and mourned for him; and they buried him at his home in Ramah. Then David moved down into the Desert of Maon.
- 2 There was a certain man in Maon who carried on his business in the region of Carmel. He was very prosperous--three thousand sheep and a thousand goats, and it was sheep-shearing time in Carmel.
- 2 A certain man in Maon, who had property there at Carmel, was very wealthy. He had a thousand goats and three thousand sheep, which he was shearing in Carmel.
- 3 The man's name was Nabal (Fool), a Calebite, and his wife's name was Abigail. The woman was intelligent and good-looking, the man brutish and mean.
- 3 His name was Nabal and his wife's name was Abigail. She was an intelligent and beautiful woman, but her husband, a Calebite, was surly and mean in his dealings.
- 4 David, out in the backcountry, heard that Nabal was shearing his sheep
- 4 While David was in the desert, he heard that Nabal was shearing sheep.
- 5 and sent ten of his young men off with these instructions: "Go to Carmel and approach Nabal. Greet him in my name, 'Peace!'"
- 5 So he sent ten young men and said to them, "Go up to Nabal at Carmel and greet him in my name.
- 6 Life and peace to you. Peace to your household, peace to everyone here!

- 6 Say to him: 'Long life to you! Good health to you and your household! And good health to all that is yours!
- 7 I heard that it's sheep-shearing time. Here's the point: When your shepherds were camped near us we didn't take advantage of them. They didn't lose a thing all the time they were with us in Carmel.
- 7 'Now I hear that it is sheep-shearing time. When your shepherds were with us, we did not mistreat them, and the whole time they were at Carmel nothing of theirs was missing.
- 8 Ask your young men--they'll tell you. What I'm asking is that you be generous with my men--share the feast! Give whatever your heart tells you to your servants and to me, David your son."
- 8 Ask your own servants and they will tell you. Therefore be favorable toward my young men, since we come at a festive time. Please give your servants and your son David whatever you can find for them.' "
- 9 David's young men went and delivered his message word for word to Nabal. Nabal tore into them,
- 9 When David's men arrived, they gave Nabal this message in David's name. Then they waited.
- 10 "Who is this David? Who is this son of Jesse? The country is full of runaway servants these days.
- 10 Nabal answered David's servants, "Who is this David? Who is this son of Jesse? Many servants are breaking away from their masters these days.
- 11 Do you think I'm going to take good bread and wine and meat freshly butchered for my sheepshearers and give it to men I've never laid eyes on? Who knows where they've come from?"
- 11 Why should I take my bread and water, and the meat I have slaughtered for my shearers, and give it to men coming from who knows where?"
- 12 David's men got out of there and went back and told David what he had said.
- 12 David's men turned around and went back. When they arrived, they reported every word.
- 13 David said, "Strap on your swords!" They all strapped on their swords, David and his men, and set out, four hundred of them. Two hundred stayed behind to guard the camp.

- 13 David said to his men, "Put on your swords!" So they put on their swords, and David put on his. About four hundred men went up with David, while two hundred stayed with the supplies.
- 14 Meanwhile, one of the young shepherds told Abigail, Nabal's wife, what had happened: "David sent messengers from the backcountry to salute our master, but he tore into them with insults.
- 14 One of the servants told Nabal's wife Abigail: "David sent messengers from the desert to give our master his greetings, but he hurled insults at them.
- 15 Yet these men treated us very well. They took nothing from us and didn't take advantage of us all the time we were in the fields.
- 15 Yet these men were very good to us. They did not mistreat us, and the whole time we were out in the fields near them nothing was missing.
- 16 They formed a wall around us, protecting us day and night all the time we were out tending the sheep.
- 16 Night and day they were a wall around us all the time we were herding our sheep near them.
- 17 Do something quickly because big trouble is ahead for our master and all of us. Nobody can talk to him. He's impossible--a real brute!"
- 17 Now think it over and see what you can do, because disaster is hanging over our master and his whole household. He is such a wicked man that no one can talk to him."
- 18 Abigail flew into action. She took two hundred loaves of bread, two skins of wine, five sheep dressed out and ready for cooking, a bushel of roasted grain, a hundred raisin cakes, and two hundred fig cakes, and she had it all loaded on some donkeys.
- 18 Abigail lost no time. She took two hundred loaves of bread, two skins of wine, five dressed sheep, five seahs of roasted grain, a hundred cakes of raisins and two hundred cakes of pressed figs, and loaded them on donkeys.
- 19 Then she said to her young servants, "Go ahead and pave the way for me. I'm right behind you." But she said nothing to her husband Nabal.
- 19 Then she told her servants, "Go on ahead; I'll follow you." But she did not tell her husband Nabal.
- 20 As she was riding her donkey, descending into a ravine, David and his men were descending from the other end, so they met there on the road.

- 20 As she came riding her donkey into a mountain ravine, there were David and his men descending toward her, and she met them.
- 21 David had just said, "That sure was a waste, guarding everything this man had out in the wild so that nothing he had was lost--and now he rewards me with insults. A real slap in the face!
- 21 David had just said, "It's been useless--all my watching over this fellow's property in the desert so that nothing of his was missing. He has paid me back evil for good.
- 22 May God do his worst to me if Nabal and every cur in his misbegotten brood isn't dead meat by morning!"
- 22 May God deal with David, be it ever so severely, if by morning I leave alive one male of all who belong to him!"
- 23 As soon as Abigail saw David, she got off her donkey and fell on her knees at his feet, her face to the ground in homage,
- 23 When Abigail saw David, she quickly got off her donkey and bowed down before David with her face to the ground.
- 24 saying, "My master, let me take the blame! Let me speak to you. Listen to what I have to say.
- 24 She fell at his feet and said: "My lord, let the blame be on me alone. Please let your servant speak to you; hear what your servant has to say.
- 25 Don't dwell on what that brute Nabal did. He acts out the meaning of his name: Nabal, Fool. Foolishness oozes from him. "I wasn't there when the young men my master sent arrived. I didn't see them.
- 25 May my lord pay no attention to that wicked man Nabal. He is just like his name--his name is Fool, and folly goes with him. But as for me, your servant, I did not see the men my master sent.
- 26 And now, my master, as GOD lives and as you live, GOD has kept you from this avenging murder--and may your enemies, all who seek my master's harm, end up like Nabal!
- 26 Now since the LORD has kept you, my master, from bloodshed and from avenging yourself with your own hands, as surely as the LORD lives and as you live, may your enemies and all who intend to harm my master be like Nabal.
- 27 Now take this gift that I, your servant girl, have brought to my master, and give it to the young men who follow in the steps of my master.

- 27 And let this gift, which your servant has brought to my master, be given to the men who follow you.
- 28 "Forgive my presumption! But GOD is at work in my master, developing a rule solid and dependable. My master fights GOD's battles! As long as you live no evil will stick to you.
- 28 Please forgive your servant's offense, for the LORD will certainly make a lasting dynasty for my master, because he fights the LORD's battles. Let no wrongdoing be found in you as long as you live.
- 29 If anyone stands in your way, if anyone tries to get you out of the way, Know this: Your God-honored life is tightly bound in the bundle of God-protected life; But the lives of your enemies will be hurled aside as a stone is thrown from a sling.
- 29 Even though someone is pursuing you to take your life, the life of my master will be bound securely in the bundle of the living by the LORD your God. But the lives of your enemies he will hurl away as from the pocket of a sling.
- 30 "When GOD completes all the goodness he has promised my master and sets you up as prince over Israel,
- 30 When the LORD has done for my master every good thing he promised concerning him and has appointed him leader over Israel,
- 31 my master will not have this dead weight in his heart, the guilt of an avenging murder. And when GOD has worked things for good for my master, remember me."
- 31 my master will not have on his conscience the staggering burden of needless bloodshed or of having avenged himself. And when the LORD has brought my master success, remember your servant."
- 32 And David said, "Blessed be GOD, the God of Israel. He sent you to meet me!
- 32 David said to Abigail, "Praise be to the LORD, the God of Israel, who has sent you today to meet me.
- 33 And blessed be your good sense! Bless you for keeping me from murder and taking charge of looking out for me.
- 33 May you be blessed for your good judgment and for keeping me from bloodshed this day and from avenging myself with my own hands.
- 34 A close call! As GOD lives, the God of Israel who kept me from hurting you, if you had not come as quickly as you did, stopping me in my

tracks, by morning there would have been nothing left of Nabal but dead meat."

34 Otherwise, as surely as the LORD, the God of Israel, lives, who has kept me from harming you, if you had not come quickly to meet me, not one male belonging to Nabal would have been left alive by daybreak."

35 Then David accepted the gift she brought him and said, "Return home in peace. I've heard what you've said and I'll do what you've asked."

35 Then David accepted from her hand what she had brought him and said, "Go home in peace. I have heard your words and granted your request."

36 When Abigail got home she found Nabal presiding over a huge banquet. He was in high spirits--and very, very drunk. So she didn't tell him anything of what she'd done until morning.

36 When Abigail went to Nabal, he was in the house holding a banquet like that of a king. He was in high spirits and very drunk. So she told him nothing until daybreak.

37 But in the morning, after Nabal had sobered up, she told him the whole story. Right then and there he had a heart attack and fell into a coma.

37 Then in the morning, when Nabal was sober, his wife told him all these things, and his heart failed him and he became like a stone.

38 About ten days later GOD finished him off and he died.

38 About ten days later, the LORD struck Nabal and he died.

39 When David heard that Nabal was dead he said, "Blessed be GOD who has stood up for me against Nabal's insults, kept me from an evil act, and let Nabal's evil boomerang back on him." Then David sent for Abigail to tell her that he wanted her for his wife.

39 When David heard that Nabal was dead, he said, "Praise be to the LORD, who has upheld my cause against Nabal for treating me with contempt. He has kept his servant from doing wrong and has brought Nabal's wrongdoing down on his own head." Then David sent word to Abigail, asking her to become his wife.

40 David's servants went to Abigail at Carmel with the message, "David sent us to bring you to marry him."

40 His servants went to Carmel and said to Abigail, "David has sent us to you to take you to become his wife."

41 She got up, and then bowed down, face to the ground, saying, "I'm your servant, ready to do anything you want. I'll even wash the feet of my

master's servants!"

- 41 She bowed down with her face to the ground and said, "Here is your maidservant, ready to serve you and wash the feet of my master's servants."
- 42 Abigail didn't linger. She got on her donkey and, with her five maids in attendance, went with the messengers to David and became his wife.
- 42 Abigail quickly got on a donkey and, attended by her five maids, went with David's messengers and became his wife.
- 43 David also married Ahinoam of Jezreel. Both women were his wives.
- 43 David had also married Ahinoam of Jezreel, and they both were his wives.
- 44 Saul had married off David's wife Michal to Palti (Paltiel) son of Laish, who was from Gallim.
- 44 But Saul had given his daughter Michal, David's wife, to Paltiel son of Laish, who was from Gallim.

1 Samuel 26

MSG

NIV

- 1 Some Ziphites came to Saul at Gibeah and said, "Did you know that David is hiding out on the Hakilah Hill just opposite Jeshimon?"
- 1 The Ziphites went to Saul at Gibeah and said, "Is not David hiding on the hill of Hakilah, which faces Jeshimon?"
- 2 Saul was on his feet in a minute and on his way to the wilderness of Ziph, taking three thousand of his best men, the pick of the crop, to hunt for David in that wild desert.
- 2 So Saul went down to the Desert of Ziph, with his three thousand chosen men of Israel, to search there for David.
- 3 He camped just off the road at the Hakilah Hill, opposite Jeshimon. David, still out in the backcountry, knew Saul had come after him.
- 3 Saul made his camp beside the road on the hill of Hakilah facing Jeshimon, but David stayed in the desert. When he saw that Saul had followed him there,
- 4 He sent scouts to determine his precise location.
- 4 he sent out scouts and learned that Saul had definitely arrived.

- 5 Then David set out and came to the place where Saul had set up camp and saw for himself where Saul and Abner, son of Ner, his general, were staying. Saul was safely inside the camp, encircled by the army.
- 5 Then David set out and went to the place where Saul had camped. He saw where Saul and Abner son of Ner, the commander of the army, had lain down. Saul was lying inside the camp, with the army encamped around him.
- 6 Taking charge, David spoke to Ahimelech the Hittite and to Abishai son of Zeruiah, Joab's brother: "Who will go down with me and enter Saul's camp?" Abishai whispered, "I'll go with you."
- 6 David then asked Ahimelech the Hittite and Abishai son of Zeruiah, Joab's brother, "Who will go down into the camp with me to Saul?" "I'll go with you," said Abishai.
- 7 So David and Abishai entered the encampment by night, and there he was--Saul, stretched out asleep at the center of the camp, his spear stuck in the ground near his head, with Abner and the troops sound asleep on all sides.
- 7 So David and Abishai went to the army by night, and there was Saul, lying asleep inside the camp with his spear stuck in the ground near his head. Abner and the soldiers were lying around him.
- 8 Abishai said, "This is the moment! God has put your enemy in your grasp. Let me nail him to the ground with his spear. One hit will do it, believe me; I won't need a second!"
- 8 Abishai said to David, "Today God has delivered your enemy into your hands. Now let me pin him to the ground with one thrust of my spear; I won't strike him twice."
- 9 But David said to Abishai, "Don't you dare hurt him! Who could lay a hand on GOD's anointed and even think of getting away with it?"
- 9 But David said to Abishai, "Don't destroy him! Who can lay a hand on the LORD's anointed and be guiltless?"
- 10 He went on, "As GOD lives, either GOD will strike him, or his time will come and he'll die in bed, or he'll fall in battle,
- 10 As surely as the LORD lives," he said, "the LORD himself will strike him; either his time will come and he will die, or he will go into battle and perish.

- 11 but GOD forbid that I should lay a finger on GOD's anointed. Now, grab the spear at his head and the water jug and let's get out of here."
- 11 But the LORD forbid that I should lay a hand on the LORD's anointed. Now get the spear and water jug that are near his head, and let's go."
- 12 David took the spear and water jug that were right beside Saul's head, and they slipped away. Not a soul saw. Not a soul knew. No one woke up! They all slept through the whole thing. A blanket of deep sleep from GOD had fallen on them.
- 12 So David took the spear and water jug near Saul's head, and they left. No one saw or knew about it, nor did anyone wake up. They were all sleeping, because the LORD had put them into a deep sleep.
- 13 Then David went across to the opposite hill and stood far away on the top of the mountain. With this safe distance between them,
- 13 Then David crossed over to the other side and stood on top of the hill some distance away; there was a wide space between them.
- 14 he shouted across to the army and Abner son of Ner, "Hey Abner! How long do I have to wait for you to wake up and answer me?" Abner said, "Who's calling?"
- 14 He called out to the army and to Abner son of Ner, "Aren't you going to answer me, Abner?" Abner replied, "Who are you who calls to the king?"
- 15 "Aren't you in charge there?" said David. "Why aren't you minding the store? Why weren't you standing guard over your master the king, when a soldier came to kill the king your master?"
- 15 David said, "You're a man, aren't you? And who is like you in Israel? Why didn't you guard your lord the king? Someone came to destroy your lord the king.
- 16 Bad form! As GOD lives, your life should be forfeit, you and the entire bodyguard. Look what I have--the king's spear and water jug that were right beside his head!"
- 16 What you have done is not good. As surely as the LORD lives, you and your men deserve to die, because you did not guard your master, the LORD's anointed. Look around you. Where are the king's spear and water jug that were near his head?"
- 17 By now, Saul had recognized David's voice and said, "Is that you, my son David?" David said, "Yes, it's me, O King, my master.

- 17 Saul recognized David's voice and said, "Is that your voice, David my son?" David replied, "Yes it is, my lord the king."
- 18 Why are you after me, hunting me down? What have I done? What crime have I committed?
- 18 And he added, "Why is my lord pursuing his servant? What have I done, and what wrong am I guilty of?"
- 19 Oh, my master, my king, listen to this from your servant: If GOD has stirred you up against me, then I gladly offer my life as a sacrifice. But if it's men who have done it, let them be banished from GOD's presence! They've expelled me from my rightful place in GOD's heritage, sneering, 'Out of here! Go get a job with some other god!'
- 19 Now let my lord the king listen to his servant's words. If the LORD has incited you against me, then may he accept an offering. If, however, men have done it, may they be cursed before the LORD! They have now driven me from my share in the LORD's inheritance and have said, 'Go, serve other gods.'
- 20 But you're not getting rid of me that easily; you'll not separate me from GOD in life or death. The absurdity! The king of Israel obsessed with a single flea! Hunting me down--a mere partridge--out in the hills!"
- 20 Now do not let my blood fall to the ground far from the presence of the LORD. The king of Israel has come out to look for a flea--as one hunts a partridge in the mountains."
- 21 Saul confessed, "I've sinned! Oh, come back, my dear son David! I won't hurt you anymore. You've honored me this day, treating my life as most precious. And I've acted the fool--a moral dunce, a real clown."
- 21 Then Saul said, "I have sinned. Come back, David my son. Because you considered my life precious today, I will not try to harm you again. Surely I have acted like a fool and have erred greatly."
- 22 David answered, "See what I have here? The king's spear. Let one of your servants come and get it."
- 22 Here is the king's spear, David answered. "Let one of your young men come over and get it."
- 23 It's GOD's business to decide what to do with each of us in regard to what's right and who's loyal. GOD put your life in my hands today, but I wasn't willing to lift a finger against GOD's anointed.

- 23 The LORD rewards every man for his righteousness and faithfulness. The LORD delivered you into my hands today, but I would not lay a hand on the LORD's anointed.
- 24 Just as I honored your life today, may GOD honor my life and rescue me from all trouble."
- 24 As surely as I valued your life today, so may the LORD value my life and deliver me from all trouble."
- 25 Saul said to David, "Bless you, dear son David! Yes, do what you have to do! And, yes, succeed in all you attempt!" Then David went on his way, and Saul went home.
- 25 Then Saul said to David, "May you be blessed, my son David; you will do great things and surely triumph." So David went on his way, and Saul returned home.

1 Samuel 27

MSG

NIV

- 1 David thought to himself, "Sooner or later, Saul's going to get me. The best thing I can do is escape to Philistine country. Saul will count me a lost cause and quit hunting me down in every nook and cranny of Israel. I'll be out of his reach for good."
- 1 But David thought to himself, "One of these days I will be destroyed by the hand of Saul. The best thing I can do is to escape to the land of the Philistines. Then Saul will give up searching for me anywhere in Israel, and I will slip out of his hand."
- 2 So David left; he and his six hundred men went to Achish son of Maach, king of Gath.
- 2 So David and the six hundred men with him left and went over to Achish son of Maach king of Gath.
- 3 They moved in and settled down in Gath, with Achish. Each man brought his household; David brought his two wives, Ahinoam of Jezreel and Abigail, widow of Nabal of Carmel.
- 3 David and his men settled in Gath with Achish. Each man had his family with him, and David had his two wives: Ahinoam of Jezreel and Abigail

of Carmel, the widow of Nabal.

- 4 When Saul was told that David had escaped to Gath, he called off the hunt.
- 4 When Saul was told that David had fled to Gath, he no longer searched for him.
- 5 Then David said to Achish, "If it's agreeable to you, assign me a place in one of the rural villages. It doesn't seem right that I, your mere servant, should be taking up space in the royal city."
- 5 Then David said to Achish, "If I have found favor in your eyes, let a place be assigned to me in one of the country towns, that I may live there. Why should your servant live in the royal city with you?"
- 6 So Achish assigned him Ziklag. (This is how Ziklag got to be what it is now, a city of the kings of Judah.)
- 6 So on that day Achish gave him Ziklag, and it has belonged to the kings of Judah ever since.
- 7 David lived in Philistine country a year and four months.
- 7 David lived in Philistine territory a year and four months.
- 8 From time to time David and his men raided the Geshurites, the Girzites, and the Amalekites--these people were longtime inhabitants of the land stretching toward Shur and on to Egypt.
- 8 Now David and his men went up and raided the Geshurites, the Girzites and the Amalekites. (From ancient times these peoples had lived in the land extending to Shur and Egypt.)
- 9 When David raided an area he left no one alive, neither man nor woman, but took everything else: sheep, cattle, donkeys, camels, clothing--the works. Then he'd return to Achish.
- 9 Whenever David attacked an area, he did not leave a man or woman alive, but took sheep and cattle, donkeys and camels, and clothes. Then he returned to Achish.
- 10 Achish would ask, "And whom did you raid today?" David would tell him, "Oh, the Negev of Judah," or "The Negev of Jerahmeel," or "The Negev of the Kenites."
- 10 When Achish asked, "Where did you go raiding today?" David would say, "Against the Negev of Judah" or "Against the Negev of Jerahmeel" or "Against the Negev of the Kenites."

- 11 He never left a single person alive lest one show up in Gath and report what David had really been doing. This is the way David operated all the time he lived in Philistine country.
- 11 He did not leave a man or woman alive to be brought to Gath, for he thought, "They might inform on us and say, 'This is what David did.' " And such was his practice as long as he lived in Philistine territory.
- 12 Achish came to trust David completely. He thought, "He's made himself so repugnant to his people that he'll be in my camp forever."
- 12 Achish trusted David and said to himself, "He has become so odious to his people, the Israelites, that he will be my servant forever."

1 Samuel 28

MSG

NIV

- 1 During this time the Philistines mustered their troops to make war on Israel. Achish said to David, "You can count on this: You're marching with my troops, you and your men."
- 1 In those days the Philistines gathered their forces to fight against Israel. Achish said to David, "You must understand that you and your men will accompany me in the army."
- 2 And David said, "Good! Now you'll see for yourself what I can do!" "Great!" said Achish. "I'm making you my personal bodyguard--for life!"
- 2 David said, "Then you will see for yourself what your servant can do." Achish replied, "Very well, I will make you my bodyguard for life."
- 3 Samuel was now dead. All Israel had mourned his death and buried him in Ramah, his hometown. Saul had long since cleaned out all those who held seances with the dead.
- 3 Now Samuel was dead, and all Israel had mourned for him and buried him in his own town of Ramah. Saul had expelled the mediums and spiritists from the land.
- 4 The Philistines had mustered their troops and camped at Shunem. Saul had assembled all Israel and camped at Gilboa.
- 4 The Philistines assembled and came and set up camp at Shunem, while Saul gathered all the Israelites and set up camp at Gilboa.

- 5 But when Saul saw the Philistine troops, he shook in his boots, scared to death.
- 5 When Saul saw the Philistine army, he was afraid; terror filled his heart.
- 6 Saul prayed to GOD, but GOD didn't answer--neither by dream nor by sign nor by prophet.
- 6 He inquired of the LORD, but the LORD did not answer him by dreams or Urim or prophets.
- 7 So Saul ordered his officials, "Find me someone who can call up spirits so I may go and seek counsel from those spirits." His servants said, "There's a witch at Endor."
- 7 Saul then said to his attendants, "Find me a woman who is a medium, so I may go and inquire of her." "There is one in Endor," they said.
- 8 Saul disguised himself by putting on different clothes. Then, taking two men with him, he went under the cover of night to the woman and said, "I want you to consult a ghost for me. Call up the person I name."
- 8 So Saul disguised himself, putting on other clothes, and at night he and two men went to the woman. "Consult a spirit for me," he said, "and bring up for me the one I name."
- 9 The woman said, "Just hold on now! You know what Saul did, how he swept the country clean of mediums. Why are you trying to trap me and get me killed?"
- 9 But the woman said to him, "Surely you know what Saul has done. He has cut off the mediums and spiritists from the land. Why have you set a trap for my life to bring about my death?"
- 10 Saul swore solemnly, "As GOD lives, you won't get in any trouble for this."
- 10 Saul swore to her by the LORD, "As surely as the LORD lives, you will not be punished for this."
- 11 The woman said, "So whom do you want me to bring up?" "Samuel. Bring me Samuel."
- 11 Then the woman asked, "Whom shall I bring up for you?" "Bring up Samuel," he said.
- 12 When the woman saw Samuel, she cried out loudly to Saul, "Why did you lie to me? You're Saul!"
- 12 When the woman saw Samuel, she cried out at the top of her voice and said to Saul, "Why have you deceived me? You are Saul!"

- 13 The king told her, "You have nothing to fear . . . but what do you see?"
"I see a spirit ascending from the underground."
- 13 The king said to her, "Don't be afraid. What do you see?" The woman said, "I see a spirit coming up out of the ground."
- 14 "And what does he look like?" Saul asked. "An old man ascending, robed like a priest." Saul knew it was Samuel. He fell down, face to the ground, and worshiped.
- 14 What does he look like? he asked. "An old man wearing a robe is coming up," she said. Then Saul knew it was Samuel, and he bowed down and prostrated himself with his face to the ground.
- 15 Samuel said to Saul, "Why have you disturbed me by calling me up?"
"Because I'm in deep trouble," said Saul. "The Philistines are making war against me and God has deserted me--he doesn't answer me any more, either by prophet or by dream. And so I'm calling on you to tell me what to do."
- 15 Samuel said to Saul, "Why have you disturbed me by bringing me up?"
"I am in great distress," Saul said. "The Philistines are fighting against me, and God has turned away from me. He no longer answers me, either by prophets or by dreams. So I have called on you to tell me what to do."
- 16 "Why ask me?" said Samuel. "GOD has turned away from you and is now on the side of your neighbor.
- 16 Samuel said, "Why do you consult me, now that the LORD has turned away from you and become your enemy?
- 17 GOD has done exactly what he told you through me--ripped the kingdom right out of your hands and given it to your neighbor.
- 17 The LORD has done what he predicted through me. The LORD has torn the kingdom out of your hands and given it to one of your neighbors--to David.
- 18 It's because you did not obey GOD, refused to carry out his seething judgment on Amalek, that GOD does to you what he is doing today.
- 18 Because you did not obey the LORD or carry out his fierce wrath against the Amalekites, the LORD has done this to you today.
- 19 Worse yet, GOD is turning Israel, along with you, over to the Philistines. Tomorrow you and your sons will be with me. And, yes, indeed, GOD is giving Israel's army up to the Philistines."

- 19 The LORD will hand over both Israel and you to the Philistines, and tomorrow you and your sons will be with me. The LORD will also hand over the army of Israel to the Philistines."
- 20 Saul dropped to the ground, felled like a tree, terrified by Samuel's words. There wasn't an ounce of strength left in him--he'd eaten nothing all day and all night.
- 20 Immediately Saul fell full length on the ground, filled with fear because of Samuel's words. His strength was gone, for he had eaten nothing all that day and night.
- 21 The woman, realizing that he was in deep shock, said to him, "Listen to me. I did what you asked me to do, put my life in your hands in doing it, carried out your instructions to the letter.
- 21 When the woman came to Saul and saw that he was greatly shaken, she said, "Look, your maidservant has obeyed you. I took my life in my hands and did what you told me to do.
- 22 It's your turn to do what I tell you: Let me give you some food. Eat it. It will give you strength so you can get on your way."
- 22 Now please listen to your servant and let me give you some food so you may eat and have the strength to go on your way."
- 23 He refused. "I'm not eating anything." But when his servants joined the woman in urging him, he gave in to their pleas, picked himself up off the ground, and sat on the bed.
- 23 He refused and said, "I will not eat." But his men joined the woman in urging him, and he listened to them. He got up from the ground and sat on the couch.
- 24 The woman moved swiftly. She butchered a grain-fed calf she had, and took some flour, kneaded it, and baked some flat bread.
- 24 The woman had a fattened calf at the house, which she butchered at once. She took some flour, kneaded it and baked bread without yeast.
- 25 Then she served it all up for Saul and his servants. After dining handsomely, they got up from the table and were on their way that same night.
- 25 Then she set it before Saul and his men, and they ate. That same night they got up and left.

1 Samuel 29

MSG

NIV

- 1 The Philistines mustered all their troops at Aphek. Meanwhile Israel had made camp at the spring at Jezreel.
- 1 The Philistines gathered all their forces at Aphek, and Israel camped by the spring in Jezreel.
- 2 As the Philistine warlords marched forward by regiments and divisions, David and his men were bringing up the rear with Achish.
- 2 As the Philistine rulers marched with their units of hundreds and thousands, David and his men were marching at the rear with Achish.
- 3 The Philistine officers said, "What business do these Hebrews have being here?" Achish answered the officers, "Don't you recognize David, ex-servant of King Saul of Israel? He's been with me a long time. I've found nothing to be suspicious of, nothing to complain about, from the day he defected from Saul until now."
- 3 The commanders of the Philistines asked, "What about these Hebrews?" Achish replied, "Is this not David, who was an officer of Saul king of Israel? He has already been with me for over a year, and from the day he left Saul until now, I have found no fault in him."
- 4 Angry with Achish, the Philistine officers said, "Send this man back to where he came from. Let him stick to his normal duties. He's not going into battle with us. He'd switch sides in the middle of the fight! What better chance to get back in favor with his master than by stabbing us in the back!
- 4 But the Philistine commanders were angry with him and said, "Send the man back, that he may return to the place you assigned him. He must not go with us into battle, or he will turn against us during the fighting. How better could he regain his master's favor than by taking the heads of our own men?
- 5 Isn't this the same David they celebrate at their parties, singing, Saul kills by the thousand, David by the ten thousand!"
- 5 Isn't this the David they sang about in their dances: " 'Saul has slain his thousands, and David his tens of thousands'?"

- 6 So Achish had to send for David and tell him, "As GOD lives, you've been a trusty ally--excellent in all the ways you have worked with me, beyond reproach in the ways you have conducted yourself. But the warlords don't see it that way.
- 6 So Achish called David and said to him, "As surely as the LORD lives, you have been reliable, and I would be pleased to have you serve with me in the army. From the day you came to me until now, I have found no fault in you, but the rulers don't approve of you.
- 7 So it's best that you leave peacefully, now. It's not worth it, displeasing the Philistine warlords."
- 7 Turn back and go in peace; do nothing to displease the Philistine rulers."
- 8 "But what have I done?" said David. "Have you had a single cause for complaint from the day I joined up with you until now? Why can't I fight against the enemies of my master the king?"
- 8 But what have I done? asked David. "What have you found against your servant from the day I came to you until now? Why can't I go and fight against the enemies of my lord the king?"
- 9 "I agree," said Achish. "You're a good man--as far as I'm concerned, God's angel! But the Philistine officers were emphatic: 'He's not to go with us into battle.'
- 9 Achish answered, "I know that you have been as pleasing in my eyes as an angel of God; nevertheless, the Philistine commanders have said, 'He must not go up with us into battle.'
- 10 So get an early start, you and the men who came with you. As soon as you have light enough to travel, go."
- 10 Now get up early, along with your master's servants who have come with you, and leave in the morning as soon as it is light."
- 11 David rose early, he and his men, and by daybreak they were on their way back to Philistine country. The Philistines went on to Jezreel.
- 11 So David and his men got up early in the morning to go back to the land of the Philistines, and the Philistines went up to Jezreel.

1 Samuel 30

MSG

NIV

- 1 Three days later, David and his men arrived back in Ziklag. Amalekites had raided the Negev and Ziklag. They tore Ziklag to pieces and then burned it down.
- 1 David and his men reached Ziklag on the third day. Now the Amalekites had raided the Negev and Ziklag. They had attacked Ziklag and burned it,
- 2 They captured all the women, young and old. They didn't kill anyone, but drove them like a herd of cattle.
- 2 and had taken captive the women and all who were in it, both young and old. They killed none of them, but carried them off as they went on their way.
- 3 By the time David and his men entered the village, it had been burned to the ground, and their wives, sons, and daughters all taken prisoner.
- 3 When David and his men came to Ziklag, they found it destroyed by fire and their wives and sons and daughters taken captive.
- 4 David and his men burst out in loud wails--wept and wept until they were exhausted with weeping.
- 4 So David and his men wept aloud until they had no strength left to weep.
- 5 David's two wives, Ahinoam of Jezreel and Abigail widow of Nabal of Carmel, had been taken prisoner along with the rest.
- 5 David's two wives had been captured--Ahinoam of Jezreel and Abigail, the widow of Nabal of Carmel.
- 6 And suddenly David was in even worse trouble. There was talk among the men, bitter over the loss of their families, of stoning him. David strengthened himself with trust in his GOD.
- 6 David was greatly distressed because the men were talking of stoning him; each one was bitter in spirit because of his sons and daughters. But David found strength in the LORD his God.
- 7 He ordered Abiathar the priest, son of Ahimelech, "Bring me the Ephod so I can consult God." Abiathar brought it to David.
- 7 Then David said to Abiathar the priest, the son of Ahimelech, "Bring me the ephod." Abiathar brought it to him,
- 8 Then David prayed to GOD, "Shall I go after these raiders? Can I catch them?" The answer came, "Go after them! Yes, you'll catch them! Yes, you'll make the rescue!"

- 8 and David inquired of the LORD, "Shall I pursue this raiding party? Will I overtake them?" "Pursue them," he answered. "You will certainly overtake them and succeed in the rescue."
- 9 David went, he and the six hundred men with him. They arrived at the Brook Besor, where some of them dropped out.
- 9 David and the six hundred men with him came to the Besor Ravine, where some stayed behind,
- 10 David and four hundred men kept up the pursuit, but two hundred of them were too fatigued to cross the Brook Besor, and stayed there.
- 10 for two hundred men were too exhausted to cross the ravine. But David and four hundred men continued the pursuit.
- 11 Some who went on came across an Egyptian in a field and took him to David. They gave him bread and he ate. And he drank some water.
- 11 They found an Egyptian in a field and brought him to David. They gave him water to drink and food to eat--
- 12 They gave him a piece of fig cake and a couple of raisin muffins. Life began to revive in him. He hadn't eaten or drunk a thing for three days and nights!
- 12 part of a cake of pressed figs and two cakes of raisins. He ate and was revived, for he had not eaten any food or drunk any water for three days and three nights.
- 13 David said to him, "Who do you belong to? Where are you from?" "I'm an Egyptian slave of an Amalekite," he said. "My master walked off and left me when I got sick--that was three days ago.
- 13 David asked him, "To whom do you belong, and where do you come from?" He said, "I am an Egyptian, the slave of an Amalekite. My master abandoned me when I became ill three days ago.
- 14 We had raided the Negev of the Kerethites, of Judah, and of Caleb. Ziklag we burned."
- 14 We raided the Negev of the Kerethites and the territory belonging to Judah and the Negev of Caleb. And we burned Ziklag."
- 15 David asked him, "Can you take us to the raiders?" "Promise me by God," he said, "that you won't kill me or turn me over to my old master, and I'll take you straight to the raiders."
- 15 David asked him, "Can you lead me down to this raiding party?" He answered, "Swear to me before God that you will not kill me or hand me

- over to my master, and I will take you down to them."
- 16 He led David to them. They were scattered all over the place, eating and drinking, gorging themselves on all the loot they had plundered from Philistia and Judah.
- 16 He led David down, and there they were, scattered over the countryside, eating, drinking and reveling because of the great amount of plunder they had taken from the land of the Philistines and from Judah.
- 17 David pounced. He fought them from before sunrise until evening of the next day. None got away except for four hundred of the younger men who escaped by riding off on camels.
- 17 David fought them from dusk until the evening of the next day, and none of them got away, except four hundred young men who rode off on camels and fled.
- 18 David rescued everything the Amalekites had taken. And he rescued his two wives!
- 18 David recovered everything the Amalekites had taken, including his two wives.
- 19 Nothing and no one was missing--young or old, son or daughter, plunder or whatever. David recovered the whole lot.
- 19 Nothing was missing: young or old, boy or girl, plunder or anything else they had taken. David brought everything back.
- 20 He herded the sheep and cattle before them, and they all shouted, "David's plunder!"
- 20 He took all the flocks and herds, and his men drove them ahead of the other livestock, saying, "This is David's plunder."
- 21 Then David came to the two hundred who had been too tired to continue with him and had dropped out at the Brook Besor. They came out to welcome David and his band. As he came near he called out, "Success!"
- 21 Then David came to the two hundred men who had been too exhausted to follow him and who were left behind at the Besor Ravine. They came out to meet David and the people with him. As David and his men approached, he greeted them.
- 22 But all the mean-spirited men who had marched with David, the rabble element, objected: "They didn't help in the rescue, they don't get any of the plunder we recovered. Each man can have his wife and children, but that's it. Take them and go!"

- 22 But all the evil men and troublemakers among David's followers said, "Because they did not go out with us, we will not share with them the plunder we recovered. However, each man may take his wife and children and go."
- 23 "Families don't do this sort of thing! Oh no, my brothers!" said David as he broke up the argument. "You can't act this way with what GOD gave us! God kept us safe. He handed over the raiders who attacked us."
- 23 David replied, "No, my brothers, you must not do that with what the LORD has given us. He has protected us and handed over to us the forces that came against us."
- 24 Who would ever listen to this kind of talk? The share of the one who stays with the gear is the share of the one who fights--equal shares. Share and share alike!"
- 24 Who will listen to what you say? The share of the man who stayed with the supplies is to be the same as that of him who went down to the battle. All will share alike."
- 25 From that day on, David made that the rule in Israel--and it still is.
- 25 David made this a statute and ordinance for Israel from that day to this.
- 26 On returning to Ziklag, David sent portions of the plunder to the elders of Judah, his neighbors, with a note saying, "A gift from the plunder of GOD's enemies!"
- 26 When David arrived in Ziklag, he sent some of the plunder to the elders of Judah, who were his friends, saying, "Here is a present for you from the plunder of the LORD's enemies."
- 27 He sent them to the elders in Bethel, Ramoth Negev, Jattir,
- 27 He sent it to those who were in Bethel, Ramoth Negev and Jattir;
- 28 Aroer, Siphmoth, Eshtemoa,
- 28 to those in Aroer, Siphmoth, Eshtemoa
- 29 Racal, Jerahmeelite cities, Kenite cities,
- 29 and Racal; to those in the towns of the Jerahmeelites and the Kenites;
- 30 Hormah, Bor Ashan, Athach,
- 30 to those in Hormah, Bor Ashan, Athach
- 31 and Hebron, along with a number of other places David and his men went to from time to time.
- 31 and Hebron; and to those in all the other places where David and his men had roamed.

1 Samuel 31

MSG

NIV

- 1 The Philistines made war on Israel. The men of Israel were in full retreat from the Philistines, falling left and right, wounded on Mount Gilboa.
- 1 Now the Philistines fought against Israel; the Israelites fled before them, and many fell slain on Mount Gilboa.
- 2 The Philistines caught up with Saul and his sons. They killed Jonathan, Abinadab, and Malki-Shua, Saul's sons.
- 2 The Philistines pressed hard after Saul and his sons, and they killed his sons Jonathan, Abinadab and Malki-Shua.
- 3 The battle was hot and heavy around Saul. The archers got his range and wounded him badly.
- 3 The fighting grew fierce around Saul, and when the archers overtook him, they wounded him critically.
- 4 Saul said to his weapon bearer, "Draw your sword and put me out of my misery, lest these pagan pigs come and make a game out of killing me." But his weapon bearer wouldn't do it. He was terrified. So Saul took the sword himself and fell on it.
- 4 Saul said to his armor-bearer, "Draw your sword and run me through, or these uncircumcised fellows will come and run me through and abuse me." But his armor-bearer was terrified and would not do it; so Saul took his own sword and fell on it.
- 5 When the weapon bearer saw that Saul was dead, he too fell on his sword and died with him.
- 5 When the armor-bearer saw that Saul was dead, he too fell on his sword and died with him.
- 6 So Saul, his three sons, and his weapon bearer--the men closest to him--died together that day.
- 6 So Saul and his three sons and his armor-bearer and all his men died together that same day.
- 7 When the Israelites in the valley opposite and those on the other side of the Jordan saw that their army was in full retreat and that Saul and his sons were dead, they left their cities and ran for their lives. The Philistines moved in and occupied the sites.

- 7 When the Israelites along the valley and those across the Jordan saw that the Israelite army had fled and that Saul and his sons had died, they abandoned their towns and fled. And the Philistines came and occupied them.
- 8 The next day, when the Philistines came to rob the dead, they found Saul and his three sons dead on Mount Gilboa.
- 8 The next day, when the Philistines came to strip the dead, they found Saul and his three sons fallen on Mount Gilboa.
- 9 They cut off Saul's head and stripped off his armor. Then they spread the good news all through Philistine country in the shrines of their idols and among the people.
- 9 They cut off his head and stripped off his armor, and they sent messengers throughout the land of the Philistines to proclaim the news in the temple of their idols and among their people.
- 10 They displayed his armor in the shrine of the Ashtoreth. They nailed his corpse to the wall at Beth Shan.
- 10 They put his armor in the temple of the Ashtoreths and fastened his body to the wall of Beth Shan.
- 11 The people of Jabesh Gilead heard what the Philistines had done to Saul.
- 11 When the people of Jabesh Gilead heard of what the Philistines had done to Saul,
- 12 Their valiant men sprang into action. They traveled all night, took the corpses of Saul and his three sons from the wall at Beth Shan, and carried them back to Jabesh and burned off the flesh.
- 12 all their valiant men journeyed through the night to Beth Shan. They took down the bodies of Saul and his sons from the wall of Beth Shan and went to Jabesh, where they burned them.
- 13 They then buried the bones under the tamarisk tree in Jabesh and fasted in mourning for seven days.
- 13 Then they took their bones and buried them under a tamarisk tree at Jabesh, and they fasted seven days.